

The Narrative Campaign Field Guide

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Executive Summary

With COVID-19 herd immunity moving from future concept to near-term necessity in many nations and the looming risk of a continued global trend of riots, extremism, and breakdowns in institutional trust, many organizations will be proposing and implementing initiatives to impact narratives and their resulting attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions. These initiatives, or “Narrative Campaigns”, offer opportunities to help rebuild trust, reduce polarization, and restrict the flow of misinformation—however, they also have the potential to be counterproductive if certain methods and practices are applied under the wrong conditions and the resulting negative impacts can be difficult to observe and remedy.

There is a meaningful interconnectedness between the issues these initiatives seek to address—for example, the negative impacts of counterproductive efforts to affect narratives related to COVID-19 vaccination will not be limited to vaccination or to the organizations responsible for the initiative. Furthermore, these Narrative Campaigns will not take place in a vacuum and will have to consider both state and non-state actors which intentionally or unintentionally disrupt the information environment, amplify or place misinformation, and run adversarial initiatives. This Field Guide is intended to help strategists design Narrative Campaigns, increase their efficacy, and reduce their cost, development time, and potential for blowback. To this end, the Guide also provides frameworks that increase observability of narrative and the campaign’s impacts, helping to avoid over-reliance on response data and data sources traditionally used in this space which may become increasingly illusory or difficult to attain.

Contributors

Richard J. Cordes is a co-founder of COGSEC and a Non-Resident Fellow at the Atlantic Council on appointment to the GeoTech Center. He has contributed research to a variety of working groups and committees across Department of Defense programs, the IEEE, and the Private Sector, and has authored, coauthored, and edited books on topics such as gray zone warfare, knowledge management and education technology, optimization of human learning, social systems engineering, remote team performance, and complex systems. He is especially interested in unifying concepts within narrative design, intelligence analysis, science and scholarship, behavioral engineering, and pedagogy under the domains of sensemaking and knowledge management.

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Dr. Ajit Maan is a narrative strategist focused on the non-kinetic aspects of national defense and global security. She is the founder and CEO of the award-winning think-and-do tank, Narrative Strategies, LLC. She is a Professor of Practice in the Master's Program in Politics and Global Security at Arizona State University, Faculty at the Center for the Future of War, and member of the Brain Trust of the Weaponized Narrative Initiative also at Arizona State University. Dr. Maan writes a column "Narrative and National Security" for Homeland Security Today and is the author of seven books including Counter-Terrorism: Narrative Strategies, Narrative Warfare, Plato's Fear, and is Editor of Soft Power on Hard Problems: Strategic Influence in Irregular Warfare and Dangerous Narratives: Warfare, Strategy and Statecraft.

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Eric Sapp serves as the President of the certified B Corp. Public Democracy, a data creation and human insight company that uses empathy-driven machine learning and moment-based engagement in pursuit of its mission to “align what is right with what works”. Eric directed Public Democracy’s nationally recognized campaigns supporting veterans with severe PTSD, inclusive clinical recruiting, economic empowerment, voter protection and mobilization, and COVID awareness and tracking. Eric has worked with over 40 US Congressional campaigns and guided communications campaigns associated with arms and nuclear treaties, peace talks, poverty and hunger, pollution control, and security, all focusing on authentic and effective ways to connect with voters through shared values. Eric holds a Master of Divinity and Master of Public Policy from Davidson College and Duke University, respectively.

Pat Scannell is among the world’s most experienced technology strategists. He is regularly invited to speak at academic, industry, defense, and other forums and has 3 forthcoming books on the topic of technological impacts on cognition. He has deep subject matter expertise in the commercialization of emerging technologies, and his work in this space has included the development of go-to-market analysis and guiding the implementation of some of the world’s most sophisticated technologies and platforms backed by venture capital, DARPA, and some of the world’s largest companies. Pat currently sits on the board of advisors to several NGOs and is currently working on 5G infrastructure. He has served as a leader or advisor on, and built and led strategies related to, scores of industry initiatives regarding 5G/mobile, big-data, internet of things (IoT), connected cars, smart grids, defense and homeland security, and artificial intelligence. He has worked with and for the US Government, nearly all US wireless operators, the US cable industry, and a major 5G infrastructure OEM.

Sahil Shah is a co-founder and director of Sustainable Seaweed, an agri-tech company scaling seaweed production for food security and blue carbon sinks. He is also an Honorary Fellow at the Jahn Research Group at the University of Madison-Wisconsin and a specialist advisor at US food security nonprofit, the Alliance to Feed the Earth in Disasters (ALLFED). He sits on the Chatham House Food and Land Use round table, and has been a Fellow and Action Council Member at the Atlantic Council. He co-founded an open-source project, the Food Systems Handbook, collating, curating and summarizing highly effective food security interventions for policy makers. Mr. Shah previously advised the think tank Let’s Fund, co-founded the technology startup Sujester, and served as a strategy and management consultant with Accenture and Legal & General Investment Management. Sahil holds an MA in Economics with Management from the University of Cambridge and Judge Business School.

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1. Introduction

With ongoing economic crises, escalation in tension between near-peer nations, and climate change, there has been no shortage of existential threats to Western nations. In 2020, the COVID-19 pandemic was added to this pile, revealing and exacerbating strains on global economies and logistics systems as well as the mental health of affected populations. As diverse as these threats are, attempts at resolving them face a common obstacle in the form of a global trend of civil unrest, an increasingly polarized and hostile public discourse, a rapid breakdown in institutional trust, and the spread of extremist ideologies—all facilitated and accelerated by digital affordances. Military doctrine had already begun to reflect the need for an influence component to accompany every operation to reduce the impacts of adversarial influence operations which take advantage of polarization and mistrust, and responses to COVID-19 have revealed a similar need for operations as simple as asking the public to wear masks. Every response and every issue, no matter how benign, now runs the risk of being politicized both by actors intent on sowing discord and by well-meaning, engaged citizens alike.

Given the shift in perception of COVID-19 herd immunity from future concept to near-term necessity and the looming risk of a continued global trend of riots, extremism, and breakdowns in institutional trust, many organizations have begun to propose and implement initiatives to impact sensemaking and narratives within target audiences. These initiatives draw their methodology from a diverse set of fields, including communications and advertising, influence operations, logistics, and user experience design (UX). For this Guide, we are defining all these efforts to influence narrative and resulting attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions, as “Narrative Campaigns”.

Narrative Campaigns offer opportunities to help rebuild trust, reduce polarization, restrict the flow of misinformation, and increase the likelihood of success of the initiatives they’re meant to accompany but come with their own set of challenges and risks. While cost and time-to-deployment are common concerns to strategists, the application of these campaigns also carries the risk of counterproductive effort and potential for blowback. Certain methods and practices, applied at the wrong time or under the wrong conditions, can result in unintended consequences and negative impact which can be difficult to predict, observe, measure, and remedy. The information environment is complex, and there are meaningful interconnections between issues which sit both inside and outside the scope of a campaign. This being the case, the negative impacts of a campaign will not be limited to the issues it sought to address or to the organizations responsible for the campaign. Adding to this complexity, Narrative Campaigns have to account for the broader informational context. Other state and non-state actors will intentionally and unintentionally disrupt the information environment, amplify or place mis- and dis-information, and run adversarial initiatives. Narrative campaigns will neither exist in a vacuum nor be able to count on a static informational environment throughout.

Narrative Campaigns are not new, but the digital affordances provided to the campaign, its adversaries, and the audiences they target have changed the area of operations. As a consequence, campaigns will have to become less linear and more modular in their implementation, so they can be updated iteratively in response to new developments. It is essential that organizations intending to plan and deploy Narrative Campaigns have a strong understanding of the narratives they intend to impact and that they are aware of the practices and tools available to them. Equally important is awareness of the nuances which accompany these practices: where they are most effective, what they can achieve, and when they may be ineffective, counterproductive, or harmful.

This Field Guide is intended to help design Narrative Campaigns, increase their efficacy, and reduce their cost, development time, and potential for blowback or poor performance in their deployment.

1.1. Organization of the Field Guide

This Field Guide is organized into the following sections:

Definitions. Given the variety of methodologies and fields that Narrative Campaigns can draw from, this section is meant to provide a top-level overview of some of the key concepts that readers from different fields might be unfamiliar with and anchor the way we will use these terms in this Guide.

Narrative Analysis. Narrative is difficult to observe and often misunderstood. A primer on the topic with perspectives from recent literature is provided, followed by frameworks which help campaign planners model the narratives of their target audience.

Adversarial Campaigns. Campaign strategists have to acknowledge that they are not alone. This section helps the campaign planner get a lay of the land regarding the types of both well-meaning and hostile actors and how they might negatively impact campaign outcomes.

Campaign Planning Tools. Campaigns can often be difficult to scope and can easily be exposed to mission creep or drift. This section provides some easy-to-implement tools for setting goals and planning campaigns.

Practices Catalog. A catalog of summarized campaign practices with relevant considerations, caveats, and guidance for implementation and use as well as identification of their use by other campaigns.

Case Studies. Finally, a variety of informative case studies of past Narrative Campaigns and related phenomena are provided to illuminate both the positive and negative impacts of successful and failed initiatives alike.

Given recent events in the United States and the current pandemic, all sections provide special consideration for campaigns which address extremist ideology and vaccine hesitancy.

1.2. Disclaimer

We are entering a new era and there is a great deal of justified and reasonable conflict regarding the ethics of various deployments, implementations, and methodologies related to narrative campaigns, whether the source be advertisers, nonprofits, or state actors. With this in mind, all practices and considerations within this document were approached with an intent to remain neutral, as each of them can be used for both noble and nefarious purpose alike. And what is considered noble intent by one group might be considered nefarious by another, and use that begins with the right motives might, if unchecked, become nefarious.

Nevertheless, although any of the tools in this guide could be used for good or ill, that does not mean all are equally suited for both purposes. A rifle and spade can both be used to kill or to dig, but each is better suited to one task and more likely to be used for that purpose. While we attempted to remain neutral in addressing these practices, it is our hope that the Guide helps readers identify which tools and practices might undermine democratic institutions and which provide nudges while generally supporting open societies and informed decision-making. This will both inform better use and selection of those tools as well as support readers' ability to identify these practices "in the wild" while navigating the information environment themselves.

Recommendations regarding the use of practices discussed in this document should be treated as conditional on their use—not as synonymous with a recommendation of the use of the practice itself. The reader should take careful note to consider the ethics of implementation of any practice carefully, and always ask the conscience, "what if I were the target". Along those lines, this Field Guide is intended to be more than a collection of tactics to improve campaign outcomes—by offering practices and tools that help readers better understand narrative and the tools used by adversarial campaigns, it may also help both campaign strategists and general readers alike empathize and avoid dismissive judgement of attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions they see and be less likely to contribute to polarization.

Remember that this is a field guide, not a playbook. **We are all learning together.** The writing of this Field Guide was an exploratory task: we've had to name emergent practices yet to be named or choose a single name where practices and methods were shared across many disciplines. We encourage the reader to seek out where information is lacking, misleading, in need of nuance and additional context, or in need of additional perspectives and reach out to us at the contact information included at the end of this document. This document is the release of what is intended to be one of many versions. The current version leans heavily on U.S. perspectives, but in future versions we hope to include more international collaborators in order to develop an increasingly global perspective.

2. Definitions

Adversarial Campaign. Narrative Campaigns being run by other organizations that may intentionally or unintentionally impact the efficacy of the subject campaign.

Advertisement. Marketing communication in which a commercial, political, or social message is delivered by buying space and time on media and which is based on creating a desired change in target audience's thoughts, attitudes or behaviors.

Agenda Setting. The act of defining what it is will be spoken as opposed to defining what it is that will be said. Research in the 1980s and 90s indicated that media had less power than expected in defining what people thought about topics—instead the power they held was in defining what topics people thought about, referred to as "defining the agenda" or "agenda-setting".

Center of Gravity. Defined as the point from which a body or system may be considered to act. While this term is often used in areas such as martial arts and gymnastics to refer to physical centers of gravity, "centers of gravity" has been generalized for use in the description of systems since Carl Von Clausewitz's use of the term to describe socio-political systems and battlefields. While their meaning in certain contexts can be unclear, they can generally be described as the elements within some system around which other elements dictate behavior. For example, a communications hub in a socio-technical system or a defensible hill on a battlefield.

Cognitive Security. Cognitive Security (COGSEC) refers to practices, methodologies, and efforts made to defend against social engineering attempts intentional and unintentional manipulations of and disruptions to cognition and sensemaking. Cognitive Security, in cybersecurity contexts however, usually refers to the application of AI and Machine learning technologies which are modeled on human cognition to the detection of security threats in this respect, the two definitions are intertwined, as research which informs the practices and methodologies of the first definition inform the models used in the second.

Complexity Science. Complexity Science is a field which uses transdisciplinary approaches for the study and design of systems which have interacting subcomponents and fundamental uncertainty. For context, a computer is a complicated system, whereas ecosystems and weather are complex.

Copypasta. Long blocks of text meant to be copy and pasted or screenshotted and shared on social media. They are often detail-laden and make an argument regarding a topic.

Cultural Landscape. A term from social sciences literature referring to clusters of sociocultural traits and characteristics.

Disinformation. The spread or classification of information which is intentionally deceptive or misleading.

Gray Zone Warfare. All forms of warfare which occur outside the context of a written declaration or formal action, including but not limited to: covert lethal action, the hiring of contractors, information and psychological operations, and cyber warfare.

Human Terrain Specialist (HTS). Individuals who are native to and/or have a strong understanding of a cultural landscape of interest to a campaign.

Human Terrain Team (HTT). Teams composed of social sciences researchers or anthropologists and individuals who are native to and/or have a strong understanding of the “Cultural Landscape” of interest. The idea is to combine academic theory and frameworks with the cultural knowledge of the local specialists in order to collect data and generate briefs which capture the local cultural knowledge but express relevant details in a way that an outsider can understand and integrate into operations.

Influence Operation. Narrative Campaigns with military and intelligence connotations and which may include the employment of military capabilities.

Information Warfare. Information Warfare is characterized by the taking of actions which deny, exploit, corrupt, or otherwise damage enemy or enemy adjacent information and information systems.

Kinetic and Nonkinetic Conflict. Kinetic Conflict refers to military actions involving "active" or lethal force, used to differentiate lethal unconventional and general gray-zone warfare from non-lethal.

Meme. A Meme is a granular concept, idea, or pattern of behavior or expression that can be spread person to person. In common usage, the term is applied to the content which communicates memes, such as images with captions, GIFs, or cypasta.

Memetic Warfare. A form of Information Warfare specifically focused on mechanisms for encouraging or enabling network-spread of propaganda or hyperpartisan content.

Messaging/Messages. Messages refer to deployable content, such as video, text, images, audio-files, and abstract content such as slogans, logos, and sound-bites.

Misinformation. The spread or the classification of deceptive or misleading information, but generally without strategic intent or knowledge of it being deceptive or misleading.

Narrative. Narrative is a complex, multi-layer representation of an individual’s moral and cultural model of the world that helps the brain rapidly compress, filter, and extract meaning from external information and take action in ways that perpetuate a consistent view of both world and self. Significant portions of this representation are contextual, unconscious, emotional, or are otherwise independent of language and rationale, but it is communicated and given form through expressions such as art, stories, and rituals.

Narrative Campaign. Any chain of coordinated and strategic actions intended to influence narrative and resulting attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions.

Narrative Warfare. A form of Information Warfare specifically intended to influence narratives in order to create systemic instability within nations or organizations.

NGO. Acronym for non-governmental organization, usually non-profits and citizen organizations, associations, and clubs.

Nudge(s). Strategic actions based on behavioral and political theory that focus on positive reinforcement, indirect suggestions, and additive information intended to influence decision making and behavior. Nudge theory seeks to encourage and empower marginal movement along a continuum rather than pursue a more binary course of correcting behavior or changing attitudes.

Operations Security (OPSEC). Operations Security (OPSEC) is the process of identifying, and preventing exploitation of, information and information-systems vulnerabilities.

OSINT. OSINT is an acronym for "Open Source Intelligence", which refers to the collection of methods used to collect and analyze information from public sources such as online content, public directories, and unclassified or leaked material.

Propaganda. A strategic effort or artifact intended to shape opinion toward a political or ideological goal by controlling information flow and access so that an audience develops an incomplete picture of reality. Propaganda is generally created by those with power and/or influence, and can include deceptive information but generally uses curated facts in misleading contexts.

Psychological Operations (PSYOPs). Psychological Operations (PSYOPs) is defined as the deployment of information to influence foreign target audiences in support of military objectives.

Storifying/Storification. The composition of a story from real or fictitious sources in order to create change through the channeling of empathy, values, symbols, and resentments.

Story. A story can refer to any set of information units that can be presented consecutively in order to communicate and fit narrative within a context.

Threat Actor. An individual or organization whose behavior or intents represents a threat to a system or network.

3. Narrative Analysis

We have to reckon with the fact that influencing attitudinal change or fighting disinformation is not actually about conflict over information—it is about conflict over the meaning of information. While there are many definitions for “Narrative”, research on narrative analysis has sought to distinguish narrative from the expressions of narrative or the vehicles which propagate it to avoid confusing the message with the meaning it is meant to communicate. Thus, narrative is the lens through which individuals process and understand their world and self, and stories are tools used to fit narrative into specific contexts and applications. A narrative campaign will use stories and other context to connect with (and potentially shift) the individual narratives within a target audience.

Without this distinction between narrative and its expressions, we will inevitably struggle with the inefficacy of fact checking or the limited changes in opinion in response to new information. It is difficult to shake this linear communications model that many of us were taught. The underlying assumption of the linear model—that the goal of effective communication is to get a message securely from sender to receiver, uncompromised and undistorted, has had a lasting and detrimental effect on our ability to influence a target audience.

The most glaring problem with the linear communication model is that it treats the target audience as passive receptors of information—as though the eyes and ears are portals through which information can be dumped into the brain. This misguided linear model has much to do with failed efforts across multiple domains as many strategic communications professionals are still operating within it. Many communicators begin by asking what it is they want to say or that their audience “needs” to hear, rather than the all-important question of what the audience is able to hear and see as plausible. This is one of the many reasons we need to get clear about what narratives are and how they operate.

Rather than asking what our audience needs to hear, we need to ask what our audience is able to hear.

Narrative is a complex, multi-layer representation of an individual’s moral and cultural model of the world that sits in the nexus between physiology and deeply encoded symbolic memory. It is dynamically constructed and esoterically communicated through socio-cultural interactions, such as stories, rituals, and art, and intermediated by technology, physiology, risk, and incentives. Significant portions of this representation are contextual, unconscious, emotional, or are otherwise independent of language and

rationale. Narrative helps the brain to rapidly compress, filter, and extract meaning from external information and take actions in order to maintain a consistent view of both the outside world and the self. We do not “see” reality, we “see” a model that our brains generate. What the visual cortex does for our visual model of the world, adjusting, filtering, or emphasizing inputs and filling in blind spots to keep it consistent with expectations, narrative does for our moral and cultural models of the world.

While this description of narrative makes it seem like an obstacle in reasoning, it is important to recognize that these functions help us navigate complex environments. Narrative itself is not “good” or “bad”, just as bias itself is not “good” or “bad”. For example, a technical expert’s narrative of their profession and their place within it as well as their work experience will create biases and expectations that enable them to work rapidly, communicate effectively, and adhere to standards and protocols we might associate with logical thought—but these same biases and expectations may cause them to miss anomalies. Research on active inference, sensemaking, and on the intersection of knowledge, memory, and narrative has improved our understanding of both the potential utility and negative impacts of narrative by developing frameworks that see narrative as informing the generation and maintenance of behavioral “scripts” which reduce uncertainty about the environment and the actions one should take to navigate it successfully. Most importantly, this research has helped to recontextualize decades of research on memory, morality, bias, and ethics to provide clarity in understanding why it is that narrative is so difficult to express, observe, and disrupt.

Active Inference?

Active Inference is a framework that draws upon cybernetics, neuroscience, and physics to model the activity of goal-directed agents in uncertain and changing environments. Active Inference has been applied to the behavior of systems across scales, for example learning behavior in humans or foraging activity of ant colonies. In Active Inference, system behavior embodies statistical regularities in its physical, informational, and narrative niche and enacts policy based upon a process known as Bayesian Updating. System behavior of active inference agents is cast in terms of reducing uncertainty and optimal experimentation, rather than maximal reward.

Once cultural narratives are internalized, they are like meaning maps in our heads—they become the lens through which we understand our world and process information. The less cultural and subcultural narratives we share with the target audience, the more the campaigns and initiatives we design will underperform or worse, backfire. Not acknowledging this principle, has not only led to failures in communications campaigns, but also in domains such as intelligence analysis and human studies research. If we want to reduce uncertainty and potential for negative externalities in the campaigns we produce and to increase the likelihood that the target audience processes the content and stories we deploy in the way we want them to, then we need to get very familiar with

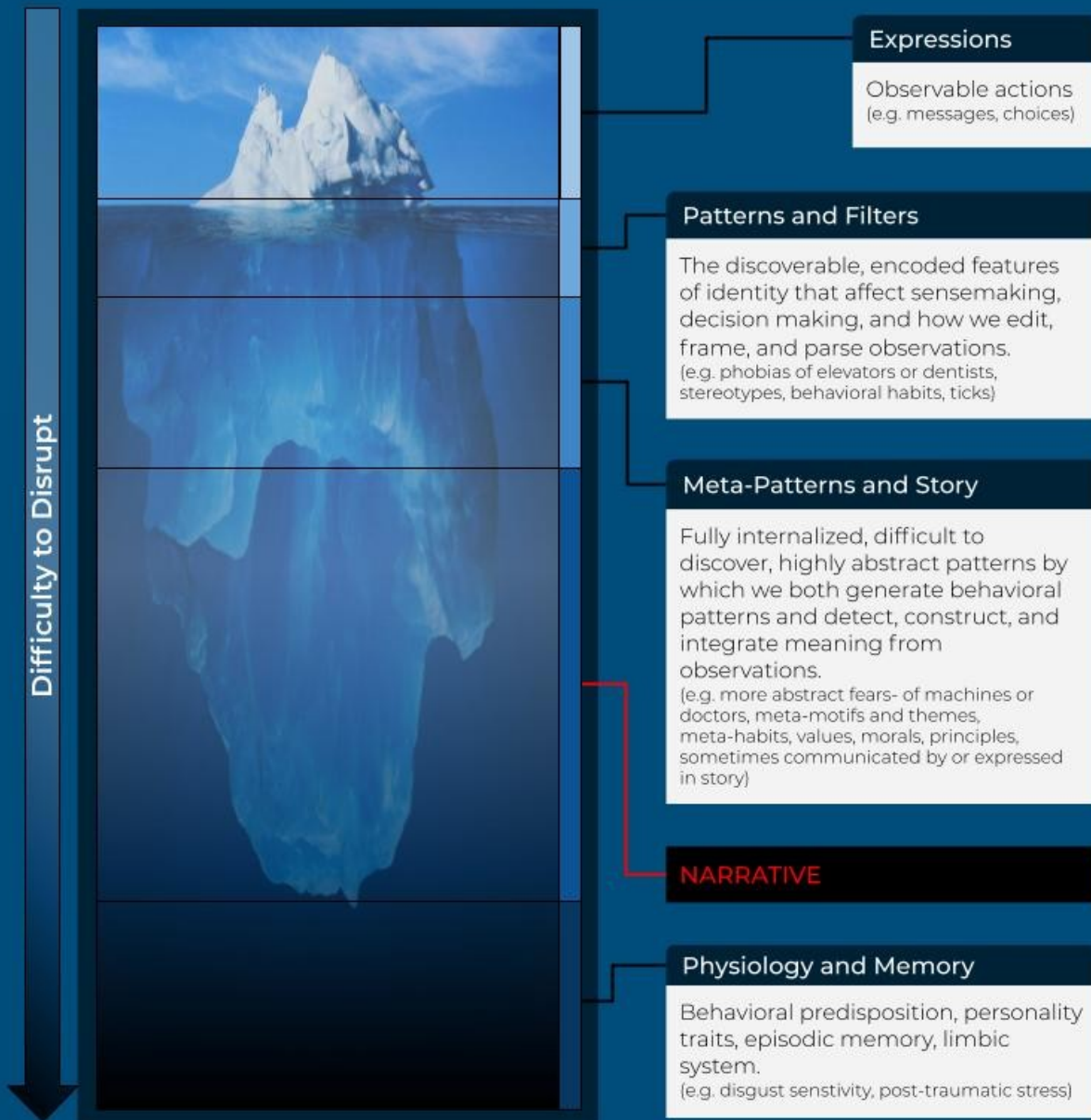
the narratives and sub-narratives the target audience lives by, determines meaning by, and understands their identities within. If we want to influence the target audience, we must start by understanding them. Empathy is the first and perhaps most important step in any effective communication and vital in recognizing and combatting disinformation.

“If we want to reduce uncertainty and potential for negative externalities in the campaigns we produce... then we need to get very familiar with the narratives within the Target Audience”

The meaning of concepts like safety, security, and pandemic are not static. We interpret and compress information into meaning and abstract concepts according to our current mental state, the reactions and perceived interpretations of others, our expectations of why the information was presented, and the environment in which it is presented—all of this context is developed through the lenses that our internalized narratives provide. Further, they help dictate who we are supposed to be, how we are supposed to behave, and how we are supposed to interpret the meaning of concepts in those contexts and the definition of the context itself.

What is Narrative?

Narrative is a complex, multi-layer representation of an individual's moral and cultural model of the world that sits in the nexus between physiology and deeply encoded symbolic memory. It is dynamically constructed and esoterically communicated through socio-cultural interactions, such as stories, rituals, and art, and intermediated by technology, physiology, risk, and incentives. Significant portions of this representation are contextual, unconscious, emotional, or are otherwise independent of language and rationale. Narrative helps the brain to rapidly compress, filter, and extract meaning from external information and take actions in order to maintain a consistent view of both the outside world and the self.



Key Insights

- Most of what we label as narrative are the expressions of narrative or the vehicles which propagate it, not the narrative itself. Successful messages and stories tap into a larger motivating narrative, usually one rooted in identity.
- Narrative is a complex, multi-layer representation of an individual's moral and cultural model of the world based in the nexus between symbolic memory and physiological factors and predispositions.
- Narratives are constructed and communicated through socio-cultural interactions.
- Significant portions of narrative are contextual, unconscious, emotional, or are otherwise independent of language and rationale.
- Narrative helps the brain to rapidly compress, filter, and extract meaning from external information and take actions in order to maintain a consistent view of both the outside world and the self.
- Messages we construct are not static. Their meaning will change based on the target audience receiving it, the messenger that shares it, the medium it's received over, and the timing in which it is received.
- Narratives are generally uncritically inherited and influenced.
- Credibility, trust, and plausibility are more important aspects of narrative influence than truth.
- One of the biggest challenges facing a Narrative Campaign Strategist is the observability of their target audience's Extant Narrative and their ability to empathize enough with that narrative to effectively understand how communications will be filtered and internalized.

3.1. Observing Narrative: Frameworks and Tools

Having supplied a primer for understanding the importance and nature of narrative and the difficulty in observing it, here a variety of frameworks for making it more observable and easier to account for are provided. These tools and recommendations were synthesized from reviewing requirements and planning materials from areas such as social media campaigns, political campaigning, influence and psychological operations (psyops), and marketing and advertising.

The driving questions of this section are:

- How do we influence a population that doesn't share our worldview, principles, or historical context?
- What if we are dealing with a hostile target audience?
- How do we avoid falling into a linear communications strategy?
- How do we better observe the narrative of the target audience so that we can integrate it into our campaigns?

3.1.1. Human Terrain Teams

Geography can concentrate and unify individual narratives through culture and physical context. In the social sciences literature these resulting clusters of cultural traits are sometimes referred to as "cultural landscapes" (sometimes also described as "human terrain"). Our connected digital environment has expanded these landscapes beyond physical space, but these new digital cultural landscapes are often different than physical ones in their impact on individual narratives of their members. To this end, there are a number of best practices related to the observation of narrative which can be compressed by discussing the recommendation of forming and deploying "Human Terrain Teams" or HTTs.

HTTs are generally meant to be composed of social sciences researchers or anthropologists and (perhaps most importantly) individuals who are native to and have a strong understanding of the "cultural landscape" of interest. The idea is to combine academic theory and frameworks with the cultural knowledge of the local specialists in order to collect data and generate briefs which capture the local cultural knowledge but express relevant details in a way that an outsider can understand and integrate into Narrative Campaigns or other operations. Campaign planners can also inform the HTT of current methods, strategies, and messages and receive direct, invaluable feedback on how it might be interpreted. HTTs can also be exceptionally helpful in identifying the correct "messengers" if your campaign will make use of external individuals to cross-promote or synchronize messaging. Messaging is most effective if the messenger is a member of the target audience's in-group or deemed credible by them. The plausibility of messages is an amalgam of fit with prior knowledge and narrative, the credibility of the messenger, and the medium through which the message is received.

"The plausibility of messages is an amalgam of the fit with prior knowledge and narrative, the credibility of the messenger, and the medium through which the message is received."

HTTs for Vaccine Hesitancy

In addressing vaccine hesitancy, an HTT might include cooperative first-responders who are on the fence about vaccination but leaning toward acceptance, individuals who were previously on the fence, individuals who are from households which are anti-vaccination, moderators of forums which deal with these kinds of topics, and scientists and researchers focused on extremism, cultural bias, sensemaking, or behavioral psychology.

HTTs do not necessarily have to adhere to any specific structure in order to be effective and can come in a number of forms. For example, focus groups can act as a form of HTT, with the interviewer taking the role of researcher and the members being local specialists. We also do not need a “team” to achieve some of the same results, having a member of the team who knows individuals in the target audience can be of notable help as well, however, take note that using single individuals may come with the risks. The value of an HTT is derived from its ability to contain members from multiple subcultures as a single individual may be over-fit for a particular subculture, and its ability to communicate, filter, and generalize the observations of these members.

While military and intelligence HTTs come with ethical concerns (e.g. the “weaponization of anthropology”), the concept of HTTs is generalizable to a broad range of situations which do not carry similar connotations or concerns.

3.1.2. Linguistic Analysis

The language we use to describe language itself can often mislead us about its nature. We use the term language to describe a grammatical and syntactic rule-set tied to a vocabulary (e.g. English) and the term dialect to describe the rulesets and vocabulary that use its mother language as a root but differ enough to require careful listening or reading from speakers of other dialects (e.g. American English, British English), but this is an oversimplification of the actual phenomena—as languages borrow from each other and dialects can have many subdivisions, jargons, pidgins, patois, and slangs.

In the past, the segmentation and development of language was generally quite slow and bounded by geographic constraints and difficulty of travel, with accelerations being driven by invasions and the opening of trade routes. However, due to the decentralized nature of the cyber information environment, there are now a perceivably infinite number of what could potentially be described as subcultural slangs and dialects—and, because individuals online are not bound by geography, these dialects are associated with intersections at a myriad of communications hubs that are accessible at the click of a button rather than with towns or villages as would have been the case in the past. An individual could be associated with many communities and subcommunities, some of which develop slangs and dialects purposefully. While code-switching is a term commonly used to refer to Black Americans rapidly changing dialects, it can also be generalized to describe other shifts in dialect, such as those which occur between different communities, and modes of communication. Do not underestimate how fast ontology can change or develop. Regular data extractions are necessary throughout a campaign to ensure analyses are up to date (see Figure 1).

Text analysis of communications hubs used by your target audience and comparing ontology and vocabulary with that of news sites and unrelated hubs can reveal a great deal about where the target audience is getting their information and what communities they may be a part of outside of these hubs. In addition, more direct, heuristic analysis of language-use and metaphors around topics of interest, can reveal how they may be thinking about those topics but not saying. It can also demonstrate how certain words with identical meaning can have different use or emotional associations. As shown in the word trees in Figure 2, which compare context and 5 words preceding and following the root word in national media the first week of February 2021, “coronavirus” was used and associated much more often with pandemic, and “COVID” with vaccine and solutions.

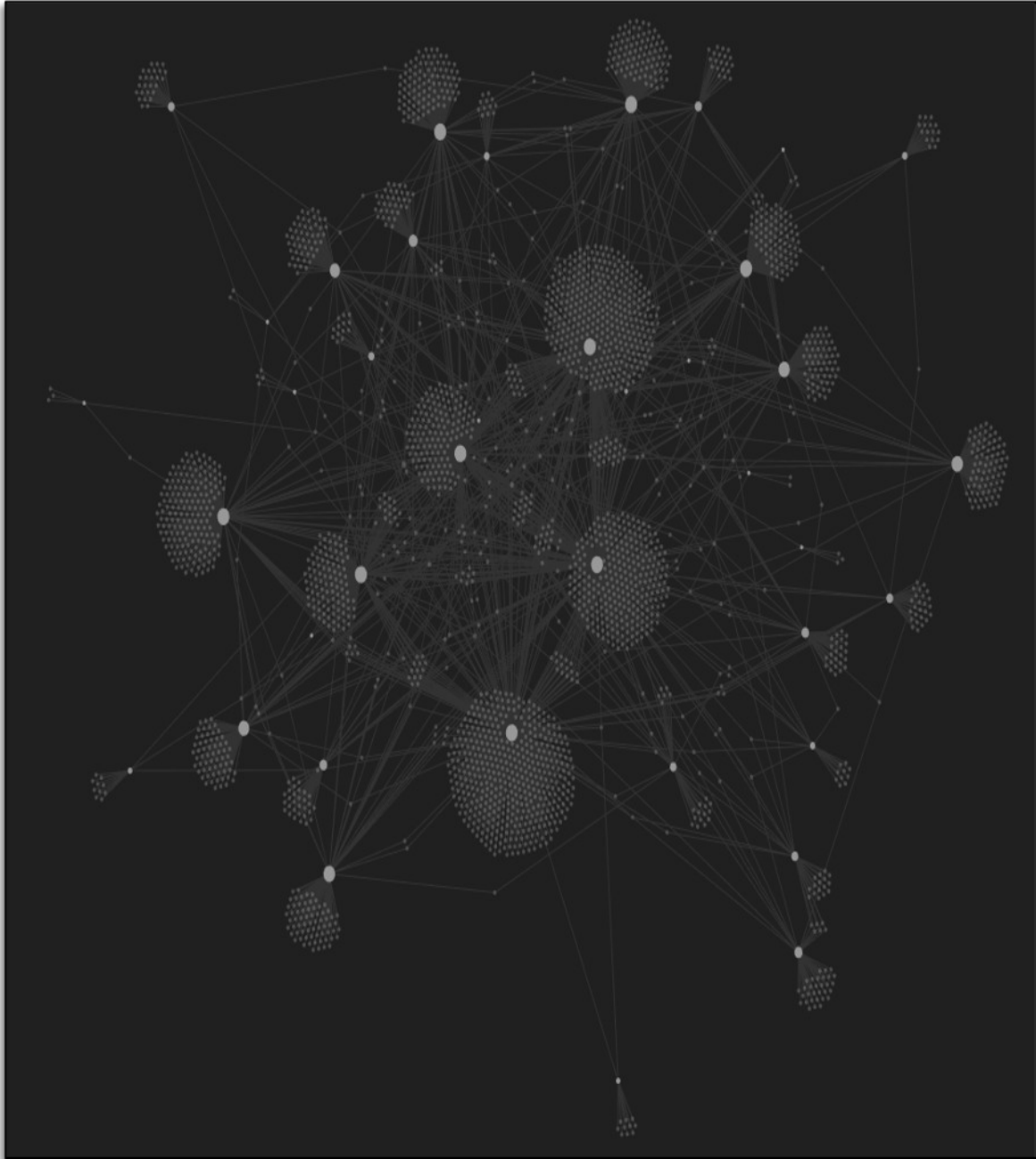


Figure 1. Ontology scraped from communications hubs during a virtual hackathon, Complexity Weekend (www.complexityweekend.com) which brings together a large number of working professionals and students from many fields to work on solutions to difficult problems. Large nodes represent separate channels, smaller nodes represent terms of art and keywords used, lines tie terms to their use in a channel. Given the diversity of backgrounds and perspectives present in any given channel, ontology can rapidly develop and then spread—presence and context of terminology in one channel can thus indicate past exposure to other communications channels.

Words also change over time to reflect subtle shifts in perspective and learning. For example, text analysis by Public Democracy showed that from early January through late February, searches and content engagement by Americans indicated that the most common word associated with content on the COVID vaccines shifted from “vaccine”, to “COVID vaccine”, and finally to “vaccination”—showing a progression from general to direct understanding and from concept to action.

Similarly, at the beginning of the outbreak, Public Democracy was able to predict locations of COVID spread and the potential for loss of smell as a symptom ahead of the first reported results throughout March due, in part, to minor variants in word used by localized populations. After first identifying an odd language difference in February between Seattle and the rest of the country, an interesting trend began to emerge nationally: people searching for and reading content on “Coronavirus symptoms” focused on more generalized news and content about this new disease and its origins, whereas those searching and reading about “symptoms of Coronavirus” did additional investigation into each of little-known symptoms associated with COVID at the time.

Free Association: Many Names, One Virus

The words used to describe COVID-19 may vary greatly by community: COVID, COVID-19, SARS-COV-2, Corona, Coronavirus, The Virus, Rona, the China Virus, the Wuhan Virus, 2019-nCoV, and Novel Coronavirus. Comparing terminology between communications hubs and that which is used in the target audience can give a sense of their traffic, usage, and context throughout the web without access to tracking data, but trying to understand why some terms are used in certain contexts or predicting how new terms will be interpreted can be a challenge.

Free association is a technique in psychology meant to help access unconscious patterns an individual might have attached to symbols or specific contexts. It asks that the therapist offer a patient a prompt in the form of an image or single word or statement and then allowing them to respond using a selected method. In trying to understand why some words are being attached to certain contexts and not others, it can be helpful to replicate and adapt this process when using focus groups or even your own team. While internal use might not reveal how the audience will respond to those words, at the least, it can be helpful in revealing your team’s expectations (and biases) about the use of these words.



Figure 3. Text analysis performed by PublicDemocracy.io

Key Insights

- Performing linguistic analyses and becoming language-aware can increase observability of the target audience's narrative, and this understanding can help prevent accidental use of potentially triggering terms in messaging and content. Understanding of language and its contextual use by a target audience (and adversaries) can also be used to pre-define or give context to language you expect the target audience to encounter later in undesired contexts. Placing a word in quotes for example can have a notable impact on how a target audience will perceive the term in the future—however, if they've already been exposed to and embrace the term, placing it in quotes may be interpreted as inappropriate or demeaning and will have notable impacts on how they interpret the rest of your messaging.

- Further, by focusing on when certain language is used, campaigns can better connect and meet a target audience in specific moments when they are most open to engage. For example, in Public Democracy's work with veterans with severe PTSD, veterans who were reading and searching for content on "Veterans' Affairs health benefits" were 10x more likely to respond to offers to enter communities of trust and ultimately seek services than when they were reading about "VA health benefits". Language is not merely a way we express ourselves, it can deeply affect our interpretation of context and our emotional state and it is one of the most fundamental keys to both enabling and understanding complex thought and narrative.

3.1.3. Deconstruction and Story Identification

We cannot fully express the narrative of our target audience in a statement for the same reason we cannot easily express the structure of a network: there is often a complexity that doesn't lend itself to being described in single statements, but instead in models. If we want to represent a network, we can model its nodes and edges, and we can use similar principles in representing narrative. Here we compress some best practices from literary theory, applied psychology, network theory, and user experience design in the interest of helping to create ad hoc representations of narrative.

Key elements of narrative focused on under this methodology include: Hubs, Symbols, Stories, Expressions, and Values.

(1) Hubs

Starting this process of story identification and deconstruction begins with identifying hubs. Hubs are the centers of gravity for communications within the target audience. This process can be done through various forms of social network analysis or it can be heuristic and exploratory. Identifying a single hub and following those that interacted with it through OSINT (open-source intelligence), cookie tracking, and other methods may reveal numerous other smaller, as well as larger, communications hubs. When identifying these hubs, be sure to mark their importance and impact on the target audience and the nature of their relationship with the target audience.

Two specific aspects of the relationship between the audience and the hub are essential to address:

1. Who has the power to set agendas?
2. Who has the power to impact discourse?

Research on attitudinal change reveals that the media expresses the power to influence not through its ability to change what people thought about a subject but through their ability to change what subjects people were thinking about. The fields of study concerned with the nature of this power to influence are referred to as “agenda setting” and “agenda-melding”. The more distributed the ability to set agendas and impact discourse is, the more quickly information and interpretations will mutate and change.

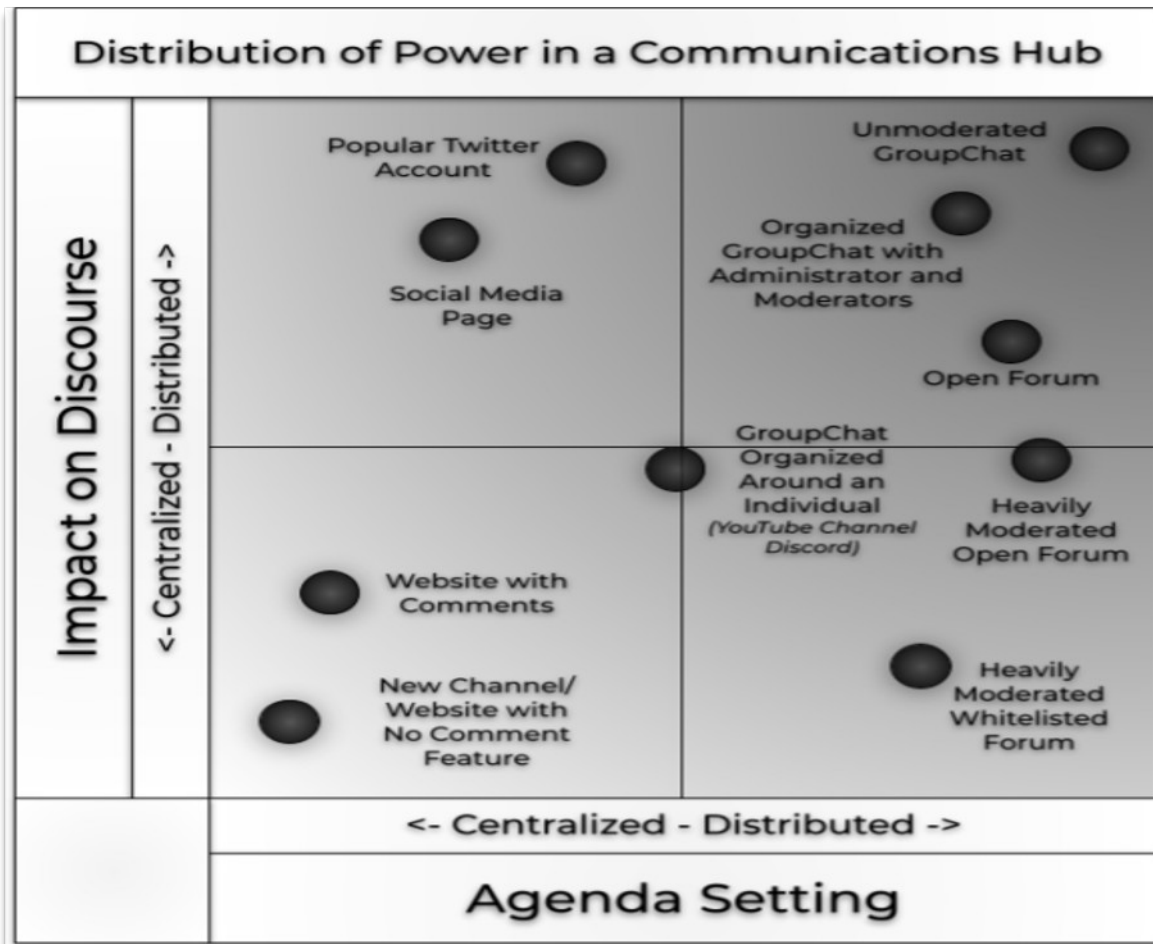


Figure 4. Hubs might include email threads, social media pages and accounts, discord servers, forums, and websites. The ability to set and modify agendas are paramount in mapping the impact of hubs and considering their relative importance in a social network. A high-traffic website with no comment section is a very different kind of hub than a discord server or forum.

(2) Expressions

If key communications hubs for messaging within the target audience have been identified, then the collection of “expressions” can begin. Expressions are the easily observable products of internalized narratives, such as statements, image-template memes, copy-pasta, videos, books, comments, and other content. It is important to catalog popular expressions within the hub, as patterns may emerge that wouldn’t otherwise be apparent through simple scrolling. During cataloging, be sure to mark the key objects of reference within them, the slang, ontology, and keywords they use, and what ideas and concepts are present. To make cataloging impactful, it’s important to annotate the expressions with the sentiment your target audience is indicating they have toward the objects and ideas referenced.

If cataloging is automated, there are algorithms available to calculate sentiment, but if cataloging is heuristic and performed by humans it may be helpful to generate a simple rubric. Rubrics can be numeric (e.g. negative to positive on a scale of 1-10), but given that emotion is regulated by threshold events in a psychochemical system, categorical rubrics can be more appropriate in some cases (see Figure 5).

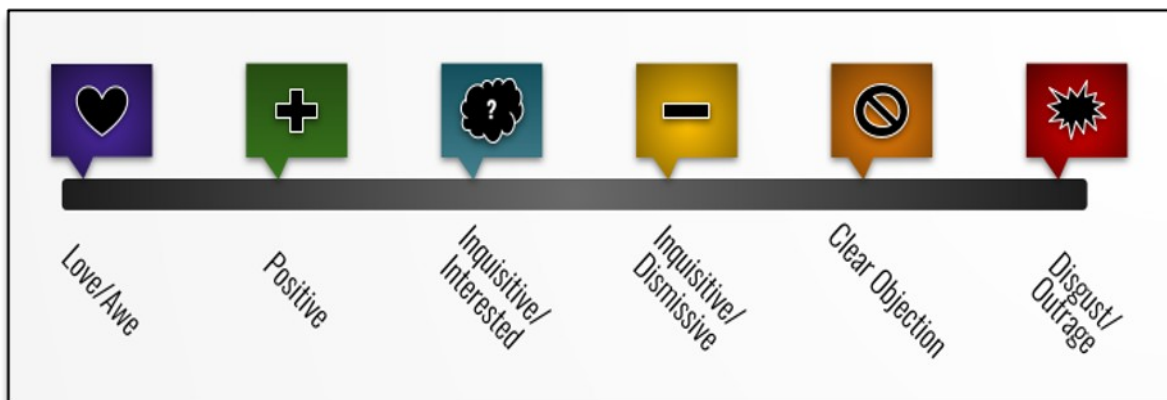


Figure 1. Example Categorical Sentiment Rubric

Cataloging expressions, the sentiment contained with them, and the sentiment shared in response, as said earlier, allows us to see and document patterns. These patterns may reveal specific stories and symbols within their narrative that would have otherwise been invisible or obscured given the volume of messages in some communications hubs. In addition, it may reveal cypypasta as well as “parroting” of or reflexive responses to other messages in the space—knowledge of reflex and pattern can greatly increase the predictability of campaign messaging.

Coppypasta?

Copy-pasta is a phrase referring to copy-pasted statements rapidly shared on social media. Some may be short and interpreted as slogans others may be long essays with notable detail. Copy-pasta is an emergent and impactful element in the information ecosystem. In some cases, copy-pasta is marked clearly as having been copied and pasted, but in others, both state actors and members of more organized virtual communities will make slight adaptations to the copy-pasta and allow people to assume that it is novel content—this is especially disruptive when deployed en masse by many individual accounts on social networks. Where image-template memes rarely add information to a space, copy-pasta content is usually used to “dump” information into a space, often containing dozens of, often statistical, details. Copy-pasta has been in common use during the pandemic, both in support of and against vaccines.

(3) Stories

Target audiences are often described in terms of their targeted sentiment: “hostile toward x”, “open to y”, but these descriptions are rarely accompanied by the stories that they constructed that led them to these sentiments. Stories can be composed from real or hypothetical expressions and events that reveal the progression toward some attitude, behavior, conclusion, or decision. Stories can be represented in story-boards with collections of static, visual expressions, such as memes and statements, as well as notes regarding the events that prompted them with indications of sentiment. They can also be constructed as written stories of events and the general responses of the target audience, indicating the catalyzation of some narrative. Stories are a great way to both represent and reveal key aspects of the target audience’s narrative. Constructing stories from expressions may reveal recurring themes, motifs, and symbols as well as the moral principles and values of the target audience.

(4) Symbols

Symbols present in expressions and stories may be (a) physical or visual, such as flags and icons, (b) real or fictional persons, such as perceived heroes, enemies, and mascots, or (c) abstract, such as phrases or concepts. The field of semiotics helps to define symbols and lends support to tools found in other fields which make use of symbols or the deconstruction of their meaning. Any attempt to model narrative should include the cataloging and identification of the symbols of the target audience. Remember that your target audience is likely composed of sub-communities which may not share the same symbols and that there may be symbols which you do not recognize as such and some symbols may be adopted from other communities and mutated over time. Symbols act as

key centers of gravity around which narratives are constructed and anchored—identifying them is prerequisite to disrupting or fortifying them.

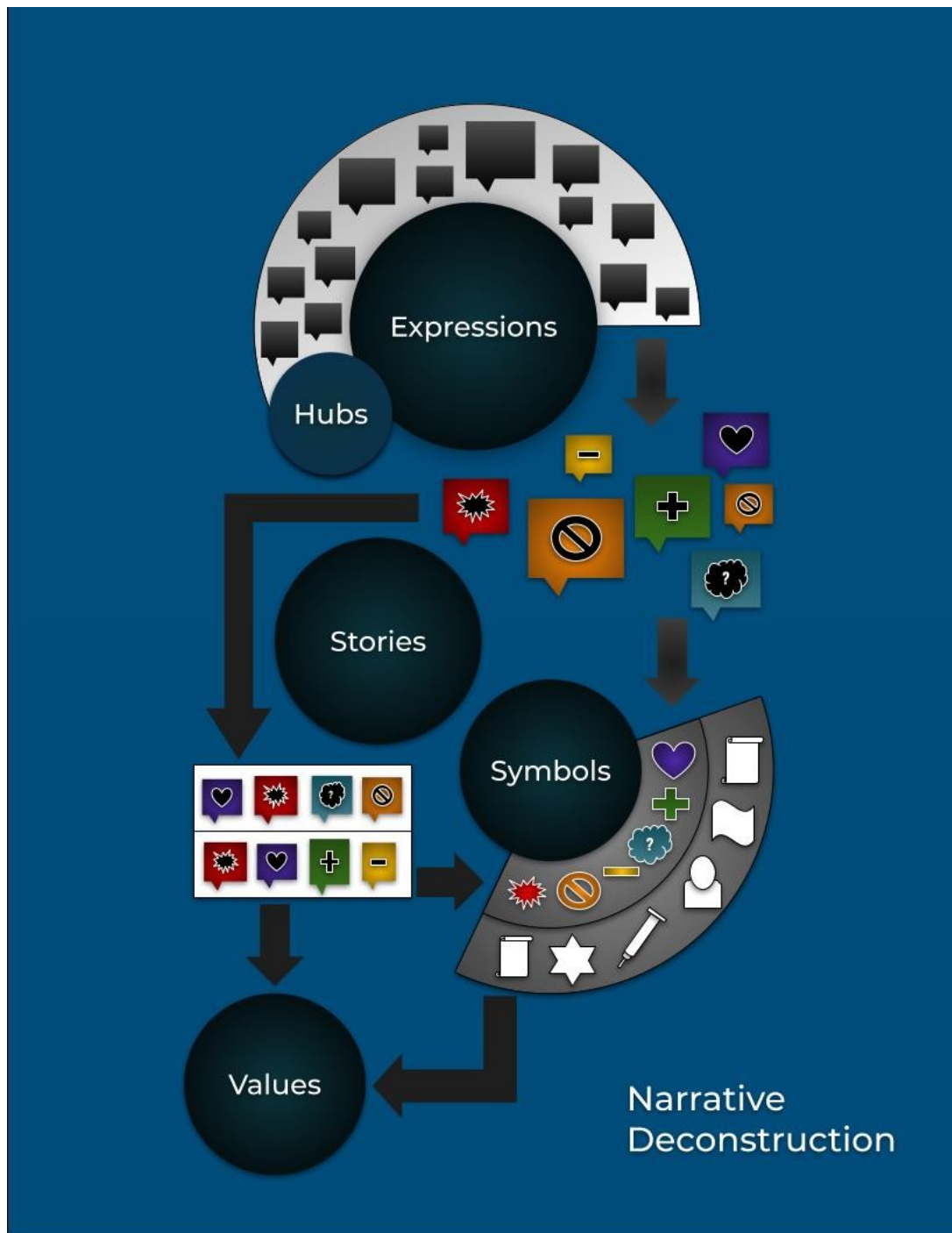
No-Vax Symbols

Past anti-vaccination symbols have included phrases like “Reject Big Pharma”, individuals like Bill Gates, and the Yellow Star of David Badge, the star which Jews were required to wear during the Holocaust. It may seem ridiculous to you that the target audience might compare the plight of European Jews during the Holocaust to the requirement for vaccination cards, but your goal isn’t to judge the quality of their arguments or outlook, it is to understand it—and many of the individuals in this case do make this comparison. In trying to understand a target audience’s values, it is the (undesired) default to frame them as in opposition to our own. When addressing vaccine hesitancy, it may be easy to label “personal freedom” as “anti-authority” and “public welfare” as “anti-capitalist”. If we want to better understand the values of our target audience, we have to be aware of our own.

(5) Values

Values are the moral principles and objections of the target audience. While values are most closely mapped to internalized narrative, there is a reason we don’t begin by trying to document values, but instead allow them to emerge from patterns in symbols and stories: the values of the target audience may be illusory, contradictory, or contextual. Whenever a value, such as “personal freedom”, “parental autonomy”, or “public welfare” is determined, it can be helpful to indicate an “except where...”, to give needed context. Values are one of the most direct connectors and anchors of narrative, providing the fundamental reasons people hold positions and support or oppose issues. Assignment of values is a deeply heuristic process, but invaluable in compressing and communicating a model of the narrative of the target audience.

Given that individuals will hold numerous core values, one of the most effective ways to shift attitudes is to reassociate information and actions with different values. For example, the most vocal and politically meaningful of the advocacy groups credited by the EPA for Obama-era Mercury regulations were pro-life Christians who were not active on climate protection but mobilized by the hundreds of thousands to lobby for federal restrictions on coal power plant emissions when that issue was linked by climate groups to “protecting the unborn”.



3.1.4. Moments and Threshold Analysis

Compressed here are methods from user experience design, literary analysis, and software development which have recently been modified for use in successful narrative campaigns related to PTSD, Extremism, and Heroin Addiction. A key principle of successful user experience design is to regularly break from the view of your audience as a group and view them instead as a smaller set of specific individuals who best represent that group and its key outliers. Many software development and team organization frameworks include recommendations to have an individual role-play a specific end-user and most user experience design frameworks demand numerous “user stories”, which are about specific users and their key interactions or “moments” within the designed platform. Outside of the digital space in literary analysis, there is an emphasis on meta-story structure and the suggestion that successful or meaningful stories are generally composed of a series of key threshold events which act as centers of gravity for the narrative being communicated.

Moments analysis is a strategy developed by the organization Public Democracy, which makes use of these principles in narrative campaigns. It takes this concept of shifting the frame of view from audience to individual a step further by recognizing that individuals may be substantially more receptive under specific circumstances. How we understand ourselves, our peers, and our world can vary greatly with context (e.g. at home with the kids, in a work meeting, in worship, or out at a bar with friends). Understanding these different moments and engaging in them in a way that is responsive to the needs and intent of the individual in that moment is often the key to successful message reception.

The objective is therefore to place focus on temporally-oriented (time and place) stories of real or imagined individuals in the target audience on their path to the intended or unintended decision or development of an attitude, behavior, conclusion, or decision rather than on the abstract stories that the target audience may be constructing from events, messaging, and previous experiences. Both telling a story about the individual and trying to deconstruct the stories that an individual has constructed about the world help us to build empathy for the individual’s position and the reasoning behind their choices, but the former offers a special insight: the moments and key threshold events at which they would be most open or closed to external influence, over what kinds of mediums over which they could be influenced, and what messengers or formats they would be responsive to.

These stories can be discovered by viewing the expressions of the target audience or engaging with them directly. Many individuals may be more open than you think to explaining why they think what they think if you approach them and offer nonjudgmental validation of their views. Using a storyboard with frames can be helpful in exploring the story of a real or imagined individual on their journey. Key threshold events to consider are personal tragedies, serious changes in mental or physical state,

breaks in trust, or anxiety inducing discoveries. At each of these thresholds discovered, it's important to ask yourself:

- Where are they when it happens?
 - What technology will they have access to?
 - Where will they look for information?
- What behaviors will stem from these thresholds being reached?
 - What will these behaviors look like in data?
- How will their attitudes change?

All of this information can then be used in a variety of methods to plan interventions and disruptions, predict expected behaviors, and target individuals who will experience these moments in the future. This approach's focus on the individual will also remind the narrative campaign strategist that the quality of the campaign will be expressed in its impact on individuals and that group impacts are a byproduct of its individual successes.

COVID-19: A Mass Threshold Event

Everyone has been affected by COVID-19: wearing or being prompted to wear a mask, the quarantine, and the difficulty in managing normal activities has had mass impact. While this constitutes a key threshold event, moments analysis asks us to dig into unique, individual stories and to remember that some of these stories may have begun before COVID-19. Examples to consider may be a mother whose child developed seizures after receiving an unrelated vaccine, an individual who after a quarantine-triggered divorce and job-loss now lives alone for the first time in 20 years, a person who watched protests be deemed not to be a public health risk after not being allowed to be with their loved ones before they died in the hospital.

3.1.5. SEE-A Narrative Framework

As this Field Guide was developed, a need was recognized for a framework to anchor more comprehensive modeling approaches to narratives, especially one which could generalize approaches found in systems modeling and engineering, active inference, psychology and criminology, neuroscience, and social computing. A working-framework was developed which incorporates many principles from the aforementioned fields and from other approaches offered in the Field Guide that are intended to make narratives observable but also includes other elements which acknowledge both narrative as not static and the presence of a campaign intended to affect it. The resulting framework is intended to help adapt the model as the campaign progresses, inform engagements and messaging, predict future impacts on that narrative, and present the campaign to stakeholders. Further, it uses concepts from the fields of complexity science and knowledge management, to allow the model to both be built and analyzed qualitatively as well as to be adapted and analyzed using systems analysis tools, such as cadCAD, which are growing in popularity for performing social network analysis and simulating intervention impact.

What is Complexity Science?

Complexity Science is a field which uses transdisciplinary approaches for the study and design of systems which have interacting subcomponents and fundamental uncertainty. Real world systems exist across multiple spatial and temporal scales, and actions at a higher level (e.g. socio-political regulations) can influence actions at a lower level (e.g. movement patterns) and vice-versa. These pervasive interactions within and between scales can thwart the design of adaptive short- and long-term policies. In light of this difficulty, Complexity Science prescribes the search for the patterns across systems such as brains, ecosystems, and economies. To elucidate and exploit these cross-system patterns, Complexity Science incorporates insights and methods from physics, biology, design, innovation, and more.

The framework expects the strategist to begin by specifying the desired attitude, behavior, conclusion, or decision, and then selecting the model's "center of gravity", which is a hypothetical or real expression within a target audience that acts as a barrier to the desired policy, referred to as a "Barrier". It is likely that more than one barrier to policy is present in an individual's narrative. This being the case, many of the models can be chained together in order to create a model of models, a method which is becoming more commonplace in systems analysis. Following this introduction of a Barrier, the SEE-A Narrative Framework includes four key elements: (1) Stepping

Stones and Shields, (2) Engagements, (3) Explorations, and (4) Accelerants, all defined below with numerous examples focused on vaccine hesitancy.

Barriers

As stated in the description of the framework, the barrier is the model's center of gravity, best expressed as a short statement which expresses objection or hesitance about enacting an attitude, behavior, conclusion, or decision that is representative of expressions that might be made within the target audience. While the narrative of interest can be composed of multiple barriers, building on one at a time both allows the model and campaign to be well scoped and targeted and prevents the strategist or researcher from becoming overwhelmed. It's important to define whether the barrier is likely to result in a hesitancy about the intended attitude, behavior, conclusion, or decision, or in a direct objection. Further, given limitations on both cognitive and material resources, it can be helpful to start by listing a large number of barriers and consider which ones could be compressed and merged or deprioritized.

When listing potential barriers to develop a SEE-A Narrative Model around, patterns may emerge that allow compressions or merges. Limits on time and resources means careful prioritization, so annotating or color-coding barriers as likely resulting in hesitancy versus clear objection to enacting desired policy can be impactful. For example, addressing vaccination objections based on religious belief will be much more likely to fail and more prone to backfire as opposed to vaccine hesitancy based on concerns about side effects.

Examples of Barriers to Vaccination

There is no simple way to easily address “vaccine hesitancy” because there are so many different reasons people may be placed into that category. To restate one of the most central truths of this Guide, **audience understanding is more important than any particular tool or message to effective Narrative Campaigns**. Toward that end, the authors identified 5 common categories of “barriers” to vaccination (see Figure 6). Some of these barriers manifest in similar behavior (and definitely in identical answers to polling questions), but are internalized by individuals for very different reasons based on their experiences and resulting narratives. As highlighted in the case study section, messages that might be effective with audiences that are “hesitant” due to one barrier can be absolutely counter-productive if their “hesitancy” stems from another.

I don't think the vaccine is safe - It was produced too rapidly - The risks and side effects are worse than the disease - I don't trust the govt, academia, and/or pharmaceutical industry - mRNA vaccines have no track record, we have no idea what the long term effects might be - It's still not approved	I don't think the vaccine works - It doesn't prevent COVID - I don't trust the govt, academia, and/or pharmaceutical industry to get it right - It may work for most people, but likely won't work on me COVID Isn't a Threat - It's a hoax - It's like the flu	Risk Assessment & Preference - If something goes wrong, I have no legal recourse - This is against my religious beliefs - Even if I get the vaccine, society won't return to normal - I'm afraid of shots - People I respect aren't getting it - If everyone else is getting vaccinated, why do I need it? (Free Rider) - I prefer natural immunity
Logistical and Informational Uncertainty - I don't have enough information to make a decision - I don't even know how to go about getting it - There's so much disinfo, noise, and junk information- I'll wait for clarity - I don't know how it might affect fertility		Barriers to Vaccination

Figure 6. Categorized barriers to vaccination.

It's important to note that many of the barriers shown in Figure 6 are built on perfectly reasonable concerns, so adjustment to risk calculus is often preferable to counter-messaging and universally preferable to dismissing underlying concerns. Also worth noting is that, despite the focus of US media focus on vaccine hesitancy being linked to anti-scientific and conspiracy viewpoints, very few of the barriers discovered were necessarily "anti-science" or conspiratorial, but most had links to distrust. Further, the focus on characterizing those who are vaccine-hesitant as conspiracists and anti-scientific may be causing many to withhold their views and in some cases even encourage conspiratorial thinking.

Anti-Science or Anti-Scientist?

A study of conservative anti-science trends noted that conservatives actually have "remarkably positive" attitudes toward scientific research, but perceive scientific authorities as politically biased. Evangelical Environmental Network conducted a fascinating poll which is discussed in the paper "Love the Science, Hate the Scientists: Conservative Identity Protects Belief in Science and Undermines Trust in Scientists" which illustrates both this point and how easily barriers can sometimes be overcome when audience narratives are understood. It found that American evangelical Christians opposed by a 3-1 margin the statement that the federal government should take action to "address climate change because 97% of scientists agree climate change is real and humans are the cause," but that 80% supported the statement that the government should act because "the Bible teaches we have a moral responsibility to care for God's creation, and 97% of scientists agree climate change is real and humans are the cause." By adding a few words, the message went from being perceived as biased and politically motivated to supporting a core set of values and beliefs held by the target audience.

(1) Stepping Stones and Shields

Stepping Stones and Shields represent features that would affect the ingress of information and the construction and processing of story of a target audience which held the barrier in question. Stepping Stones act as a sort of precursor, representing the necessary priors and outlooks necessary for the development of a barrier whereas Shields act as inhibitors to this development. These precursors and inhibitors are broken into four categories, Scars, Scripts, State, and Structures. The items within these will often be interconnected, and in a system modeling framework, could be given meaningful edges and relationships between one another.

a. Scars and Imprints

Scars are emotionally charged memories of both lived experiences and media. Due to connotations associated with the word, lesser scars may be described as closer to stains and emotionally charged memories which are not negative are perhaps better described as imprints. Watching a particularly dramatic documentary about an event or having lived through the event are different but both have similar functions. Emotionally charged memories greatly affect how we parse information and how we develop story, and can create scripts and state (discussed below) which are both incredibly difficult to disrupt and mostly invulnerable to direct messaging campaigns. They are important to understand either to avoid or potentially use as a means of motivating action, understanding, or common connection between otherwise different audiences. Searching for scars should always be a priority because they may lend important context for other features yet, unlike physical scars, may not always be easily spotted.

Scars related to vaccine hesitancy and objection: It's important to remember that not all concerns about vaccines are conspiratorial or "anti-science" and that dismissing some concerns that may be identified to be "emotionally-driven" is akin to dismissing trauma. **Dismissing what a target audience deems to be legitimate concern will reliably generate blowback and hardening.** While vaccine mishaps are arguably rare, those small percentages can be extrapolated to represent real individuals who have or know children that have developed seizures and other conditions after being vaccinated. Even where concerns are conspiratorial in nature, it's equally important to remember the notion that "sometimes paranoid people are right": knowledge of the Tuskegee Syphilis Study, Operation Sea-Spray, and Operation Green-Run act as scars, greatly, and reasonably, impacting the ingress of information. Counter-messaging against these kinds of subjects, especially in a dismissive way, is not likely to be impactful.

Scars aren't always Stepping Stones: Some scars aren't stepping stones but instead act as shields against the barrier to the desired policy. In the case of an anticipatory or proactive campaign, rather than a reactive campaign, identifying scars can help

prioritize subgroups in the target audience which are actually less vulnerable to developing the barrier. For example, in the case of vaccine hesitancy, the most obvious scars which act as shields to development of a barrier to vaccination might be losing a family member to COVID-19, but less obvious may be losing a family member to the flu or other preventable disease. A less serious (depending on what one might define as serious) example of a scar that acts as a shield might be bringing information to a group chat or community that turns out to be demonstrably false (shame) which would greatly affect ingress of information from poor sources. By conducting subject interviews and cataloging messaging, behavior can sometimes be deconstructed to reveal these kinds of scars.

b. Scripts

Scripts are predictable and cued patterns of behavior that act as stepping stones and shields. Scripts can be encoded by scars and imprints, triggered by state (described below), and be closely associated with structures (described below). For example, scientists have socially-constructed scripts that act as impetus to cite or verify claims in certain environments and we all have physiological scripts, reinforced by social-construction, such as the ones which cause us to wince in response to sour milk. Scripts help us rapidly make sense of and take action in the world, when to shake hands, when to sit down at a restaurant, when to get off the train, what a trustworthy website looks like, and so on. Scripts may become especially apparent when cataloging messages from a communications hub central to an in-group. For example, a discord server, private Facebook group, or a whitelisted forum where the target audience interacts online with a hostile out-group such as on a mainstream news and information social media page. Scripts are important to identify because they represent behavior that isn't necessarily tied to reasoning, but instead tied to past reasoning, expectations tied to self-identity and identity within a group, and to physiology, therefore greatly impacting the efficacy of messaging.

Some example scripts: Knowing the audience's scripts can help to avoid wasted time and energy just as much as it can help spend it wisely. For example, using direct messaging from a corporate source toward a group which finds all messaging from corporate entities laughable or untrustworthy, or offering information on how to schedule a vaccine appointment to a group which has serious objections to non-organic food and medicine would likely be a waste of resources. However, targeting messaging about vaccine appointments to certain populations through trusted messengers with an ask to share could result in a great deal of reach with limited expense. Language Analysis can be helpful in both discovering scripts and designing messages which bypass or trigger them.

c. State

State refers to the current mental, financial, and physical state of the target audience at a macro-level. State greatly affects the ingress of information and can trigger scripts and in some cases cause scars. High levels of anxiety, worry, and anger will impact decision making and bend the focus of attention toward threat-objects and paranoia. In many individuals it may also cause them to externalize sensemaking to third-parties, and if traditional institutions are no longer considered trustworthy, these third-parties are just as likely to be helpful as they are dangerous.

A difficult trade-off: While lockdown reduces the infection rate of COVID-19, the accompanying social isolation increases anxiety and irritability, thereby reducing the quality of reasoning and decision making—contributing to the spread of dangerous ideology and breakdowns in relationships. “Isolated” would thus be an important State attribute to consider.

d. Structure

Structures can be social, such as a community or a group-chat, or physical, such as residence type and their place in the settlement hierarchy (low-income apartment in a city, rural house, suburban home). Identifying social structures helps the campaign strategist observe key messaging and community resilience hubs and identifying physical structures can give some sense of what it is that the individual encounters offline.

Geospatial data still matters: Even though people are moving around less during the pandemic, knowing where the target audience is placed can indicate a great deal about what they’re up against outside of cyberspace. People living in small apartments during lockdown are far more likely to be experiencing heightened states of anxiety and individuals living in rural places are far less likely to see the impacts of COVID-19 at all and therefore see Government countermeasures oriented toward cities as unnecessary and oppressive.

(2) Explorations

While stepping stones and shields are about helping to map the potential features of a narrative which precede or prevent a barrier to policy, Explorations, the first E in the SEE-A narrative framework, are the part which indicates the tools that will be used to both reveal previously unseen features of that narrative and the impacts the campaign's engagements are having on those features. If the framework were being used in a systems analysis tool, some of the categories discussed below may include actual functions and scripts that update the model. Campaigns should not be static, they should be iteratively updated in response to new developments, data, and feedback—and defining your methods of Exploration helps ensure your expectations are reasonable and your campaign's ability to observe changes is well scoped and consistent. Explorations are broken into 4 categories: Extractions, Encounters, Echoes, and Experts.

a. Extractions

Extraction refers to the act of cataloging and scraping data about and from the target audience for various forms of analysis. This is not a one-time event, and should be done iteratively throughout the campaign. Extractions are the basis for both predictive and monitoring analytics regarding behavior and sentiment within the target audience. If your only source of data is encounters (described below, e.g. collecting data about sentiment response to a message) between the campaign and the target audience, the data may mislead attempts to quantify impact. **It is vital that the final step in any extraction exercise is to ask what is missing and where the holes in the data are.** Data analysis that lacks an intentional effort to understand what was not able to be analyzed runs a significant risk of generating not just incomplete, but incorrect insights.

b. Encounters

Encounters refer to the direct responses to affordances or messages the campaign deploys and exchanges between the target audience and the campaign. Campaigns cannot be static, as noted before, they have to be updated regularly in response to new data and feedback. Tracking encounters and related data such as sentiment and keywords help keep the campaign apprised of impact and valuable feedback that can inform iterative updates to strategy and tactics. Identifying the types of encounters from which data will be cataloged and how it will be cataloged helps ensure the campaign doesn't miss an opportunity for valuable insight regarding how it is being perceived.

Managing encounters: While a social media manager can be used to interact directly with the target audience, there is a growing trend in the use of chat-bots in order to engage with audiences at scale. Chat-bots also ensure that data is being cataloged effectively. Not all engagements with the target audience lend themselves to data collection and some may provide misleading or incomplete data, which is why it is important to identify which encounters you will collect from in advance and where the holes will be in order both to prioritize and interpret encounters effectively.

c. Echoes

Echoes refer to indications of the indirect impacts of affordances or messages the campaign deploys. Given that socio-technical systems are complex, echoes are generally heuristically discovered and unpredictable. Common echoes include campaign messaging being used or reported on over unexpected channels previously unconsidered or thought to be unrelated to the target audience, or impacts of the campaign on demographics outside of the target audience. In cases where unexpected impacts are made, data should be collected and stored, and the nature of the impact classified to allow for the emergence of patterns that would otherwise go unnoticed. The echoes of campaign impacts aren't just limited to repetition of expressions, but also the measurable changes in attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions within the target population or in descriptive data about changes to the information environment itself, such as measures of messaging volatility, sentiment, negative emotion, and confusion.

Watch Carefully: It's essential that the team is constantly on the lookout for developments elsewhere that may be linked to the campaign. For example, Reddit's rapid deplatforming of multiple forums considered to be linked to hate-speech may have been deemed successful at reducing hate-speech given data extractions on both Reddit and similar platforms. However, an observant team may have noted that Discord, Parler, 4chan, Gab, and Telegram all saw notable increases in growth following the deplatforming. The most notable of which may have been Discord with a growth from 56 million to 100 million users between 2019 and 2020. No data extraction would have revealed these kinds of echoes of the initial impacts of the campaign.

d. Experts

The campaign should have experts that they can rely on to inform or comment on the campaign's progress and impacts. Experts might include Human Terrain Specialists that know the target audience well enough to inform the team of developments that might not be apparent from data extractions or encounters, or individuals at organizations that have access to data that the campaign does not. It's important that these individuals be identified in advance and be contacted regularly for comment and feedback.

(3) Engagements

Engagements are the second E in the SEE-A Narrative framework, and represent the actual messaging, experiences, interventions, and affordances the campaign deploys. The categories represent broad classifications of the types of engagements that might occur. Engagements are broken into 4 categories: Expressions, Education, Enforcement, and Equipment. Even with the very best of intentions, engagements run the risk of causing unintended consequences, expressions can accidentally offend, education engagements can offer incorrect information, enforcements can backfire, and even simple deployments of equipment and affordances can cause truly unexpected outcomes. Additionally, even with the very best of intentions, engagements also run the risk of doing nothing at all. In order to ensure rapid response to blowback as well as lack of impact, it is important to update methods of exploration in response to newly considered engagements by asking the question: “How will we measure impact?”

a. Expressions

Expressions include messaging, slogans, and all forms of media deployed by the campaign. While planning expressions in advance is helpful, it’s far more important to be ready to adapt in response to feedback and new developments. Each expression deployed by the campaign should be cataloged in order to prevent contradictions and lend context to data analysis on the campaigns impacts. While all other categories are likely accompanied by or composed of expressions, it’s important to make them accessible as one catalog.

b. Education

Education engagements are engagements which come in the form of workshops, informative content, and training materials. Educational deployments are difficult as they often require work and acceptance on the part of the target audience in order to be effective. Educational engagements with hostile or uninterested target audiences are likely to fail and may be better off being adapted and reallocated to adjacent audiences which are more likely to engage. Care should be taken in designing the feedback and data collection methods to measure impacts.

Serious Games: Some educational deployments are disguised in other forms to prompt engagement, such as games—a method which has steadily been growing in popularity with developments in the field of “serious games”. Serious games are games which are built to serve purposes other than entertainment, some are identifiable as games, some

may not be. Key examples include fold.it, a puzzle game that crowd-sources training data for protein folding modeling in biology and EVE Online’s mini-game “Project Discovery”, built by MMOS (Massively Multiplayer Online Science), in which players of the space-faring online game interpret real astronomical data in order to get in-game benefits. While these games are a means of enabling citizen-science, others may focus more on helping their target audiences understand the impacts of difficult to understand phenomena such as redistrictinggame.org’s attempt to make the process and impact of gerrymandering and redistricting easy to understand.

c. Enforcement

Enforcements are engagements made with the target audience through setting or successfully lobbying for the setting of rules and regulations, terms and conditions, and legal or quasi-legal actions in order to influence the target audience. Enforcements should always be considered carefully as they have the highest potential for blowback to the campaign and can often simply harden the target audience into a certain view if the enforcement isn’t considered fair or reasonable.

Vaccine (and Related Speech) Enforcement: The origin of the quote “Your liberty to swing your fist ends just where my nose begins” is uncertain, but it is widely looked to in attempting to make sense of the limitations of personal liberty—but is swinging a fist comparable with being unvaccinated on public transit? The answer to this is clearly not a simple yes, as the precedents set in response to COVID-19 can be used and misused in the future in response to other illnesses. With such high levels of polarization, every attempt at deploying or lobbying for an enforcement must be approached with serious caution and long consideration for the narrative within the target audience, whether it be as benign as a forum moderation rule or as serious as a vaccine passport requirement for travel.

d. Equipment

Some narrative campaigns don’t rely on messaging at all, instead focusing on the provision of digital affordances, direction toward logistical support, creation of social and physical structures, and the deployment of physical equipment. In cases where messaging and education are likely to be ineffective and enforcements are likely to create blowback, the provision of equipment and digital affordance may be notably more impactful.

Hodology: A great deal of our decision-making isn’t just risk-driven but also affordance driven and related to path-finding. The (rather obscure) field of Hodology deals with our navigation of decision-making in terms of a direct mapping to path-finding in physical space, and is often applied in the study of game design. Reduction of

uncertainty regarding the path to vaccination may have just as much, if not more, impact than a messaging campaign intended to reduce uncertainty about the vaccine itself—especially if the target audience is resistant to messaging.

(4) Accelerants

Accelerants are events and phenomena that may accelerate either the crystallization of a Barrier or the sharing of messaging that expresses it. Identifying potential accelerants in advance can help the campaign prepare anticipatory defenses and responses. While using different terms, political campaigns have a long history of conducting opposition research on their own candidates as often as they conduct opposition research on their actual opposition, this allows the campaign to “prebunk” or prepare responses to potential information leaks or events. Not all potential accelerants can be predicted, but those which are likely should certainly be cataloged and considered. Accelerants are broken into 4 categories: Accidents, Attacks, Acts of Nature, and Acts of Algorithms.

Prebunking?

Prebunking is the act of “debunking in advance”. It is a critical tool because there is a first-mover advantage in narrative influence: messaging deployed prior to an event is substantially different to messaging deployed in reaction to it. This is especially the case for counter-messaging. Breaking down or fact checking potential negative interpretations prior to an event is far more likely to have impact and avoid blowback than it would if done reactively.

a. Accidents

Accidents are broadly classified in this framework as unintentional acts or the unintended consequences of intended acts made by individuals, institutions, and the campaign itself. Considering the accidents which may occur that would cause acceleration of the barrier and message-sharing allows for the deployment of messaging in advance that either indicates its possibility and thus decreases the severity of the surprise that may accompany the event itself or helps reduce the perceived relationship between the event and the barrier therefore reducing the acceleration after the events occurrence.

Vaccine Mishaps: Accidents are not unknown to happen in even quite routine manufacture, distribution, and deployment of vaccines. For example, the accidental contamination of Haemophilus influenzae type b vaccines with the bacteria B. Cereus, or recall of HPV vaccines due to glass particles ending up in vaccine vials. The 2021 rollout of COVID-19 vaccines is the most complicated vaccine rollout in human history, accidents should be expected, and any narrative campaign being conducted during this time should strongly consider the potential accidents that may occur during the length of the campaign and afterward.

b. Attacks

In this framework, attacks are classified as the intentional acts of individuals and institutions intending to stabilize or accelerate the sharing of messages about the barriers being considered by the campaign, generate undesired attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions in the target audience, or reduce the effectiveness of engagements with the target audience. Some attacks may be launched by competing or adversarial campaigns. It is essential that the campaign identify potential adversarial campaigns and the attacks they may launch during the campaign's progress in order to prepare (this is discussed in detail in this Field Guide's section: "Adversarial Campaigns").

c. Acts of Nature

Acts of nature refer to events that are not directly caused by the conscious actions of individuals or institutions, that may accelerate barriers and messaging sharing about them all the same. These may be difficult to predict, but are important to consider as some may emerge quickly that are worth prebunking developing anticipatory responses to.

Paranoia and Uncertainty: Uncertainty and structural complexity is an accelerant for paranoia and over-emphasis on threat detection. There are many events that could broadly be considered "acts of nature" that will influence decision making regarding vaccination. For example, a string of mysterious deaths in any place with a vaccine roll-out is likely to prompt well-meaning and adversarial messaging alike on the potential link to the roll-out.

d. Acts of Algorithms

Acts of algorithms are an accelerant unique to our modern world. Many of the algorithms dictating our message and news feeds do not have a strict business-logic in their curation, but instead are based on AI models that are un-auditable and have behaviors that may be mysterious even to their creators. It is important to consider where algorithms such as curation AI may have impacts on your campaign or on the target audience and how these impacts can be circumvented, planned for, or even intentionally altered.

4. Adversarial Campaigns

The modern information space is vastly more voluminous than is possibly imaginable. As a crude measure, researchers offer that 44 Billion gigabytes of data were being produced across the internet daily in 2016—increasing to 463 Billion in 2019. Rising sharply as a function of the interconnectedness and relative ubiquity of networked devices, the information space has become as much a tribute to the collaborative and ingenuitive capabilities of our species as it has an unwieldy and treacherous place rife with content capable of provoking the very worst of our instincts and behaviors.

This interconnectedness and ambiguity in this complex information space means we are not yet very good at discerning the roots of techno-social phenomena. Heuristic observation of what results from conspiracy theory, errant falsehood, and propagation of mis and disinformation is often the only viable mechanism we have in our search for contributing factors and the underlying mechanisms and phenomena which define any particular event—from election matters to emergent swarm activity (e.g. GameStop, internet vigilantism, and twitter mobs). In investigating these heuristic observations, using OSINT techniques and intuition—during postmortems of these events, those in the information warfare space may often come across fairly certain “tells” or signs that threat actors were involved. For those not in the Information Warfare space, the questions are:

- Who are the threat actors?
- How do we define them?

In information warfare (and information security), threat actors are defined as entities that are responsible for incidents that impact or have the potential to impact the information environment—entities which engage in activities which are intended to destabilize or negatively affect the quality or security of a space or extract information from it that they were not permissioned to access. In the information environment which exists on social media, threat actors introduce or, more often, amplify conspiracy-related or dis- and misinformation materials as a basis for destabilization.

Threat Actor or Civilian?

Counter-terrorism operations over the years have run into a very serious problem: terrorist groups aren't just hardening and becoming more resilient with more decentralized logistics, administration, and operations, but also becoming more and more difficult to separate from civilians. Operations in coastal cities offer violent extremists to blend with and access funding from organized crime and organized crime blends

with civilians, leaving boundaries between the groups increasingly unclear.

On social media, the boundaries are even less clear—many of the actions taken in the information space by threat actors are virtually the same as those taken by civilians, are not illegal, and often have network impacts that incentivize other civilians to replicate the actions and become unintentional threat actors themselves. The notable difference is usually in coordination and strategic intent.

Modern Narrative Campaigns will have to reckon with the fact that they will never be alone in attempting to modify the sensemaking of their target audience. While some external campaigns may be well-aligned or even coordinated with your own, most will not be and as such run the risk of becoming intentionally or unintentionally adversarial. In this new environment, many types of actors have to be considered—some are coordinated and planned, some are emergent and have impacts similar to planned campaigns.

4.1. Conspiracy Theories and Conspiracism

Conspiracy theories often act as centers of gravity for emergent or swarm-like narrative campaigns with which other campaigns may have to contend. Fundamentally, conspiracy theories are stories, typically with some element of rational plausibility, which propagate almost autonomously, due to certain values they possess—entertainment value, validation of hostility or distrust toward some target entity, and/or the provision of a feeling of being informed or of belonging to a group. Anxiety, fear of authoritarianism, distrust, negative emotions, and mental or physical health status all have notable impacts on their acceptance. Due to their nature and the public stigmatization of many of conspiracy theory related material, accepting these theories often provides an individual with a community, further reinforcing its acceptance and providing onramps to adjacent, often more extreme ideas.

The expression “conspiracy theory” however, due to its use as a pejorative to dismiss ideas, has become a bit unwieldy or loose in terms of its definition—here a few brief clarifications are provided.

Conspiracy Theory vs Conspiracy Hypothesis

There is a notable difference between conspiracy theories and conspiracy hypotheses. Hypotheses are *proposed* explanations for phenomena based on reasoning and logic which considers available evidence, established theories, anomalies, and observations—saying something *might* be the case, is substantially different than saying something *is*. On the other hand, theories are explanations for phenomena that are substantiated through notable evidence and, in the case of repeatable phenomena: predictive value.

- Sometimes paranoia is well-justified and labeling all speculation regarding the potential for conspiratorial factors can mislead and drive interest. Hostile counter-messaging in response to reasoned speculation will reliably provoke blowback or, depending on the organization or individual counter-messaging, further reinforce the speculation.
- There are “good” conspiracy theories and “bad” conspiracy theories. For example, in the US, Watergate, Tuskegee, and Iran-Contra are examples of events which have well-substantiated conspiracy theories.
- Many conspiracy hypotheses/theories are accepted because they’re built on truth—often an individual discovered they had been lied to about some other phenomena, leaving them asking “What else?”. When considering how to impact a target audience associated with a conspiracy theory, be sure to investigate the other theories they accept and see if there is a logical order to their acceptance.

Conspiracy Theory vs Conspiracism

Simply labeling some stories as “conspiracy theories” may make them more difficult to respond to, as some of these stories aren’t supported just by information specific to one event, but instead supported by a general worldview. Further, that worldview may be something closer to an embrace of folk-lore than a reasoned philosophy. Conspiracism is a term which has been given definitions used to address these two cases in different communities:

- **Conspiracism as Folklore.** Similar to a conspiracy theory, but often with less plausibility and thought to be more about blind assertions. Their fitness is generally linked to already extant views and the size of and stability of communications within communities which hold those views. Conspiracisms tend to spread in a similar way to folklore, as a consequence, they are even more difficult to source and attribute than common conspiracy theories. The most notable examples include “stories” in the UFO community and, more recently QAnon, with “Q” being cloaked in folkloric legend, offering revelations and prophecies from the shadows.

- Attempting to impact these forms of conspiracisms with counter-messaging is likely folly

- Folk-lore like structure means impacting symbols is likely the most effective method of disruption

- **Conspiracism as Worldview.** A meta-outlook similar to the philosophy of political realism. Where political realism sees the world as a series of geopolitical entities acting with *raison d'état*, or a risk calculus built on the objectives of the state, conspiracism is a view in which the world is composed of interwoven webs of conspiracies and mystery cults from the birth of civilization to today. It may be an outlook that views this from an anthropological lens, suggesting that humans tend to conspire when incentives are right, or it may be tied to the mal-intent of a specific group. Key examples of the latter include worldviews that place the Jews, Royal Families, or the Illuminati as prime, coordinated, intergenerational groups managing world affairs from the shadows.

- Attempting to impact these forms of conspiracisms with evidence about particular events is not effective

- Philosophical structure means channeling individuals to adjacent, plausible, and less extreme world-views is likely the most effective method of disruption

4.2. State-Actors: Planning Campaigns

It can be helpful to consider how campaigns are planned, from an information warfare perspective, in order to contend with them more easily.

Planning for information operations campaigns involves detailed work on the information environment—studying geopolitical circumstances with natural “attack surface” lending to plausible information injects. Ultimately, the broader desired end-state and the potentially promising and actionable environments to conduct information warfare will be considered and selected by parent organizations, while the work of detailing the nature of the campaign and tasking out actions is performed by staff or task forces. There is a great deal of planning and carefully coordinated mission execution used to achieve desired objectives. Such “information operations campaigns” are well informed and well-planned activities which require deliberate and focused planning and are typically approved at very high levels of government—particularly in Russia, where such activities are managed by the three major intelligence agencies: the SVR, FSB, and paramilitary/special force GRU.

All actions are done with the highest degree of operational security in order to avoid evidence of their activity, and maintain highest degrees of plausible deniability. To this end the objectives of these kinds of campaigns are not to simply blast messaging or “drop pamphlets”, but to have messaging picked up and repeated by actors outside of the source organization. The best-case scenario is the messaging being picked up and curated by a large news organization, but often just as much impact can be made by having the messaging get curated by newsfeed algorithms on social media. The higher the profile of the echoes (see discussion of Echoes in the Narrative Analysis section’s SEE-A Narrative Framework subsection) of the campaign’s messaging, the more the campaign is thought to be successful. Initial messages themselves are spread by bots and aliases.

Scottish Independence Referendum

As an example of progress toward a desired end-state, consider the circumstances of the Scottish independence referendum of 2014. Russians were highly active on social media spreading articles to persuade Scotland to leave the UK. This activity is thought to have caused a significant effect in terms of affecting the voting turnout and mindset, and is also thought to have been a runup and rehearsal for the Brexit referendum that followed where the Russians greatly increased their social media presence.

AI and AP

While AI and bots are always a popular choice for rapid and swarm messaging, they are not great for handling any sort of interactive engagements with the target audience and thus often have trouble developing the influence on social media necessary to build traction for messaging. Alias Personae (AP) are used instead for developing this kind of influence and bots can then help amplify it. AP are carefully constructed fake identities, often enriched with stories referred to as “legends” and complementary elements to back them up on numerous social media platforms or sites. AP may have high degrees of detail, such as government credentials and financial capabilities. The more complex the AP, the more capable it is of building a presence on the internet and conducting any number of activities with witting and unwitting persons or entities. The AP serves as a key mechanism for delivering disinformation, where particularly Russian actors develop characters which engender trust from unwitting people in true name on the internet, offering passive or active dissemination of content.

Although we don't know enough about stated objectives, it is important to “think big” and not underestimate state actors. A logical continuation of Russia's interest in the US, for example, could very well be a multi-epoch campaign to simply cause our two-party system to create enough friction—doing and undoing policies, creating a destructive vacillation across the populace and institutions of government—in other words a distinct continuation of the USSR's intergenerational “water on a stone” strategy which was built on early concepts of complexity science and cybernetics: no single message introduced into a system will undo the system, it is about sparking feedback loops and patterns of messaging. The predicted increases in polarization would ultimately cause the US to collapse in internal matters, all with the same insidious rhythm and plodding course used to influence the fall of the Soviet Union.

Exploiting the information space and its effects on humans is, and will continue to be, the focus of different classes of actors who view the average person as a target—some more parasitically oriented for profit or notoriety, some for well-meaning intents, and others aiming for specific and nefarious end-states aligned with the interests of foreign powers, criminal syndicates or other threat actors. It is important that any narrative campaign be aware of the adversaries that are present in the space in which they'd like to make impacts, as **being ignorant of those adversaries may not just mean inefficacy, it may also mean taking actions that those adversaries will use against the campaign, directly or indirectly.**

4.3. Actors to Consider

There are many actors that may be considered adversarial to your campaign, and it's valuable to scope which types of actors should be prioritized as preparing for all of them may simply be overwhelming.

4.3.1. State Actors

State-Actors are increasingly becoming more organized and investing heavily in the ability to wage large scale information warfare, seeking an asymmetric advantage over other nation states by influencing their populations. At this time, at least 70 nations are known to be actively engaged in media manipulation. Nation state treatment of the COVID information environment varies between China, Venezuela, Iran, and others.

(1) Russia

Among threat actors in the information warfare space, Russia is the most pointed and active disinformation aggressor. Focusing on Russia lends itself to the richest discussion, because their intent and complex approach has been refined over decades and has exponentially improved as a consequence of its prioritization by President Putin—a former intelligence officer who sees the flow of information in the context of his academic work on the flow of mineral resources. In addition, it is especially important to discussions on information warfare in the West because these approaches and their implementation likely pose the most easily identifiable, adversarial threat to Western democracy and stability, at least in the near-term. Where China, Venezuela, Iran, and other adversaries are primarily concerned with internal politics and matters of the populace, Russia is more offensively focused, seeking to settle old Cold War scores, and ultimately conquer former soviet bloc states—evidence of which is available in observation of their ongoing activities in Ukraine and past aggressions in Georgia, Estonia, and more recently during the 2016 US election.

Researchers and analysts have been studying Russian Information Warfare strategies, tactics, units, and broader capabilities which have provided the Russian state important advantages. The Russian case highlights complex, integrated thinking, planning, and maneuvers orchestrated by three distinct units:

SVR

The Russian Foreign Intelligence Service (SVR). The SVR (in Russian, Sluzhba vneshney razvedki Rossiyskoy Federatsii) operates internationally and executes lines of

effort across matters of state, particularly espionage and opposition research matters known as kompromat.

FSB

The Russian Federal Security Service (FSB). The FSB (in Russian, Federal'naya sluzhba bezopasnosti Rossiyskoy Federatsii) functions as the internally-focused intelligence apparatus of the Russian state, similar to the US FBI, but with vast surveillance mandates consistent with the tenets of the authoritarian Russian state.

GRU

Main Directorate of the General Staff of the Armed Forces of the Russian Federation (GU, or more commonly known as GRU). GRU (in Russian, Glavnoye Razvedyvatel'noye Upravleniye) is a component of the Russian military which works in conjunction with paramilitary and intelligence agencies to present cyber and information warfare capability against military objectives and associated targets.

(2) China

China's PLA (People's Liberation Army) now has doctrine which embraces "Systems Destruction Warfare". In PLA doctrine war is redefined as confrontations between systems, rather than between national militaries, uniting all methodologies, both kinetic and nonkinetic, in pursuit of the same goal: disruption and paralysis of the enemy system. The PLA was primarily focused on domestic Chinese platforms, such as Weibo and WeChat, until the protests in Hong Kong connected Western influence to impacts close to home—they now have a notable interest in the use of Western platforms such as Facebook and Twitter. China now leverages Government assets, politicians, and private contractors as well as influencers and companies tied to the CCP (Chinese Communist Party) in order to suppress and amplify information abroad.

China stands apart from other state actors for several reasons. First, is the sheer size of their personnel involved in the space—indicating a true embrace of their systems-oriented doctrine. They are estimated to have as many as 2 million individuals involved in cyber operations and media manipulation. Next is China's use of companies and civil institutions abroad in order to amplify, suppress, and gain access to information, for example, their "Chinese Schools" in Cambodia or "Confucius Schools" in the United States. Finally, is the use of their "Water Armies", which large groups of individuals paid to ghostwrite or post information on specific issues with specific views in order to suppress genuine discussion or for the sake of being able to report on "broad praise" by elements of the public.

4.3.2. Non-State Actors

These are interest groups which are not established by, nor acting on behalf of a government. Causes range from political, religious, moral, ethical, etc. It is important to make categorical distinctions between them, because the medium of exchange between these groups and target audiences is not as discernible in nature and character as is physical violence. **As such, it is equally important to avoid drawing moral equivalences between non-state actors on the basis of their belonging to a common category.**

(1) Terrorists and Insurgents

These are individuals or groups of people inciting or employing violence or conducting nefarious activity in order to effectuate a desired outcome commonly related to political or religious matters. Doctrinal definitions of terrorists and terrorist organizations are best drawn from Irregular Warfare, and the specific focus of this subject matter extends those definitions with respect to the use of force to achieve desired effects. Terrorists and terrorist organizations are commonly declared by nation-states (as enemies of the state). At this time, there are no declared terrorist organizations which operate exclusively in the information or cyberspace domains. Rather, entities such as Al Qaeda and ISIL are established, surveilled, and engaged based on their physical violence actions or propensities. Terrorists often augment their actions with metaphysical enhancements, traditionally in the form of written propaganda.

The Internet has, of course, offered new means for terrorists to publish their message. Al Qaeda's (AQAP) "Inspire" Magazine, for example, provides an array of messaging. Terrorist social media presence is harder to manage, since the groups represented are actively hunted by intelligence agencies and other government apparatuses. ISIS and other insurgent and terrorist organizations have moved to the social media space as a basis for recruiting and spreading propaganda. Much of this messaging is distributed rather than centralized and not attributed to these groups as they often use more widely accepted anti-Western messages in public postings but use direct reach outs in private messages as a basis for sharing more extreme messages based on engagement with public content. Occasionally, more centralized messaging is used and is usually paired with violent content such as beheadings, which often cause these messages to go viral and be widely disseminated and discussed, on and off social media.

Cyber Caliphate

The cyber caliphate is a group of Islamic State affiliated hackers, also known as the Islamic Cyber Army (ICA) or Islamic State Hacking Division (ISHD). It has a track record of running operations which are in the gray zone between traditional cyber

warfare and narrative campaigns. For example, their attacks on US Central Command were obviously not intended to do any direct damage to their operations, targeting aspects of their operations visible to the public in order to damage perception of US cybersecurity capabilities. They often assist in the release and placement of violent content and with the production of kill-lists by hacking websites, stealing data, and mining social media in order to intimidate civilians.

(2) Activist Groups and Emergent Collectives

Activist Groups are somewhat easier to define and important to delineate from terrorist groups, but can become extremely difficult to categorize when their activities begin to include planned and premeditated acts of physical violence, physical threats, or associations with organizations that do. However, metaphysical force in the form of propaganda and some forms of cyberattack and cyber-harassment are common among them. Activist Groups are important to consider because, as a consequence of the space they occupy, they may take actions which your campaign will have to respond to. For example, they may hijack and borrow elements of your narrative campaign, doing damage even when they are not attempting to act in opposition.

Activist Groups tend to be influential on social media and can therefore leverage a great deal of power in influencing how elements of your campaign will be interpreted and shared. Due to their tendency to seed and support smaller organizations and chapters, and the tendency of these smaller sects to fracture or go unsupervised by the parent organization—**discussion of groups in these categories can be quite difficult and often contentious, especially as smaller sects realign without a parent organization.**

Cyber Harassment and Doxxing

Cyber harassment comes in many forms, but is most commonly enacted through the direction of distributed behavior like twitter mobs, where individuals call for the firing or deplatforming of individuals en masse (known as “canceling”) and through more direct means such as “doxxing”, in which an individual’s identity or personal details (such as address or place of work) are released in order to enable both distributed and directed harassment and vigilantism.

Emergent Collectives are not a new phenomenon, but are certainly more common now than ever before given the presence of digital affordances. Generally, emergent collectives align on narrative and ontology but do not use formal rosters or memberships, making them difficult to observe or report on. They are often deeply intertwined with the activities of activist groups, making it very difficult to place responsibility on activities while taking advantage of support and more widely

disseminated branding and messages. As can be seen from the history of social-action and change movements, it is all too common that smaller sub-organizations, chapters, and sects splinter, fracture, and reform—often as leaderless cells. These cells, as noted, may maintain the messages and guiding principles of the original organization, but may begin to use tactics that their original organizations could not possibly use due to legal ramifications and restrictions. Greenpeace’s Paul Watson, a co-founder of the organization which later had to remove him and denounce him as a violent extremist, is a key example of this. **When reading this section, do not assume any moral equivalence between the groups noted or any prioritization based on the order of their listing—these are simply examples provided to offer some context on the nature of emergent collectives and activist groups, and their impacts on national narratives.**

(a) US Militia and Right-Wing Groups

Militia Groups and Right-Wing Groups are now numerous and have had notable impacts on narratives within the United States, Germany, and other nations. The groups in the US are diverse in their ideology and lack any central parent organizations between them. The grouping of these groups into one category has created a great number of misunderstandings and misattributions—similar to those which may occur in discussion of Antifa and Black Lives Matter. Detailing every group in this space would require its own report, but prominent organizations include the Civilian Defense Force, Oath Keepers, Three Percenters, Proud Boys, Patriot Prayer, and the Boogaloo Bois. Most activity in this sphere has been reactionary, responding to social justice activism, COVID-19 related and other Government enforcements, perceived threats to freedom of speech, and election related concerns. The combination of poor categorization of these groups with the limited observability of the materials they circulate has and continues to cause messaging which has caused accelerations and blowback.

The information environment that these groups occupy is difficult to observe and navigate. While they align on some key issues, they are not well-aligned on ideological grounds. Some have friendly attitudes toward law enforcement, some are libertarian, some are true-to-form white nationalists, some have embraced specific conspiracy theories while some groups claim these same theories are Government psychological operations campaigns or nonsense, and some are attempting to accelerate societal collapse while others are attempting to prevent it. As such, organizations within the space will coordinate on specific actions on those issues on which they align, but do not have any bridge or association organizations that act as parent or sponsor. Often, actions attributed to them may just be those of emergent collectives which may include members but then cannot easily be attributed to decisions by any central organization.

The Boogaloo Bois may be the most concrete example of the difficulty of attribution, observability, and categorization. In many ways—they defy categorization. Membership is not centralized and the only required alignment would appear to be the belief of a

coming civil war following gun confiscation, an event referred to as “Civil War 2: Electric Boogaloo”. As a result, there are sub-chapters which espouse neo-Nazi and white nationalist views yet a great deal of boogaloo related content builds on content released by Black Lives Matter, as the two groups align on excessive use of force by police. Even the notion of them being a single organization is up for debate, with some experts suggesting that they are instead, an emergent collection of small groups and individuals rallying around ideology and shared concern.

After the US Capitol occupation on January 6th, 2021, it is clear that the messaging shared by these and adjacent groups is impactful and cannot be ignored.

(b) QAnon

In common usage, QAnon refers to a conspiracy theory, a cult built around a conspiracy theory, or the alleged individual at the center of said theory or cult. The theory suggests that an organized network of pedophiles exists at the highest levels of the Government and media. Originally, it centered around releases by an “individual” posting on message boards under the handle “Q”, that claimed to have Q-level clearance. While the nature of QAnon is highly debated, it could be argued that it eventually became a collection of individuals supported by a large, emergent collective that shared, discussed, and amplified their messages as well as performed poor-quality OSINT—forming connections between phenomena and events in order to co-create a new, and semi-structured form of conspiracism (see discussion of Conspiracisms in this Section). Like most conspiracisms, this world-view was blended with many truths and half-truths, and contained a great deal of onboarding material that allowed it to become plausible to a surprisingly large group of people. When combined with President Donald Trump’s amplifying of some of their messages, foreign interference, validation of some of their concerns due to media bias, and the sustained stresses put on the United States during the first waves of the pandemic, this movement grew disproportionately large relative to similar conspiracisms. Their messaging has had massive impacts on national narratives, and indicates a very serious need for cognitive security and new digital affordances for collective sensemaking.

(c) Antifa (Anti-Fascists and BlackBlock)

Antifa is an example of an emergent collective. Misunderstandings about the nature of emergent collectives and the political nature of their activities has made discussion about them incredibly contentious and polarizing, to such an extent that their very existence is debated. Even the FBI is having trouble communicating about Antifa—while their director has publicly stated that Antifa is an ideology not an organization, the FBI also confirms that Antifa extremists and supporters are subjects of ongoing domestic terrorism investigations. Their status as an emergent collective means that

when we speak about “Antifa”, we’re speaking about clear examples of coordinated action, alignment on narrative, shared literature, messages, and symbols, and the individuals and groups involved in these processes, rather than about some central organization with logistical and administrative aspects.

While highly decentralized and being composed of mostly autonomous groups, members have aligned on OPSEC principles, narrative, and symbols. Key narrative elements and principles being derived from anarchism, socialism, communism, environmentalism, and vigilantism. Some of these autonomous groups were pre-existing and have integrated into the movement, while others have formed in response to messaging from other chapters—but many do not refer to themselves as being a part of this distributed network or use the term Antifa. Distributed literature and shared memes make suggestions such as:

- Fundraising and promotional events to recruit members
- Intelligence collection and monitoring of groups and individuals who are hostile to the movement
- Making use of rallies held by like-minded organizations
- Defacing publicly posted symbols of hostile outgroups
- Doxxing, releasing the photographs, social media profiles, phone numbers, addresses, and employers of individuals who are hostile to Antifa
- Compelling organizations to deplatform individuals and to encourage adjacent communities to do the same
- Dearresting and reducing impact of police activity
- Developing a coordinated social media presence to promote Antifa views, reduce impact of anti-Antifa content, and amplify impacts of doxing

The literature and memes also offer tactics and strategies for OPSEC: hiding illegal activity, making reporting on Antifa difficult, and preventing identity leaks within their own community. Despite not having a central organization, these OPSEC practices make it as difficult to track the impact of emergent and distributed narrative campaigns by Antifa as it is to track those of state actors. More centralized messaging channels such as the RUST (Remote Uprising Support Team) channels do not use the term Antifa and generally adhere, as suggested above, to OPSEC related messaging protocols, some borrowed from the military, to prevent reporting, discovery, and incrimination. Further exacerbating observability and plausible deniability of the movement, potentially emergent “shout-about” campaigns encourage civilians to post the phrase “I am anti-fascist”, “I am Antifa”, and “#Antifa” on social media.

(d) BLM (Black Lives Matter)

BLM has had its messages amplified by everything from government agencies to multinational corporations and has seen support offered by large swathes of the American public. It is a formal organization sponsored by Thousand Currents, an organization which provides funding, administrative, logistical, and networking support to a number of political action groups. While having a formal, central organization, it appears that the communities and chapters which use their branding, messaging, and support are encouraged to not maintain or develop any centralized leadership or administrative capability.

Unfortunately, this has meant that many leaderless cells have embraced far more radical views and interwoven themselves into communications channels with Antifa and anarchist organizations. These private communications channels are known to be used to plan acts of vandalism and violence against Government Employees and Police as well as property and counter-protesters. These communications channels blur the lines between BLM and Antifa groups and between the individuals involved and the actual collectives. Material is shared on these channels which sometimes condones violence, shares tactics, and helps protect the members from being labeled a part of coordinated action—embracing a doctrine of “swarm tactics” of which the bee is a chosen symbol. Despite individuals affiliated with chapters of these groups being involved in the siege of a Portland Federal Building, the capture of a police station, and other acts in this vein, actions which fit the U.S. State Department’s definitions of terrorism, neither group has been declared a terrorist organization in the US and whether they will or should be is highly contentious. Similar to the situation regarding right-wing militias, there is a great deal of plausible deniability and legitimate absence of organizational responsibility due to the lack of central control over semi-anonymous smaller groups which operate with shared slogans, brands, and messaging but do not maintain any formal relationships or organizations.

(3) Advertisers and Opportunists

This broader category pertains to organizations focused on profitability or similarly harvested value (attention, brand recognition), particularly the realization of a tangible and profitable end-state. Actors with these intentions may believe in their message, or may be passively involved in it, but are guided by their interest in developing advantages for themselves or a broader entity such as a corporation.

There are many examples of how companies might misuse the information space in order to achieve their desired end-state, but among the most relevant for this discussion are social media companies which have designed algorithms to curate online content in ways that feature compelling elements to broad audiences, and then refine curation in order to compel what become target audiences—all with the aim of keeping the audience engaged on their platform. This can occur passively as a viewer dwells on a certain video, whereupon the algorithmically-designed curation service makes a calculation that the video is “interesting” to the viewer, and then queues up similar

content—all intended to keep the viewer’s attention, and to create conditions where the viewer interacts with the platform by selecting other videos, clicking advertisements, and providing inputs that help characterize their preferences such as “likes” or upvotes associated with the platform.

Provocateurs and opportunists not otherwise defined. These actors perform what could be thought of as the manual form of the aforementioned algorithms—curating content and developing messaging, actively promoting both in order to discover a target audience, then refining curation and messaging shaping to increase and maintain viewership on television, radio, and of course across the internet and social media environments. The most active and successful characters in this space such as Alex Jones and his Infowars platform emphasize messaging which attempts to use fear and uncertainty as a basis to hold attention and sell products.

There are simpler versions of these kinds of agents who focus on their notoriety as a specified value of itself—influencers or more broadly-defined thought-leaders who carry a large following, and whose tweets or periodic writings are echoed by a fanbase, but which may not lead to sponsorships or endorsements. These actors tend to be ego-driven, and the attention is enough to keep them engaged. Notably, these actors are among the most interesting from an “attack surface” standpoint, because of their egoistic orientation to the information space, and because there are no other matters of value such as endorsements which could be lost or used as leverage in order to shape behavior of the actor. Rather, this actor gains and maintains followers through offering their base something interesting—a vector which could be exploited.

Alias Personae and Influencers

One such exploitation thread which has been used is the false persona making contact with an influencer on Twitter, posing as a journalist, offering an inside story to help the influencer solidify and/or broaden their base. The cloaked actor is an agent of a foreign power, using the vector to inject propaganda into a target audience, leveraging the trust of the influencer. A successful tactic used in conjunction with this aforementioned schema is to then bring a high volume of false personae to bear as audience, working alongside successful organic reflections of the planted information in order to boost the presence of a message, increasing the chances of natural propagation on a large scale (e.g. going viral).

(4) Referral/Curation Algorithms and AI

While referral and curation algorithms have been discussed in other sections, it is important to recognize them as a category of actors in and of themselves. This is

perhaps an unusual choice for an actor, but algorithms are increasingly becoming active and vitally important players in audience experience, narrative development, and decision-making. It is important to understand and consider them as non-passive actors. Algorithms are human constructions with a strategic purpose that decide and act and evolve based on that purpose and outside inputs. In this way, they are very similar to any other of the more traditional institutional actors above. As with all of the above actors, they can also be influenced and countered, and must be both understood and considered for any effective modern Narrative Campaign.



5. Planning Tools

Historically, campaigns would often see their “success” measured in terms of the efficacy of the deployment, relying on metrics such as visibility, reach, and scheduling targets—this is partially a consequence of campaigns being static, heavily scheduled deployments but also a consequence of impact being much more difficult to map to the deployments themselves. The modern information environment campaigns operate in afford them many more opportunities to deploy content rapidly and adapt targeting and scheduling. As campaigns become more modular and adaptive, they can also become more difficult to scope and as such, easily fall victim to mission creep. In addition, the broad range of options means mapping tasks to expertise and capability can also be difficult. This section provides some easy-to-implement tools for setting goals and planning campaigns.

5.1. EBO Planning

EBO or “Effects Based Operations”, is a process of planning narrative campaigns which focuses on the selection of a set of actions which contribute to desired and undesired effects. It is generalizable to all forms of course of action (COA) planning, and was developed to aid in COA planning in military operations. The complexity of large scale and coalition military operations and the introduction of systems warfare doctrine has necessitated new methods to consider the full spectrum of options available. EBO Planning methods have a number of different method-sets associated with them, some highly technical and use-case specific. In the case of considering COA analysis in influence operations or kinetic operations with an influence component, systems modeling software have been introduced, using “influence nets” built on Bayesian probability models in order to regularly update expectations and inform action during simulations and the operation itself.

The generalized format described below can be used and adapted for the effects-based planning of narrative campaigns.

EBO Problem

The first step of EBO planning is the answering of the question: “what effects are needed”. The set of desired and undesired effects on the adversary are collected and then reverse engineered to consider what actions the campaign might have at its disposal in order to realize these effects. In the military, this activity is managed by intelligence, operations, and situation analysts. The output from this step should be a set of potential actions mapped to capabilities as well as desired and undesired effects.

COA Problem

The second step is the identification of the probabilities associated with the set of actions discovered in the prior steps. In doing so, it is important to map the temporality and chaining of actions (if “x” is done first, how does this affect the probability of “y”?) and to consider the operational aspects of any particular set of actions. The objective of this activity is to produce a series of potential COAs for review.

ISR Problem

The third step is to take the set of potential COAs, and then identify the observable phenomena that would likely be associated with each COA, and to then map the observables to sense-capabilities and measurements. These sense-capabilities may be electronic sensors, surveillance, reconnaissance, and other intelligence assets, or OSINT systems. The objective is to have a clear map of how operations associated with each COA would be monitored and what data would be available in evaluating the success of operations. At this stage, COAs may begin to evolve into much more detailed plans and those which have severe constraints in terms of monitoring may be removed.

Evaluation Problem

The fourth step is to take the developing COA models and consider the desired and undesired effects and their relationship with:

1. Available sense-data from monitoring capabilities,
2. Operational capabilities to achieve those effects,
3. and the Probabilities associated with the success and impacts of those operational capabilities.

The objective of this activity is to find the most viable and impactful COAs—those which maximize potential effects, reduce constraints, provide flexibility, and have high probabilities of success. There is also a secondary focus on finding contingency COAs in the case of failure. At this stage, COAs can now become operational plans—in some use-cases, the COA may be disseminated at this stage for feedback, consideration, and preparation purposes to the individuals and units that would be responsible for overseeing or carrying out the plan's actions and to the operational controllers who would be monitoring and managing the ingress of the sense-data relevant to operations. The output from this activity should be a curated list of detailed COAs.

Execution Assessment

Now that the most viable and impactful COAs have been curated, explanatory or computational systems models are generated from the results of the prior steps in order to allow for the measurement and calculation, simulation, or logical consideration of each of the COAs and their contingencies by stakeholders.

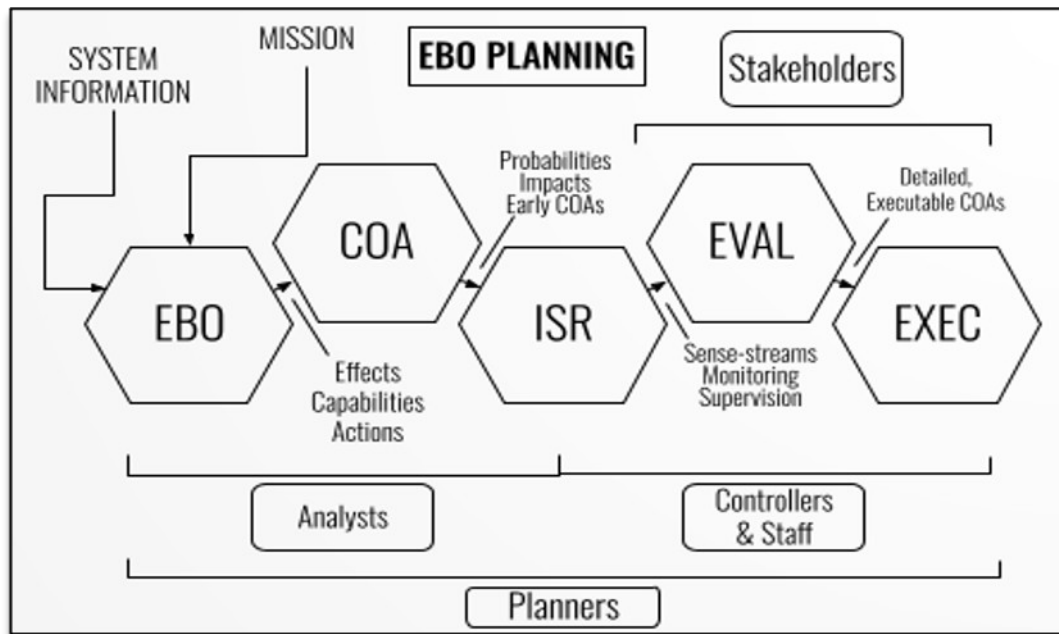


Figure 7. EBO Planning Diagram

5.2. AB Planning

AB Planning, or “Assumptions Based Planning” (ABP), is a very high-level approach to campaign planning generated by the RAND Corporation in the 1990s in response to the cascading breakdown in expectations and resulting uncertainty following the collapse of the Soviet Union. While its intended use-case was for large-scale military programs, it can be helpful to use in any endeavor in which scoping or missing drift are likely. ABP differs from other planning methodologies in that it is not meant to be used in the construction of plans from scratch, instead it is meant to be used to modify, adjust, and “reign in” existing strategies by focusing on the critique of assumptions. It takes an “ends-uncertain” approach, and as such, is best used when attempting to redefine or crystallize the goals and objectives of a campaign or reconsidering what mechanisms would be necessary for their realization.

It is intended to be carried out in 5 stages:

(1) Identification of Critical Assumptions

The first stage is the identification of the critical, underlying assumptions in an organization’s plan. This is not necessarily an easy task as organizations have a tendency to converge on these assumptions over the course of many meetings or engagements and consequently fail to declare them in a discoverable format. Further, where they do declare them, they may be declared in the form of “Enthymemes”—rhetorical syllogisms which may have assumptions built within them. The objective of this activity is to declare outright and in clear terms, the assumptions that underly the campaign’s objectives and operations.

(2) Identification of Vulnerability

The second stage is the identification of the assumptions which are most vulnerable. In complex environments with many moving pieces, confounding variables, and difficult-to-discover patterns, many of the assumptions may be contradictory or be dangerous to build upon given the level of environmental uncertainty. Any assumption which if found to be untrue or no longer viable would require a complete overhaul of the campaign or emergency response should be given additional weight—the vulnerability described in this context is in the relationship between an assumption’s vulnerability and the vulnerability of the campaign to change or failure of that assumption.

(3) Signposts

In the third stage, analysts may now begin to assign “signposts” to vulnerable assumptions. Signposts are intended to be a sort of short-report or brief about a particular vulnerability and are intended to be updated over time. As operations continue or get closer to deployment, the signpost is meant to rapidly apprise operations planners of the state of the assumption. In modern systems, signposts might be informed by data or AI systems.

(4) and (5) Shaping or Hedging Action

The fourth and fifth stages are denoted as the Shaping and Hedging of actions. Shaping actions are actions intended to influence the environment or operation in order to prevent the failure of an assumption or prevent the impact of its failure. Where shaping actions are proactive and anticipatory, hedging actions are generally more reactionary, and focus on insulating the operation from the impact of changes to the state of an assumption. The signposts of the previous stage are used as impetus for hedging actions.

5.3. Prometheus Process

Planning effective campaigns that are flexible, adaptive, and durable requires systems level thinking. To this end, strategists may look to Iceberg methodologies, OODA toolkits, the Cynefin Framework, or the multi-dimensional and complex Policy Sciences of Harold Lasswell. Here is presented a short summary of a planning process which incorporates much of Lasswell's effective comprehensiveness, the iterative nature of the OODA-loop, acknowledgement of the complexity addressed in Cynefin, and, while not as simple as Iceberg methodologies, is simple enough to pick up and implement quickly: The Prometheus Process.

John Warden, architect of the air strategy for the First Gulf War, and a leading influence on air warfare, developed the Prometheus Process to formalize the crafting of effective strategies for campaigns in complex environments, whether they be theater-level military campaigns, industrial technology and logistical roll-outs, or advertising campaigns. He defines campaigns as follows:

Campaigns are mechanisms or vehicles to pull everything together, to use the people, money, and other resources in our organization in order to affect the centers of gravity in order to change a system and bring it toward some desired state.

The Prometheus Process sees the following keys to campaign success in complex environments:

Harmonization

The strategies used should be consistent and should harmonize or synergize all of an organization's assets toward common goals.

Granularity

The strategies used should provide for "tactical granularity" or modularization of the campaign's elements, assets, and tactics.

Resilience

The strategies used should limit dependence on the success of any particular element and should include proactive and anticipatory consideration both for success and failure.

Adaptability

The strategies used should allow for flexibility and adaptation in the face of new threats. Contingencies that provide buffer-time for recalibration and adjustment should strongly be considered.

While the methodology has supplementary materials and recommendations, the Prometheus Process itself can be broken down into the asking of four simple questions:

Where do we want to be in the future? This question is meant to serve as a beacon in the future, a center of gravity for the strategy chosen and the harmony it is meant to facilitate. It should be clear, compelling, understandable, measurable, meaningful, and, as it is meant to be achieved in the real world, practical and set against timeframes.

What centers of gravity are you going to apply resources against? This question asks for the strategist to map the system which they intend to affect and to clearly define and declare its centers of gravity—where it is that impacts would have network-effects on the system.

How are you going to apply your resources? This question asks for the strategist to clearly define how resources will be applied and over what time scales they'll be deployed.

Are exit points and plans in place for everything? The final question in the Prometheus Process is what sets it apart from many other planning frameworks. It asks for proactive considerations and plans of both success and failure at every point in the campaign, not just at the end of it.

5.4. The Narrative Campaign Strategist's Catechism

Catechisms are traditionally a set of questions with predefined answers meant to stabilize religious doctrine in the narrative of the user by generating a scripted response to spiritual questions. However, in the late 20th Century, the concept of a catechism was adapted and the predefined answers removed in order to create project-planning documents. This adaptation was pioneered by DARPA director George Heilmeier in order to create a “pre-flight safety checklist” for research projects, the idea being: if you cannot answer this set of simple questions effectively, you are not ready to commit to the work being planned. Since that time, use-case specific catechisms and catechism-like documents have begun to emerge for other activities, such as Ed Waltz's Catechism for statistical modeling in intelligence analysis, the Facilitator's Catechism for emergent research teams, and the Innovator's Catechism for teams at hackathons and start-up weekends. Catechisms are useful because they ensure that plans can be easily compared and communicated. In addition they increase the observability of inconsistency or impracticality, allowing bad plans to fail fast. Depending on their structure, they can sometimes be filled out as part of the process of planning (rather than just documenting finished plans) and upon completion be rapidly rendered to a number of presentable formats such as NABC, Slide Decks, and Canvases. Catechisms are easy to adopt because they can be used alone but can also be used in conjunction with any particular planning framework your organization might already have before or after that planning framework has been used, adding value without requiring any overhaul of existing systems.

Here a Narrative Campaign Strategist's Catechism is presented, based on a catechism-like document for Influence Operations prepared for the U.S. Army with consideration of catechism-like documents from marketing, advertising, and political campaigns as well as recent research on the impact of catechism structure. It is composed of 13 main questions split into 3 sections which ask questions that demand clarity regarding the intents of the campaign, increase the observability of narrative of the target audience, and ask for the information necessary to choose methods prior to asking for the methods chosen:

Narrative Campaign Strategist's Catechism

Situation

1. What is the situation or opportunity the narrative campaign is being conducted in response to or in preparation for?

Mission

2. What is the desired end-state of the campaign?

Approach

3. Who is the relevant target audience?

4. What are the attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions within the target audience that are intended to be influenced or generated?

a. What are the relevant limiting factors on influence or generation of these attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions? (e.g. Religious fundamentalism, hostility, limited internet access)

b. Are these attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions an expression of an unmet need or intent of the target audience?

5. What sources and information channels are considered most credible by the target audience? Why?

a. Of these sources, which are most influential? Why?

6. What medium(s) and format(s) is the target audience most familiar with?

7. Are there adversarial campaigns to consider?

8. What messages is the target audience already being exposed to?

9. What set of methods will be used to attempt to influence the target audience?

a. Given these methods, what potential is there for negative response or blowback from the target audience? What potential is there for positive response from the target audience?

10. What resources will be necessary to carry out this approach?

11. What is the desired end-state of the campaign? How is this end-state measurable?

Milestones

1. What are the metrics that will be used to indicate the success of the campaign?

2. What are the milestones that would indicate progress toward the desired end-state?

The questions it asks are generalizable to any domain, whether it be marketing, advertising, political campaigns, or influence operations. This catechism could be adapted to have additional questions as needed, especially for specific domains, but would provide a stable “pre-flight” checklist for any campaign.



6. Practices Catalog

Here, a catalog of practices which have been identified to be of use to formal and informal narrative campaigns is provided. **The inclusion of a practice and the conditions under which they are “best used” should not be confused with a recommendation for their use.** While this section will present practices which the reader may perceive as morally dubious, it is helpful to become acquainted with these practices as they may be used by other campaigns, adversarial or otherwise. **Given the exploratory nature of the work on this guide, this section will always be incomplete and in development,** and many names given here may not be found elsewhere as some practices had not yet been named or had numerous names given in different disciplines or contexts. Due to the multidisciplinary and multidimensional nature of the practices, they are currently presented in ad hoc categories which are not intended to be interpreted as stable.

6.1. Attributes and Structure

Each practice is given three small subsections and a set of two attributes: “Commonly Used By” and “Tags”. The subsections are “Summary and Considerations”, “Best Used Where”, and “Beware”.

Summary and Considerations provides a definition of, and some brief commentary on, the practice.

Best Used Where provides some notes on the conditions under which the practice is expected to be most effective.

Beware provides the caveats of use and conditions under which the practice may be counterproductive or ineffective.

Commonly Used By refers to organizations of particular categories which appeared to be associated with the practice.

Tags is an attribute representing a first, exploratory attempt at classifications for the practices.

For reference, the definitions of the organizational categories and classification tags are provided.

6.1.1. Organization Categories

The following categories of organization were found to be relevant and are defined for their use in the catalog:

Academic Organizations are organizations such as Universities and Colleges as well as groups which represent these institutions.

Activist Groups are formal and informal organizations and emergent collectives which pursue social, cultural, and political change through direct action.

Advertisers specifically refer to organizations whose sole purpose is to produce, procure, and place content intended to influence a target audience to engage with or purchase products or services.

Companies refer to organizations which offer products or services.

Cybersecurity Firms refer to organizations which are relied on to protect digital technologies, processes, and systems from threat actors. For the purposes of this guide, they also apply to organizations and teams within other organizations which fulfill this role.

Digital Platforms refer to organizations which provide digital affordances to consumers, including, but not limited to, social media and communications systems.

Governments refer to the governing bodies of nation states, their states and provinces, and other sub-jurisdictions. For the purposes of this guide, unless otherwise specified, they also refer to the agencies and militaries of these governing bodies.

Industry/Trade Associations refer to associations that set standards for or provide opportunities within various sectors of the market.

Law Enforcement refers specifically to law enforcement agencies.

Online Communities refer to formal and informal online collectives of individuals with common narrative and communications channels.

Political Campaigns refer to organizations running narrative campaigns with and for an individual running for political office as well as to some organizations which may assist in this process.

Public Action Groups refer to formal organizations, usually nonprofits and NGOs, whose purpose is to lobby governments and other formal organizations, organize narrative campaigns, and raise awareness or funds for causes they were formed to impact.

6.1.2. Dimensions and Classifications

The tags presented and defined here were found in some cases to be mutually exclusive. This being the case they were considered to be in a common category representing some binary classification or, where designation was not necessarily binary, considered to be representative of some common dimension. Tags that weren't generalizable to more than one potential practice were removed. Some practices are flexible, thus categorization or their tendency toward one side of a dimension is dependent on their application—as such, some tags are separated by a “/” to indicate that category or dimensional tendency is based on application. This was a first, exploratory attempt at classification, and more research is needed for its refinement.

Distributed and Centralized. Some practices focus on finding ways to get crowds or external parties to carry out the work, whereas others depend on inhouse staff and direction. This is considered dimensional, rather than binary, as some practices require a great deal of central planning and funding in order to organize external parties while others require little or may emerge naturally without any planning at all.

Aggressive and Defensive. Aggressive practices are those which disrupt the narratives of others, whereas defensive ones intend to make narrative resilient to or safe from disruption. Some practices could be used aggressively or defensively, and some may simultaneously achieve both disruption of some narrative while fortifying another. Other practices may have nothing to do with strengthening or disrupting a narrative and instead focus on circumventing them. Worth noting is that some practices intended to make narrative resilient to disruption may appear to be “aggressive” actions, in the sense that they are “hostile” or very blunt—for the purposes of classification however, Aggressive and Defensive tags refer specifically to the definition provided above. For example, practices which suppress speech may appear “aggressive” and tend to make the narrative of their targets more resilient, but their intent is to make the narratives of some broad population safe from disruption, and as such, are labeled “defensive”.

Anticipatory and Reactive. Anticipatory practices are those which are used in anticipation of potential accelerants or stepping stones to narrative development, whereas reactive ones are generally used in response to them.

Direct and Indirect. Practices, when applied, fall into one of two categories: either they affect narrative directly or do so indirectly. For example, there is a notable difference between telling someone about why they should donate to organizations fighting poverty and them watching a movie which includes a story that includes someone in poverty having their life notably impacted by a small donation.

Interactive. Some practices have an interactive element, in the sense that the target audience won't just be exposed to the products of the practice but instead engage with them in a substantial way. For example, clicking on an ad is meaningful, but interacting

with a released game or arguing with someone paid to instigate is both meaningful and substantially interactive.

Scheduling Practice. Practices which are related to scheduling protocols are marked.

Rules-Related. Practices which are associated with rules, standards setting, and with enforcement actions have been marked.

Affordances-Based. Practices which are characterized or enabled by access to or ability to offer or revoke access to physical and digital affordances have been marked.

6.2. Practices

6.2.1. Scheduling Practices

(1) Continuity Scheduling

Commonly used by: Advertisers, Political Campaigns

Tags: Centralized, Scheduling Practice

Summary and Considerations: Continuity Scheduling is a form of scheduling practice for release of content which was defined in the context of advertising and political campaigns. The objective of continuity scheduling is maintaining constant awareness of the content's subject matter within the target audience. Continuity Scheduling entails the forward planning of regular and unrelenting release or placement of content in front of the target audience for the entire length of a campaign.

Best Used Where:

- The success of other campaign deployments relies on constant awareness.
- The intention of the campaign is to cause “shocks to consciousness” or negative emotion.

Beware:

- Frustration: If your messaging causes unintended negative emotion either due to misinterpretation or, in the case of advertising, due to it getting in the way of an individual accessing content, Continuity Scheduling increases the likelihood of blowback.
- Expense: Continuity Scheduling which relies on ad placement can be notably more expensive than other scheduling practices.

(2) Flight Scheduling

Commonly used by: Advertisers, Political Campaigns

Tags: Centralized, Scheduling Practice

Summary and Considerations: Flight Scheduling is a form of scheduling practice for release of content which was defined in the context of advertising and political campaigns. Flight Scheduling is defined as the release and placement of content at key threshold moments followed by silence. In advertising, Flight Scheduling in advertising is primarily used in the run-up to holiday shopping events. In public relations, it is usually used to handle messaging about admissions of guilt, apologies, and poor news. In the context of political campaigns, it is rarely used except in cases where candidates are polling extraordinarily well or running mostly unopposed. Flight Scheduling can also be used in order to keep costs of promotion and advertising low.

Best Used Where:

- Messaging Required but Not Desired: In some cases, unflattering statements must be put out because not releasing a statement would be worse and deceptive messaging would be unacceptable or illegal.
- The campaign is related to some other key threshold event, such as an election.
- Anticipatory: Messaging would be advantageous to reference in the future but isn't intended to be seen (e.g. "we did make a statement about this last year").

Beware:

- If the messaging is intended to be seen, Flight Scheduling may go unnoticed by significant portions of the target audience.

(3) Pulse Scheduling

Commonly used by: Advertisers, Political Campaigns

Tags: Centralized, Scheduling Practice

Summary and Considerations: Pulse Scheduling is a form of scheduling practice for release of content which was defined in the context of advertising and political campaigns. Pulse Scheduling is defined as the planning and release of collections of content over set intervals. In some cases the intervals change over time, iteratively shortening leading up to key events or getting longer after them, or the amount of content released at each interval may change.

Best Used Where:

- The campaign is related to some other key threshold event, such as an election.
- Constant awareness is desired, but continuous messaging is prohibitively expensive or unfeasible.

Beware:

- Predictability: Adversarial campaigns which notice patterns in your releases will be able to begin using anticipatory strategies that will reduce efficacy of your messaging.

(4) “Really Big Show” Scheduling

Commonly used by: Advertisers, Political Campaigns

Tags: Centralized, Scheduling Practice

Summary and Considerations: “Really Big Show” is a form of scheduling practice for release of content which was defined in the context of political campaigns. The objective of “Really Big Show” Scheduling is to release a large amount of content or events all over a short time period in order to attract as much attention as possible and increase the likelihood of external organizations and individuals repeating messaging or sharing information about the event.

Best Used Where:

- The target audience’s information environment is “noisy” or saturated with content.
- The campaign is related to some other key threshold event, such as an election.

Beware:

- Coordination: The more content and events being deployed over short time periods, the more opportunities there are for errors to accumulate and for response time to lag.

(5) Spurt Scheduling

Commonly used by: Advertisers, Political Campaigns

Tags: Centralized, Scheduling Practice

Summary and Considerations: Spurt Scheduling is a form of scheduling practice for release of content which was defined in the context of advertising and political campaigns. Spurt Scheduling is defined as the planning and release of collections of content in a large burst or “spurt” at the start of a campaign, followed by any other scheduling practice for the remainder.

Best Used Where:

- The campaign is related to some other key threshold event, such as an election.

Beware:

- Competition: Events that warrant this kind of scheduling practice will mean other organizations using this practice. Thus any messaging during this time will have to compete with both organic content and press in addition to other campaigns’ messaging.

6.2.2. Messaging, Placement, and Influence

(1) Adjacent Messaging

Commonly used by: Governments, Advertisers, Public Action Groups

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect

Summary and Considerations: Given the potential for negative externalities generated by direct or hostile counter-messaging, adjacent messaging is a practice that borrows from rhetorical and debate technique by attempting to find a surface of agreement with the target audience that, if acknowledged, would make it difficult for the target audience to maintain an undesired attitude, behavior, or conclusion or to make an undesired decision. Many impactful anti-smoking campaigns focus on establishing such a surface of agreement: “We want more time to be with our families, to see grandchildren, and to retire with health”, so long as the smoker is already of the opinion that smoking would decrease the likelihood of this happening, the acknowledgement of this surface of agreement generates dissonance in the maintenance of the behavior—there might not even be a need to mention smoking, in fact—mentioning it can make the previous adjacency appear to be propaganda, media meant to manipulate their decisions, therefore hardening their position.

Best Used Where:

- The reasons for attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions within the target audience are observable and reasonably well understood.
- Direct counter-messaging is likely to be counterproductive.
- The target audience has emotional attachment to the subjects that would be accessed using more direct methodologies.

Beware:

- It can be very easy to misunderstand the reasoning of the target audience or the informational niche which they occupy, and therefore be fairly easy to construct ineffective or counterproductive messaging.
- Coming on too strong can create a hardening of their position especially if the target audience has oppositional attitudes toward the information being presented as an adjacency.

- Tying direct messaging to adjacent messaging will lead observant members of the target audiences to interpret the adjacent messaging as propaganda, which will decrease the efficacy of all forms of messaging on the topic in the future.

(2) Amplification and Placement of Content

Commonly used by: Governments, Advertisers, Companies, Activist Groups

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Direct/Indirect

Summary and Considerations: Campaigns do not necessarily have to focus on generation of content, instead the focus can be on the strategic placement and amplification of content, whether that content was produced internally or externally. For example, Russia's media influence operations now primarily focus on placement and amplification of hyperpartisan content, rather than on generation of content. Amplification can be achieved through regular placement of external content in the target audience's centers of gravity for communications and influence. Strategic placement in comment threads associated with subject matter which may frustrate or induce hesitance in the target audience, especially during heated exchanges can be notably impactful. In the case that the communications hubs are on digital platforms where content is algorithmically curated based on engagement (clicks and likes), using numerous fake accounts or purchasing the use of fake accounts to engage with content may achieve similar results.

Amplification and placement of content is standard within the advertising industry and there are a wide variety of methods to achieve this, such as SEO (search engine optimization) and ad purchasing. For the purposes of this guide, discussion of more indirect methods of amplification and placement were prioritized.

Best Used Where:

- Success in generating engaging content is likely going to be unreliable.
- Where there is limited observability of account activity.
- Where there are human terrain specialists that can be used to make deployments.

Beware:

- Using accounts which may be discovered to be inorganic will make communications more difficult in the future.
- Using humans to place messages or engage with content means interactions with other humans. Failing to respond and using scripted messages means the risk of suspicion regarding the accounts and responding means risk in moving outside the scope of the campaign.

(3) Baiting and Sealioning

Commonly used by: Activist Groups, Cybersecurity Firms, Political Campaigns

Tags: Distributed, Aggressive/Defensive, Reactive, Indirect, Interactive

Summary and Considerations: There are a number of practices which are associated with encouraging or trapping others into making blunders and missteps in order to impact the narratives of a target audience. Some of these practices have been formalized, such as the hiring and training of professional agitators during political campaigns. Others have been emergent, such as the practice of “Sealioning”. Sealioning is the act of maintaining clear civility while asking questions in reply-threads on social media. While it may be difficult to see how that would be “baiting” anyone or how it could be negative, this is in fact why it has been such a contentious practice—the questions are intended to frustrate and a key part of the tactic is to never stop asking questions or pose any specific claims for the individual to respond to. If a target stops answering questions or responds in frustration, the asker now has basis to say that the “other side” doesn’t act in “good faith”. Given the style of inquiry, it is difficult to tell whether or not someone is using the tactic or actually asking questions in good faith, which means every time it is used there is now a network effect in terms of an increased probability of “false positives” which will further polarize the information environment.

Best Used Where:

- Target audience is threat sensitive.
- Target audience has a great deal of negative emotion.

Beware:

- Network Effects: Baiting is a deeply destructive practice with network effects on trust and expectations.

(4) Canceling, Brigading, Mobbing, and Swarming

Commonly used by: Activist Groups, Online Communities

Tags: Distributed, Aggressive, Reactive, Direct

Summary and Considerations: With the availability of digital affordances for rapid organization and direction of attention, principles originally applied to organizing flash-protests, boycotts, professional denunciation, or letter-writing campaigns can now be inexpensively and rapidly applied at unprecedented scales. If a person or organization's past or recent actions can be made to align with the triggers for disgust sensitivity of a large enough audience, their attention and outrage in aggregate can be directed, or weaponized, toward them in order to suppress speech, encourage vigilantism, and bring attention and recruits to boycotts. While narrative impacts on the individual or organization aren't necessarily likely, the threat of similar actions may greatly influence speech within individuals who use similar messaging or practices to the target of the swarm.

Best Used Where:

- The group that will be influenced to swarm the target already considers the organization or individual to be a part of a hostile out-group.
- The group that will be influenced to swarm the target has already established a comfortability with swarming or expressing outrage online.
- There are human terrain specialists available to the campaign.

Beware:

- While threats and fear reduce public expressions of narrative, repression often accelerates, hardens, and reduces observability of narrative. The impact of the swarm can often be net-negative even if it results in short-term victories.

(5) Coordinated Cross-Promotion

Commonly used by: Governments, Advertisers, Companies, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect

Summary and Considerations: Coordinated Cross-Promotion is the practice of coordinating many organizations and individuals with reach and influence over the target audience to schedule the release of content and messaging. Successful coordination and release will influence the target audience to believe that the narrative associated with the content is widely accepted and of importance, given the rapid emergence of what is perceived as organic attention by sources they follow. This practice also increases the likelihood that other organizations and individuals will pick up the messaging as well in an effort to capitalize on the expected interest.

Best Used Where:

- The target audience's attention is difficult to capture and actions must be taken to ensure that messaging doesn't go unnoticed.
- Other organizations are likely aligned with the intended messaging and content or the intent of the campaign.

Beware:

- Discovery of coordinated behavior may be seen as deceptive and result in the campaign being susceptible to reputation damages associated with deceptive practices.

(6) Deceptive Messaging

Commonly used by: No Organization Class in Particular

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect

Summary and Considerations: Deceptive messaging is the practice of constructing messages to purposefully mislead or deceive. Successful deceptive messaging relies on trust, limited information, suppression of communications, or poor cognitive security within the target audience. Deceptive messaging often exploits confirmation bias, negativity bias, stubbornness, hostility, resentment, narrative identity, trust in messengers or authority, and fear to inject or stabilize mis- or dis-information. Deceptive messaging is used for a variety of reasons, sometimes noble, sometimes nefarious, and carries a very high likelihood of blowback in the case the practice is discovered.

Best Used Where:

- The damage caused by the truth being revealed or amplified now far outweighs the damage caused by its being revealed or amplified later (e.g. military and law enforcement operations) and the reasons for its concealment or suppression would likely be accepted or well-understood later.

Beware:

- The damage done to trust if discovered can be irreparable or difficult to remedy.
- If the reasons for the use of the practice seem self-interested or political in nature, then blowback is likely inevitable.
- Guilt by association if discovered:
 - Affiliates, collaborators, and even aesthetically or practically related organizations will suffer reputation damage.
 - All future messaging will be looked at skeptically.
 - All past messaging will be reconsidered.

(7) Direct Messaging, Propaganda, and Placement

Commonly used by: Governments, Advertisers, Companies, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Law Enforcement

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect

Summary and Considerations: Direct Messaging is the planning and placement of content in front of the target audience via any number of means over any medium in order to influence attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions. Advertisements are the prime example of Direct Messaging, but many organizations release content in a myriad of formats (e.g. video, static images, text, pamphlets, books, reports) with similar intentions. Deployment of messaging can occur through publishing and dissemination, purchasing of advertising placement, and a variety of other methods.

While the word “propaganda” has connotations of deception or government and military origin, any artifact which is strategically designed and deployed to shape perception about ideological or political subject matter meets most definitions.

Best Used Where:

- Awareness alone would affect the target audience’s narrative.
- There is a need to channel the target audience’s attention elsewhere.

Beware:

- Saturation: If the target audience is saturated with direct messaging from other individuals and organizations your content can easily be missed or ignored.
- Counter-messaging is often Counterproductive: Releasing messages which are adversarial or could be seen as hostile toward the identity or narrative of the target audience will likely make their narrative more resilient, not less.

(8) Forum Sliding

Commonly used by: Governments, Activist Groups

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Aggressive, Anticipatory, Indirect

Summary and Considerations: Forum Sliding is a very specific practice which was “discovered” by online communities attempting to spot counterintelligence and sabotage activities by law enforcement and rival groups and has since been purported to be used by activist groups on rival movements. It has been suggested in various forums that the practice was inspired by pre-internet techniques employed by COINTELPRO, an FBI counterintelligence program intended to disrupt U.S. social movements in the 1960s. The practice begins with finding platforms and forums which act as centers of gravity for undesired circulation of information and creating numerous accounts. Then, innocuous posts are created by the network of accounts and deployed on the forum and allowed to age, in anticipation of undesired postings. When undesired content is posted, the network of accounts now engage with anticipatory posts and place additional content, effectively sliding the undesired post into a sea of other content—leaving it far less likely to be noticed or engaged with. The more actions taken to make these accounts seem organic and active the more plausible deniability is provided.

Best Used Where:

- Platforms for target audience communications provide users with limited or no observability of other user activity.
- Sharing of content is predictable.

Beware:

- Forum sliding is a deceptive practice, and as such, its being suspected or detected on a forum will create suspicion and greater attentiveness on the part of the target audience.
- The more observability and searchability of user activity, the more likely its use will be detected.

(9) Plants, Paid Influencers, Water Armies, Troll Farms, and Astroturfing

Commonly used by: Governments, Advertisers, Companies, Activist Groups, Law Enforcement

Tags: Distributed, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect, Interactive/NonInteractive

Summary and Considerations: The use of fiction in narrative campaigns is a normalcy, but in some cases the borders of the “stage” might be blurred or non-existent. The practice of planting individuals in an audience to pretend to field preplanned questions or comments which allow the hosts of an event to control the otherwise unreliable and chaotic space of audience interactions while making sure it seems they’re open to transparency and communication is not new, but digital affordances have created new vectors for their deployment. Astroturfing (a play on the term for fake-grass) is the practice of concealing the sponsoring activities and messaging, presenting it as being of a “grass-roots” origin. Companies and advertising firms pay for Yelp and Amazon reviews, social media comments, and for influencers to post about their content. There are actions in this category that aren’t intended to focus on messaging. For example, sometimes organizations will create accounts that have activity within forums and social media channels that are only there to collect information or are simply used to amplify specific messages or deamplify others (retweeting, downvoting, sharing).

Water armies are a particular form of implementation, which refers specifically to astroturfing at extremely large scales with thousands of individuals being paid for postings. The term was originally used to describe the Chinese Government and Military practice of paid postings en masse. Troll farms on the other hand is a specific implementation wherein professional posters are hired to produce content and manage accounts within an organization. It was usually used to refer to outfits similar to Russia’s St. Petersburg organization, the IRA (Internet Research Agency).

Best Used Where:

- There is limited observability of account activity.
- Produced content is likely to blend with actual organic content.
- There are human terrain specialists available to check content prior to deployment.

Beware:

- Astroturfing and use of plants are deceptive practices, and as such, its being suspected or detected on a forum will create suspicion and greater attentiveness on the part of the target audience.

- The more observability and searchability of user activity, the more likely its use will be detected.
- Influencers may reveal that they have been sponsored to produce, amplify, or present content.
- Using humans to place messages or engage with content means interactions with other humans. Failing to respond and using scripted messages means the risk of suspicion regarding the accounts and responding means risk in moving outside the scope of the campaign.

(10) Prebunking

Commonly used by: Governments, Companies, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities, Academic Organizations

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory, Direct/Indirect

Summary and Considerations: Prebunking is the act of preemptively dispelling potential misinformation, especially disinformation, and consists of several steps:

1. Identifying which potential disinformation narratives have the ability to become highly contagious and contentious, including identifying which actors may create and/or spread them, and their underlying motives.
2. Developing credible narratives that, once distributed, would render these potential disinformation narratives impotent. It is important that these are tested before scaled with the target audience to ensure that messaging does not backfire.
3. Disseminating these narratives. Dissemination has 2 critical components:
 - a. Needs to be through channels that reach the target audience and that they trust.
 - b. Needs to come from actors that are trusted by the target audience.

For example, ensuring transparency around the vaccine supply chain, such as providing information on each ingredient and how it is sourced and results of early studies, is a substantially different action than releasing this information after false information has circulated about ingredients used. Even if dissemination of false information or oppositional information is more successful initially, having material ready increases response time and having it dated prior to competing information improves its credibility as it won't be perceived as reactionary.

This practice can also be used to limit the impact of circulation of proof of deceptive practice. If proof of deceptive practice is expected to circulate, releasing full or partial information about the deceptive practice ahead of circulation can be released in order to create a center of gravity for the narrative that the expected circulation of proof will have to compete with. In these cases, the practice is referred to instead as a "limited hangout".

Best Used Where:

- Early Action: Before adversarial campaign content is widely shared and believed.
- Undesired narratives can be accurately predicted.
- Credible, trusted actors exist to preemptively create narratives that dispel potential adversarial campaigns.

Beware:

- Backfiring: If used too late, and in an adversarial manner, prebunking could cause blowback.
- Errors: If your prebunking material uses faulty logic or contains errors, it will become a new target for adversarial campaigns.

(11) Shills and Establishing Guilt by Association

Commonly used by: Governments, Advertisers, Companies, Activist Groups, Law Enforcement

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Aggressive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect, Interactive/NonInteractive

Summary and Considerations: Shills are a special type of “plant” in a community or channel whose job is to visibly and loudly pronounce agreement with some undesired attitude, behavior, conclusion, or decision. While producing messaging in agreement with the narratives a campaign intends to disrupt or replace may seem counterproductive, the shill’s job isn’t just to agree, it’s to agree while being someone that no reasonable person in the target audience would want to align with. The shill will “yes, and” the arguments in favor of the undesired viewpoint in public forums. For example, a neo-Nazi agreeing with some conservative viewpoint about the importance of the maintenance of tradition and adding that no coexistence with other traditions is possible, or placing a communist to agree with some viewpoint about the importance of a minimum wage and adding that the prices of food and housing should be universally fixed as well. If done correctly and in the right environment, organic support for the shill’s argument may be taken up by more radical members of the community or other shills placed by other groups. This practice is purported to be in use in rivalries between activist groups on both private and public channels in an effort to link groups to being comfortable with criminal activity or radical materials and ideas. Some of the impact of this practice can also be achieved by simply linking arguments made by one individual to that of a person the target audience would view as beyond the pale. Such as the linking of ideas repeated and developed by evolutionary theorists to eugenics and Chapter 11 of Adolf Hitler’s *Mein Kampf*.

Best Used Where:

- Messaging intended to be linked is nearly identical to messaging by groups which would reliably trigger disgust sensitivity in the target audience.

Beware:

- This is a deceptive practice and if detected or suspected, it may result in a new resilience of the associated narratives.
- By linking ideas in one community to those in more radical ones, you may also be creating clear on-ramps to those radical ideologies.

(12) Threshold and Moments Targeting

Commonly used by: Public Action Groups, Law Enforcement

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect, Scheduling Practice

Summary and Considerations: Methodology of targeting communications based on moments and context, rather than to certain audience groups or individuals. Traditional uses could include a reminder to wash hands in a bathroom, but digital technology has allowed for much more sophisticated applications of these principles to narrative campaigns. In a data-driven digital/mobile context, the use of these tactics differs significantly from most digital advertising, which is person and audience based. Communications that target certain individuals and audiences do so because those audiences are more likely to have moments in their day when they will be open to specific communications. This methodology takes that theory a step farther by targeting the moments themselves, as identified through thick behavioral and content-based data.

Contextual and moment-based engagement allows for the communicator to speak only into moments when intent and interest is apparent by anonymized behavioral and contextual data. This allows the communication to much better match and meet audience need and fit more naturally into the learning and informational consumption path each person who enters that moment is already on.

Best Used Where:

- Holes in data about certain groups or a preponderance of sensational or out-of-date information make it less likely that audiences will find correct and useful information on their own or through referral algorithms.
- Especially important and useful to help correct for bias in data and referral around underserved communities.
- Nudge approaches to gradual attitudinal change are being used that will feel more natural when fit into appropriate moments.

Beware:

- Pushing too hard or not appropriately understanding and prioritizing needs of the audience.
- If the moment being targeted is a particularly vulnerable one and both targeting and ulterior motives are suspected, the audience may feel exploited (e.g. advertisers targeting individuals who are ill with fear-based messaging).

- The same factors that work in favor of nudge approaches, can backfire if not executed correctly by leaving the audience feeling manipulated in ways they would not in more obvious and traditional attention-based ads and communications.

6.2.3. Context and Framing

(1) Civic and Moral Framing

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms, Governments, Advertisers, Companies, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities, Academic Organizations, Law Enforcement

Tags: n/a

Summary and Considerations: Civic and Moral Framing is the attempt to frame a behavior or action as “The Right Thing to Do” or “The Wrong Thing to Do”. Civic Framing focuses on national or community identity, suggesting that taking some action is necessary or antithetical to maintaining the identity of a “good citizen”, whereas Moral Framing is more general, focusing on anything from racial or ethnic identity to religious identity.

Best Used Where:

- Target audience has a lack of purpose in their lives.
- Target audience is emotionally invested in maintaining the civic or moral identity threatened or supported by the behavior or activity.
- There is a human terrain specialist available to approve or give feedback on messaging.

Beware:

- Reaching: “Logical Stretches” to connect an activity to the target audience’s morals and identity can result in blowback.
- Appropriating or Misunderstanding the culture and artifacts of the target audience in the process of developing messaging for Civic and Moral Framing can be disastrous (e.g. Pepsi’s Live Louder Kendal Jenner ad is still referenced and parodied, years after its release).

(2) Story Construction/Storifying

Commonly used by: Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect

Summary and Considerations: The obvious antidote to disinformation might seem to be information, however, there is a problem with the originating assumption of this statement: that true or false information is equally compelling and that all one needs to know is the difference. People will remain committed to, and cling to, disinformation in the light of cold hard facts because raw information, whether true or false, is not inherently compelling. What is compelling are stories that tell the meaning of the information. If those stories tell the meaning of the raw data in a way that also appeals to the identity of the audience, the “cold hard facts” will not be impactful. Stories play a special role in human cognition. Our brains are receptive to stories, especially stories about ourselves, or stories that we see ourselves in, or project ourselves into. We are particularly receptive to stories that speak to our preferred identities especially when we feel our identity is under threat and the story provides a circumvention of the threat.

Storytelling or “Storifying” is a technique sometimes used in digital advertising roughly defined as the composition of a story from real or fictitious sources so as to create change in the listener’s, viewer’s, reader’s and user’s emotions, attitudes, behaviors, conclusions, and decisions in a desired manner. The implementation is heuristic however, which means that it can be difficult to predict the impact or potential for blowback of any particular deployment. While messages which tell stories can be used, stories can be told through the consecutive release of multiple content objects of various types.

Best Used Where:

- The target audience has a high degree of emotionality attached to issues relevant to the campaign.
- The target audience has been largely unreceptive to fact-checking.
- Human Terrain Specialists are available to the campaign.

Beware:

- Stories which poorly map to the target audience’s narrative may simply be used as parody or labeled as cultural appropriations.
- It is difficult to predict impact and how stories will be modified, interpreted, and shared.

6.2.4. Education, Training, and Distributed Behavior Modification

(1) Bot-Spotting/Troll-Spotting Education Campaigns

Commonly used by: Non-Profit Organizations, Governments, Activist Groups

Tags: Distributed, Aggressive, Reactive, Direct, Interactive

Summary and Considerations: Providing civilians with education on how to identify Message Bots and/or Professional Trolls in the wild and how to “call them out”. Some campaigns stress civic engagement and provide communities of practice that build strong resilience against adversarial campaigns—especially against those by state-actors. A key example might be the Lithuanian or Baltic “Elves”, which are a collective of activists which both actively participate in bot-spotting and educate others on how to do so. A key consideration however: the social scripts we use to navigate our environment will adapt rapidly to environmental conditions—this often involves imitation of successful strategies. Civil discourse depends on trust and expectations of civility, if expectations of civility change (e.g. from the presence of trolls or bots perceived to be human), then the strategies of otherwise civil people may begin to look not all that dissimilar from that of the ones used by trolls and bots. False positives in bot-spotting/troll-spotting will do a great deal of damage, as offending an individual’s sense of agency or good-faith is an accelerant for both the views in question and their views of the offender’s perceived group.

Best Used Where:

- There are audiences which are expected to be willing to make active effort in order to engage in civic action.
- The campaign would need to have self-sustaining, longer-term impacts in order to be effective.
- There is limited logistical or financial support for long term messaging or organization management.

Beware:

- False positives will offend people’s sense of agency and will therefore accelerate their views and the perception of the groups with which the bot/troll-spotters are aligned as hostile out-groups.

(2) Conversation Initiatives

Commonly used by: Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities

Tags: Distributed, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect, Interactive

Summary and Considerations: Persuasive conversation initiatives are initiatives which ask for participants to arrange situations or find opportunities for dialogue between the issue advocates and targeted members of the group the campaign intends to influence or educate in regards to some issue. This practice often overlaps with methodology for private-reachout campaigns, but the key difference is that private-reachout campaigns aren't exclusively conversation-based. Conversation Initiatives can be issue-oriented, such as a discussion about a polarizing topic, or they can be meant to break down barriers between groups that might not be aligned with each other.

These initiatives come in a variety of forms and styles. Salons, for example, focus on the use of a facilitator in order to include many individuals and are often intended to be filmed and presented to others. An impactful example of the Salon method can be found in the "Death Cafe" model (deathcafe.com), wherein a facilitator helps a group of individuals from different walks of life navigate a conversation about death and life in the face of death. Conversation initiatives can also be one-on-one and don't even have to be focused on a topic, such as the "Coffee with a Cop" program (coffeewithacop.com) wherein individuals are randomly paired with a police officer to talk over a cup of coffee about issues in their community.

These initiatives can sometimes focus on just providing a hub for emergence of conversations in neutral settings, such as Police Athletic League events held at baseball fields which serve to create dialogue between youth and police, and to break down barriers, or in a "home territory" of one or both sides of the issues, such is the case with Town-hall methods. In the case of deep canvassing and adjacent methods, digital or door-to-door reach outs might be conducted (e.g. religious advocates visiting a neighborhood). Reach-outs are conducted via networks of existing contacts or through lead-sheets purchased or developed by the campaign, with a self-selected interest in the issue and conversation.

Some interesting examples of Conversation Initiatives:

- 2014 Nigerian Ebola epidemic house-to-house conversation campaign, paired with town hall/village meeting style conversations.
- Ongoing Death Cafe (deathcafe.com) program to encourage people to talk about death, and life in the face of death.
- Tobacco control conversation campaign—a multi-media, multi-channel campaign to raise awareness of and encourage discussion around the dangers of tobacco.

- 2020 Bernie Sanders peer-to-peer texting campaign, which generated 8 million messages to rally support for the candidate.
- 2014 Minnesota Interfaith Power and Light conversation campaign on climate change.
- 2012 Freedom to Marry conversation campaign on LGBTQ rights.
- National Suicide Prevention Month's #BeThe1to [ask] campaign, within which participants are asked to reach out to individuals or make other individuals aware that they are available for conversation about suicidal ideation.

Some key tips:

- Start with a question; especially with what people want in their communities (i.e. what they hope for), rather than with the problem.
- The more polarized or contentious the issues are, the more necessary it becomes to include a neutral facilitator.
- When addressing issues where individuals have a great deal of uncertainty, it can be best to encourage non-prescriptive conversations that invite stakeholders into exploration of the topic.

Best Used Where:

- Both sides need to or could benefit from consciously considering the relationship between their existing beliefs.
- There is an expectation that the participants will work to develop trust and maintain authenticity and a non-judgmental attitude.
- The target audience(s) are likely in “echo chambers” and could benefit from hearing directly from an individual in what they might consider to be a hostile out-group.
- Participants will share enough sociocultural attributes and language in order to reliably communicate and relate.

Beware:

- If the groups involved are hostile toward one another, conversations can rapidly devolve.
- Facilitators who have to rely too heavily on a script or lack the training or natural ability to manage conversations, they may further division between participants rather than decrease it.
- Cultural Clashes: groups which are not able to relate meaningfully may create more division and isolation than the initiative solves.
- Challenging participants' underlying beliefs too directly can create blowback.

(3) Developing and Sponsoring Communities of Practice

Commonly used by: Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities, Academic Organizations

Tags: Distributed, Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect, Interactive

Summary and Considerations: Sponsoring, facilitating, hosting, and otherwise developing communities of practice, or groups which are characterized by taking action or co-developing a practice or trade can be enormously impactful on the crystallization, disruption, or resilience of narratives of the participants. There are a myriad of ways to deploy communities of practice and a number of reasons to do so based on the objectives of your campaign and the attributes of your target audience. The use of sponsoring and facilitating political action groups and “grassroots” organizations is common in the political campaign space, where these groups can be used to help direct, amplify, and spread the central campaign’s messaging. However, communities of practice can be developed around concepts other than central messaging, and can be used in combination with other practices, such as conversation campaigns, gamification, or bot/troll-spotting, in order to scale campaigns without increasing costs—as these leaders of these organizations can pick up the work that would otherwise be salaried at the central organization. Communities of practice provide people with purpose, which not only makes the narrative of interest more resilient, but makes individuals more resilient in general—and depending on the topic, they are also an excellent tool for providing opportunities for civic engagement and citizen science.

In some lucky cases, there may be opportunities to include individuals from groups that see each other as hostile and allow them to build trust while working on projects totally unrelated to the narrative of interest—thus, a community of practice which is intended to change an opinion about a topic does not have to actually be about that topic—instead, it can simply be used as a tool to reduce polarization. Further, sometimes a community can be developed without any interest in affecting narrative, but instead with the purpose of developing a communications hub that is observable to the campaign—this is discussed as a separate practice, called honeypotting.

Smaller systems lend themselves to de-escalation, increased communication, increased participation, and reduced polarization, thus, many communities of practice may be a more viable solution in many cases, as opposed to simply creating one large one. A last consideration: recruiting an extant community of practice may be easier than creating one.

Best Used Where:

- The target audience has a lack of purpose, opportunity, or community in their lives.
- The target audience is the target of adversarial campaigns and needs to be made resilient.

- The campaign needs to scale non-automated processes but does not have the capital to do so.

Beware:

- Communities of practice can splinter, and may do so while using your campaign's messaging, branding, equipment, and support.

- Communities of practice can rebel, if your messaging or intents no longer align with the intents and principles of the individuals of these communities—they can simply walk away or turn on the campaign. Thus communities of practice can represent a threat surface to campaigns, especially to those that may be using deceptive messaging.

(4) “Don’t Engage” Initiatives

Commonly used by: Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities

Tags: Distributed, Defensive, Reactive, Indirect

Summary and Considerations: “Don’t Engage” initiatives come in a number of forms, and are an emergent, rather than a formalized practice. What characterizes a “Don’t Engage” initiative is the intent to spread, within their target audience, a strategy of disengagement from some other group. “We don’t talk to crazy”, “Don’t suffer fools”, “Don’t talk to press”, and “Punch a Nazi” were common phrases associated with recent emergent and coordinated initiatives (while “Punch a Nazi” may seem like a call for engagement, it was also a call to not engage in conversation or inquiry). Some initiatives focus on the mental health or quality of life of the target audience, suggesting that it is simply not worth it to engage with individuals who have viewpoints so different from your own. In other cases, the focus may be on operations security (OPSEC) and the use of these initiatives is to prevent individuals from accidentally releasing information or sound-bites to the press, which are seen to be conducting adversarial campaigns against the group. On the other hand, some are notably escalatory—suggesting that “the time for conversation is over”. While more commonly associated with recent, often anti-establishment, political movements, these initiatives were common in institutional contexts as well. For example, D.A.R.E. (Drug Abuse Resistance Education) targeted children with a “just say no” disengagement initiative which recommended the strategy of disengaging with individuals who use or are around people who use drugs. There have also been many initiatives which have encouraged people not to engage with individuals who have road rage or have expressed intent to do physical harm. In commercial and government contexts there are also OPSEC-oriented “don’t engage” initiatives, wherein one should not engage with someone who may have demonstrated “red flags” indicating that they are probing for trade secrets or classified information.

Best Used Where:

- The group that the target audience is being advised not to engage with is actually violent or dangerous.
- The group or profile which the target audience is being advised not to engage with is actually an alias persona (an individual who is lying about aspects of their identity), a bot, or is a threat actor attempting to drain the resources and attention of the target audience.
- The target audience cannot be relied on to be resilient against social engineering attempts:
 - Employees in contexts where separation of concerns is warranted (e.g. this type of employee does not engage with press on behalf of the company).

- Children.

Beware:

- Given the nature of our curation algorithms on social media, don't engage campaigns can result in:

- the equivalent of shadow-banning, which may cause narrative acceleration on the part of the group.
- filter bubbles, where individuals in the target audience will begin to see only exaggerated representations of the views of the targeted group and content with which they already agree.
- If the group or profile used is not actually violent or dangerous or is otherwise mislabeled or unfairly characterized by the campaign, it may actually generate a narrative renaissance for both the individuals in the group as well as individuals within the target audience that discover this mischaracterization.

(5) Encouraging Fact-Checking of Posted Content

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities, Academic Organizations

Tags: Distributed, Aggressive, Reactive, Direct, Interactive

Summary and Considerations: A commonly used approach to combating false and misleading information online is to encourage individuals to respond to posted content with fact-checks and fact-based counter-arguments. Many organizations go further, offering tool-kits and worksheets of counter-arguments, facts to present, and cypypasta and image-caption memes mapped to claims or content they may see posted. These initiatives sometimes use a “fire and forget” model, requesting that users don’t engage with responses to their posted materials.

Best Used Where:

- The fact-checkers and those being “checked” consider each other as neutral and part of the same in-group.
- Both the fact-checkers and those being “checked” aren’t emotionally attached to the subject matter.
- The group being encouraged to fact-check is non-hostile toward those individuals being “checked”.
- The data or “facts” being used to counter are from ideologically neutral sources and well-sourced.

Beware:

- If the group being encouraged to fact-check is hostile toward those individuals being “checked”, engagements will likely cause more polarization than they solve.
- Standardizing of responses and counter-arguments which can be easily debated by the opposing side may result in parody or further hardening of the positions held in the target audience.
- Presence of raw facts may impact individual claims but not the underlying narrative (“Yes, but”).
- Confusing facts with interpretation of facts: presenting interpretations of facts, even when there is wide consensus on those interpretations, as facts themselves can create blowback—especially where the presentation of those interpretations is standardized via worksheets or tool-kits.
- While encouraging mass fact-checking seems to be an obvious response to perceived misinformation and falsehood, when done incorrectly it can actually increase

polarization and consequently increase the demand for related content and reduce the likelihood of successful communications with the target audience in the future.

(6) Gamification/Serious Games

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms, Governments, Public Action Groups, Online Communities, Academic Organizations

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect, Interactive, Affordances-Based

Summary and Considerations: Gamification is the act of using game-based design elements and principles in non-game applications. Game design elements can include points, badges, leaderboards, performance graphs, avatars, teammates, and stories. Gamification is interactive in nature, and can be integrated with other practices in a variety of settings—as gamified design doesn’t necessarily have to result in features which look like games. Game-like incentive structures can be built into interactive frameworks—points and badges don’t have to look like the ones that might be earned in a video game in order to act as rewards for behaviors we aim to incentivize, such as prebunking misinformation. Badges can be virtual status symbols, especially when communities around these frameworks are built.

Leaderboards can be used to visualize and compare performance and rankings between players and performance graphs show a player's progress over time. This provides a competitive element, where the desire to improve is an innate motivation. Avatars and stories can be used to develop personal buy-in, and can incorporate people into communities, as well as teammates. An interesting recent implementation of Gamification is the Chinese government’s new social credit scores that is designed to incentivize good behavior.

Best Used Where:

- It is clear which behaviors want to be incentivized.
- The game-like behaviors which are meant to earn rewards can be monitored, tracked, and audited.
- Actions desired are ongoing, rather than one-off.
- Community elements are present.
- Individuals to be influenced have been habitualized to games.

Beware:

- Gamification has been used heavily by the marketing industry and has come across as gimmicky and inauthentic. If deemed disingenuous, it may well have the opposite effect as intended.
- Beware of unintended consequences, the impact of incentives isn’t always positive—if individuals begin to focus more on the points than they do on the impact the points are

meant to map to, you will likely find cheating and shortcuts that have negative impacts both on the phenomena the system was built to address and on the other individuals who are using the system.

- External reward systems have direct impact on intrinsic motivations. Be sure to consider the weight of the incentive systems and its impacts on user behavior.

(7) Private Reach-Out Campaigns

Commonly used by: Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities

Tags: Distributed, Aggressive, Reactive, Direct, Interactive

Summary and Considerations: Private, 1-on-1 interactive engagement is, in general, notably more impactful than one-to-many engagements such as ads or other forms of messaging. Unfortunately, the difficulty is scaling. Some online communities and activist groups have launched initiatives that attempt to encourage 1-on-1 engagements on topics or interventions on behavior which solves the problem of scaling. For example, the Suicide Prevention Lifeline's "be the one to ask" campaign, which offers guidelines for community engagement—how to prevent suicide within their family, social-circle, and local community by prompting 1-on-1 conversations with questions. In response to undesired behaviors online, private reach-outs can also be of great use, as engaging with hostile behavior online can often escalate and amplify it—and ignoring it can create filter-bubbles which have negative impacts as well.

While private reach-out initiatives have the potential to be impactful, it's worth noting that the kinds of impacts it creates are notoriously difficult to measure and observe. For example, the Suicide Prevention Lifeline's "be the one to ask" campaign asked individuals to take actions that would all be performed in private spaces, inaccessible to the campaign. Further, these initiatives can have illusory impacts and run into trouble when their instructions aren't followed. In the same campaign mentioned above, many individuals began posting on social media saying that it was okay to reach out to talk to them, but the campaign never asked them to make these posts and few linked back to the original instructions.

Best Used Where:

- Public engagement is likely to have blowback or negative effects.
- The topic is personal and engaging with it in a public setting is likely to result in dishonesty and negative feedback.
- The tasks involved in the reach-outs themselves are straightforward or the related best practices are easily taught and easily implemented.

Beware:

- Some intervention-style engagements require training or substantial natural skill in order to be effective.
- Without training or substantial natural skill, engagements may just have negative impacts.
- Very difficult to measure the impacts of these kinds of campaigns.

(8) Retraining, Re-education, Rehabilitation, and Deprogramming Initiatives

Commonly used by: Governments, Companies, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities, Academic Organizations, Law Enforcement, Industry/Trade Associations

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Aggressive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect, Interactive, Rules-Related

Summary and Considerations: Re-education or Deprogramming Initiatives are a relatively modern practice used to impact or maintain narrative under a wide range of conditions. While the terms “Deprogramming” and “Re-education” came about as translations or descriptions of programs managed by the communist governments of the USSR, Cambodia, China, and Vietnam, the first “mass” reeducation program of the 20th century was a part of the “denazification” of German and Austrian populations after World War 2. These initiatives are characterized by the attempt to disrupt narrative, or to suppress its expressions, using training, examination, and education. Historically, participation was generally enforced under threat of death, imprisonment, or continued imprisonment.

While this is still done in some cases, there are many modern practices in this category which carry much less severe connotations or consequences. For example, in corporate settings the impetus for participation in Re-education and Retraining is an action that is not aligned with company policy or values, or the anticipation of such an action, such as sexual harassment, racial bias, or industrial safety hazards, and the consequences of failure to participate may include termination of employment. These initiatives are sometimes highly centralized, using certified trainers or physical schools, or highly decentralized, using disseminated training-guides for distributed hosting of training events.

**Rehabilitation programs, as a narrative and behavior disruption practice, are also included in this category.*

**The term “Deprogramming” in particular is usually associated with disrupting cult-like or extremist ideology.*

Best Used Where:

- The target audience agrees that the action or anticipated action prompting the re-education or deprogramming is undesired.
- There is substantial evidence that suggests that participation will result in outcomes that the target audience considers positive.

Beware:

- Autonomy: Organizational research indicates that people generally react negatively to efforts by others to control or suppress their expressions.
- Radicalization: If the target audience doesn't agree with the interpretations they're being required to adopt or does not have the necessary priors to make the interpretations plausible, re-education will likely be a radicalizing event.
- Efficacy: Most historical mass re-education programs have either failed to be impactful at disrupting undesired narratives or were, in retrospect, considered ill-advised. Consequently, some populations have fairly severe connotations associated with re-education or deprogramming initiatives.

(9) Training and Education Initiatives

Commonly used by: Governments, Companies, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities, Academic Organizations, Law Enforcement, Industry/Trade Associations

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect, Interactive, Affordances-Based

Summary and Considerations: Training and Education Initiatives can be used to affect narrative by addressing subject matter directly or indirectly by accompanying logistical deployments (how to use equipment) or participation in communities of practice. Educational initiatives can take a variety of forms, including the publishing of books and documents as well as the holding of training events.

Best Used Where:

- Target audience is likely to participate.
- There is a clear value proposition for participation.

Beware:

- Deployment of training initiatives means liability (reputational, and in some cases legal) for the use and implementation of that training.

6.2.5. Regulatory

(1) Association Credentialing

Commonly used by: Governments, Companies, Public Action Groups, Online Communities, Academic Organizations

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect, Rules-Related

Summary and Considerations: Where Governments can force licensure, certification, and registration, industries can form associations, certification and ratings organizations, and committees to impact narratives. Industry organizations can issue ranks, titles, ratings, certificates, and grades meant to be publicly displayed. When paired with cross-promotion and coordination, these ratings and credentials can be just as impactful as more traditional ones without restricting the market legally. Eventually, other organizations may adopt these credentials as standards, effectively becoming de facto licensure.

Best Used Where:

- Government intervention would be too heavy handed, but some form of guard-rail is needed to help people make sense of what to trust.
- Those involved in the founding of the association are well trusted by both the industry and by the target audience which would use the ratings and credentials it intends to offer.

Beware:

- Unequal treatment, similar to the practice of deplatforming and censorship, if an enforcement is made on the basis of application of the rules or the introduction of new rules—it is exceptionally important that these rules be applied fairly else it will axiomatically cause negative emotion and potentially drive radicalization of the group associated with the enforcement.

(2) Deplatforming and Censorship

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms, Governments, Companies, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities

Tags: Centralized, Defensive, Reactive, Indirect, Rules-Related

Summary and Considerations: Deplatforming is the act of suppressing or lobbying for the suppression of expression over some communications channel through any number of means. Some organizations and emergent collectives have adopted the practice of attempting to lobby or coerce a platform, institution, or venue into canceling events, banning or suspending an individual from an association or account, or removing a specific communications channel in order to prevent the spread of messaging. Where activist groups and emergent collectives online focus on coercion and lobbying, digital platforms have adopted rule-sets and posting guidelines that allow removal of material and accounts under some circumstances as a basis for removing undesired content, but often apply these rule-sets and post guidelines selectively in such a way as to deplatform and censor content which they deem in opposition to narratives they want promoted. While this was previously seen as debatable, there have been numerous reports indicating that these organizations have not only done this, but have done this with other organizations and platforms as a part of coordinated narrative campaigns. Governments are arguably the organization-type most associated with these practices, employing both overt legislative and regulatory means as well as covert and physical means to censor and deplatform individuals. The number of options for governments vary to such an extent that deplatform takes on a new meaning, given that the removal of an individual from their freedom of expression by placing them under arrest, having them killed, or by threatening them and denying them recourse all become potential means of exercising these practices—to this end, organized crime and activist groups may be less known for their association with deplatforming or censorship in these contexts but all hold and have been known to use these potential options as well. Just as governments will sometimes hide their attempts to deplatform and censor in order to avoid blowback, digital platforms have now begun to use “shadowbanning”—the deamplification or hiding of an individual’s expressions in other users’ newsfeeds and notifications in order to deplatform, censor, or otherwise suppress speech while maintaining some plausible deniability.

Best Used Where:

- Similar to deceptive messaging, the damage caused by the target being allowed to continue expression over the respective communications channel far outweighs the damage caused by the inevitable blowback of their being removed and the reasons for its suppression would likely be accepted or well-understood later.
- Legal or pre-established communications channel-specific rule-sets clearly demand the deplatforming or censorship (e.g. not removing the individual’s expressions would be a violation of the rules or the law).

Beware:

- The Streisand Effect: Attempting to censor or suppress information often drives interest and reporting on that information.
- Unequal treatment, if an enforcement is made on the basis of application of the rules or the introduction of new rules—it is exceptionally important that these rules be applied fairly else it will axiomatically cause negative emotion and potentially drive radicalization of the group associated with the enforcement.
- Hitting Mold with a Hammer: Deplatforming and censorship reduce messaging and coordination over a particular communications channel, but it actually increases the resilience and volatility of the narrative which drove it, and in some cases even validates it or helps spread it. Further, it distributes this narrative and drives it underground, making it harder to observe and creating filter bubbles for those who hold that narrative. Carefully consider your objectives when applying this practice, as its impacts may be explicitly counterproductive to your goals, and carefully consider your methods of measuring impacts, as reduced influence of an individual and reduced speech on the platform of interest are not synonymous with reduced impact of the narrative they were communicating.
- Doing it deceptively: the same caveats of application of deceptive messaging apply here as well. If caught, and the reasons are not perceived to be noble, this can have devastating blowback that may be impossible to remedy, especially for organizations where there is an asymmetry of control over speech.

(3) Instituting or Lobbying for Public Law

Commonly used by: Governments, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Law Enforcement, Industry/Trade Associations

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect, Rules-Related

Summary and Considerations: Sovereign and other public body compulsion can be applied to compel behaviors of individuals that help to achieve overall population goals. Such compulsion is applied in various forms through rulemaking (legislative), operational (executive), and enforcement (judicial) functions that are the exclusive province of the sovereign with respect to its laws. Sovereigns don't need to ask for permission or forgiveness from anyone, and so can enforce rules to compel behaviors, such as vaccinations and other public health measures that the sovereign deems appropriate for its subjects. Most importantly, while governments and similar regulatory agencies aren't the only organizations which can pass rules, they are the only ones which do so outside of an opt-in basis—digital platforms can regulate the use of their systems, but users can easily leave if they don't find them appropriate. Leaving a nation-state is not impossible, but also not so simple. Of course, in democracies and other representative governance systems, the sovereign both represents and controls the population, making issues of “sovereignty” a bit more complex.

When misinformation or some other phenomenon infects a population in a manner that results in or contributes to their engaging in behaviors that threaten the stability of one or more critical infrastructure systems of a system upon which they all depend, then the governing authority of that system might exercise its general authority to compel certain behaviors of the stakeholders that are subject to the rules of that system. The vectors of compulsion of a nation state or other systemic “sovereign” are substantial by the very nature of their status in such system as the makers, enforcers and operators of binding rules.

Organizations with the ability to instantiate and enforce public law can do so to simply compel or suppress the expressions of a particular attitude, behavior, conclusion, or decision rather than conducting a traditional narrative campaign. However, public law can be used in the same way that affordances campaigns might use physical or digital affordances to purposefully impact narrative. One might argue that the severe penalties for possession of crack cocaine were an example of this—as the sentencing wasn't just intended to punish possession, it was intended to produce austere punishments for crack cocaine possession. These sentences were meant, explicitly, to scare potential offenders as a part of a national narrative campaign to reduce drug usage.

Some Notes:

Organizations which do not have the power to pass public law may lobby for it aggressively instead. Some organizations may have the ability to set regulation or criteria for licensure or accreditation that have similar impacts to public law.

For the purposes of this guide, the practice of passing public laws is considered separate from their enforcement—as laws can be passed and left unenforced or enforced leniently and interpretations of existing laws can be stretched or reconsidered in order to be applied to novel situations.

Best Used Where:

- Public support for state sovereign compulsion regarding the public issue at hand is sufficiently strong to not threaten the stability of other benefits gleaned from sovereign based systems.
- De-risking benefits depend on network effect and adoption to be effective (e.g. stop-lights only work if all stop-lights are the same and everyone has the same expectations about them).
- Public risks greatly outweigh individual private intrusions.
- Issue can be described with sufficiently broad appeal to survive political and legislative horse trading.
- Emergency or Crisis necessitates action.

Beware:

- Where the source of the behavior or expressions intended to be suppressed exists outside the jurisdiction of the law. For example, French law does not apply in the US and vice versa. The duties compelled by a law only apply within its boundaries. So, even successful lobbying for passage of a law to curb (mis)(dis) information in one country will do nothing to suppress that activity that originates in another country, but causes harm across borders. Technically there are processes that can enable cross-border applications of law—but typically only in special circumstances.
- Legal complexity and contradiction: There is a complexity that emerges from interactions between and among different jurisdictions, each with their own exclusive and shared patchworks of laws, regulations, and administrative rules as well as the contractual agreements of the parties that exist within those jurisdictions.
- Exercise of compulsion by legislative and governmental action can be perceived by burdened population as power overreach prompting backlash.
- Inability to carry out enforcement of public laws will weaken force of such laws (use sparingly).
- Tyranny of the Majority: Even if the majority might clearly consider the action warranted, be sure to consider how minority factions will perceive the action.

(4) Legal Action and Enforcements

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms, Governments, Companies, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Online Communities, Academic Organizations, Law Enforcement, Industry/Trade Associations

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect, Rules-Related

Summary and Considerations: Enforcement is part of governance systems based on public law and private (formal and informal contractual) duties. Enforcement is mentioned in other practices in the context of non-sovereign entities (e.g. digital platforms) and the creation of the basis for enforcement, but is covered separately here because in some cases, attempts at enforcement actions can be taken on behaviors not usually associated with a given rule-set (e.g. comparison of spreading vaccine misinformation to “yelling fire in a theatre”) or taken where enforcements are generally applied cautiously or not applied at all.

Lobbying for or applying enforcements given existing rulesets can be a valuable and impactful tool for a narrative campaign. In many cases, the behavior or expressions of the target audience may already be technically illegal or the campaign can introduce or amplify interpretations of existing rulesets under which those behaviors or expressions might be considered illegal. In some cases, just threatening to take action using existing rule sets or contractual agreements can be enough to suppress and prompt changes to behavior and expressions (e.g. threatening to sue on basis of defamation or libel, threatening to make arrests regarding some past incident), even if enforcement is ultimately unlikely.

As noted elsewhere, enforcements do not necessarily require the use of courts, they can instead be enforced through termination of affiliation, removal of digital affordances, the requirement of additional payments, or the revoked access to discounts or special privileges, but their enforcement can be disputed and defended in court. While these and other private law implementations see their enforcement ultimately being made reliable via courts (e.g. Condo associations writing their own bylaws), many enforcements do not require formal contracts. For example, online communities can set terms of use informally and remove digital affordances or forum membership freely.

Best Used Where:

- The rules being cited in the application of an enforcement are obvious in terms of their mapping to the infraction.

Beware:

- Every unsuccessful enforcement sets precedent and runs the risk of provoking more undesired activity.

- Unfair enforcement: if the institution carrying out the enforcement appears to have ulterior motives or is playing favorites when interpreting rule-sets, blowback is inevitable.

(5) Legislative and Regulatory Credentialing and Capture of Truth

Commonly used by: Governments

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect, Rules-Related

Summary and Considerations: Governments and regulators are in a unique position to be able to affect national narratives via legal means. One such method is to define licensing requirements for spread of information, or licensing requirements for the designation of titles associated with expertise. For example, in the United States, licenses are required to provide legal, financial, and medical advice in certain contexts and only certain institutions with appropriate licenses can offer degrees in subject matter. In addition, broadcasters are beholden to FCC regulations which encourage fair coverage of issues important to public discourse and there is recent consideration for the notion of “badging” or providing quasi-licensure for publication of journalistic or scientific content. Some governments go further, creating regulations and agencies which define the boundaries between truth and falsehood, or agencies which simply intervene and deplatform or censor when information is no longer beneficial to the state.

Best Used Where:

- Freedom of expression is not revered by populations of interest.
- The danger of allowing the market to operate freely outweighs the negative impacts of licensing regulations.

Beware:

- All government encroachment on free expression should be very carefully considered, as each step creates precedent and opportunity for abuse.
- Regulated licensures are sometimes necessary for the management of standards for safety and interoperability, but come at cost:
 - They create new barriers to entry.
 - They can prevent innovation.
- Government licensure sometimes gives the citizens they are meant to protect a false sense of security which leaves them more vulnerable than they were prior. Alternatives should always be considered prior to using regulatory and legislative approaches.

(6) Private Law and Terms of Use

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms, Companies, Online Communities, Academic Organizations, Industry/Trade Associations

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect, Rules-Related

Summary and Considerations: People and institutions use contracts to compel behavior. It is in this way, in combination with public laws, that individuals and organizations are able to render the future behaviors of other parties reliable and predictable, which in turn has the value of de-risking future interactions and leveraging current investment in interactions. The use of myriad forms of contracts can be imagined to help stabilize the efforts to achieve broad conformity to the required behaviors.

The expressions of our ideologies and narratives are impacted by utility and risk as much as they are by values and principles. For example, health insurance premiums dissuade individuals from smoking and conditional access to schools sway parents to vaccinate their children and employment contracts that cross-reference employment policies impact dress and personality. Enforcement mechanisms vary, and those applied in private and civil contexts (such as contractual disputes) differ from those applied in public and criminal contexts in terms of impact on narrative. In terms of narrative impact, a public law requiring sports venues to require proof of vaccination on entry is substantially different from sports venues deciding to implement a term of entry and a digital platform banning certain kinds of speech is substantially different than a Government doing so. This being said, many “private law” enforcements do not require the use of courts, they can instead be enforced through termination of employment, removal of digital affordances, the requirement of additional payments, or the revoked access to discounts, but their enforcement can be disputed and defended in court. While these and other private law implementations see their enforcement ultimately being made reliable via courts (e.g. Condo associations writing their own bylaws), many enforcements do not require formal contracts. For example, online communities can set terms of use informally and remove digital affordances or forum membership freely.

Best Used Where:

- Desire to avoid potential for harm outweighs desire for stakeholder autonomy.
- Rules would be deemed beneficial but would likely set dangerous precedent or encroach on constitutional rights and civil liberties if implemented in the form of public laws.

Beware:

- If there is a substantial population that is unlikely to conform:

- New organizations and communities may emerge to accommodate them.
- The resulting alienation may radicalize them.
- If coordination is obvious and seems to be politically-motivated, profit-motivated, deceptive, or otherwise driven by ulterior motives, blowback can be severe.

(7) Shadow-Banning and Deceptive Suppression

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms, Governments, Activist Groups, Online Communities

Tags: Centralized, Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect, Rules-Related, Affordances-Based

Summary and Considerations: Suppression of expression, especially in Western countries, rarely comes unaccompanied by concerns regarding freedom of speech. This, in combination with the fact that many organizations do not even have direct means of suppressing speech, has led to the emergence of a number of subtle methods of reducing the impact and spread of speech. In the case of digital platforms, in lieu of an outright ban, algorithms and moderation mechanisms can instead be tinkered with to reduce the likelihood of certain viewpoints or accounts from being shown to other users without affected users being alerted to any changes. This practice has been commonly referred to as “shadow-banning”. The accusation of its usage has been contentious for many years, at least two companies have admitted that it exists.

Twitter has admitted that shadowban-like phenomena exist, but suggested it is the result of unintended consequences of content monitoring algorithms. Most of the publicity regarding shadow-banning on Facebook and Twitter has been centered on conservative voices, but it is important to note that online communities on all sides of the political spectrum have suspected its use. Reddit on the other hand had an established “shadow-ban” system which allowed them to blacklist certain individuals without their being alerted. A shadow-banned user could still comment and post, but all content would be cataloged as spam and be invisible to other users until a moderator accepted the content. It was defended as a means of creating a sort of “honeypot” for spam-bots as alerting the bot to the ban would mean the creation of new accounts, but it was admittedly used on non-bot accounts. While Reddit has claimed this feature has been removed, many still suspect its usage under a different name.

Best Used Where:

- Blowback from suppression of speech would be likely.
- The speech being suppressed is likely from non-humans.

Beware:

- This is a deceptive practice, its suspected or detected use may cause irreparable reputation damages.

(8) Third-Party Fact-Checking

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Reactive, Direct, Rules-Related, Affordances-Based

Summary and Considerations: Third Party Fact-Checking is used on digital platforms in order to externalize the basis for moderation of what is believed to be non-factual or misleading content. This is a relatively new practice, used to avoid the potential blowback from a digital platform placing itself in the position of “arbiter of truth”. In order to avoid simply passing this role to another central authority, usually the platform will select a group of fact-checking organizations rather than just one. The fact-checking organizations’ rulings on specific claims are then connected via API to text analysis and moderation systems in order to remove content or offer warnings on content posted on the digital platform.

Best Used Where:

- The audience views the fact checker as authoritative and neutral.
- The audience views the fact checker as part of their in-group.
- The rulings are transparent and can be audited.

Beware:

- Unfair Treatment: If the fact-checking organizations are perceived to be playing favorites or applying unfair scrutiny on one narrative over another, blowback is inevitable.
- If fact-checking organizations aren’t perceived to be neutral, their warning themselves may be weaponized and parodied.
- Errors and Retractions: Every mistake is an opportunity for those who don’t agree with rulings to spread distrust in future rulings.
- If the fact checkers are perceived to be messengers of content or as benefiting from a particular interpretation of the information, then their rulings will not just be dismissed as non-neutral but will also cause reputation damages to fact-checking systems in general and increase hostility toward the information itself.

6.2.6. Affordances and Logistics

(1) Affordances Campaigns

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms, Governments, Companies

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect, Interactive, Affordances-Based

Summary and Considerations: In organizational psychology and behavioral systems engineering, it is standard practice to consider the impact on behavior by changes to external structures and the affordances offered by those structures. These affordances can be physical and as simple as handrail on a staircase or social and as complex as perceptions and reinforcements of sociocultural expectations. Narrative campaigns don't necessarily need messaging in order to affect narrative, they can instead use the deployment of affordances. As an example, we can consider the impacts of hostile-architecture, where benches and areas under bridges are designed to make it difficult for the homeless to loiter or sleep. Cities which would choose to address the impact or perception of problems of homelessness rather than homelessness itself, could choose to release messaging which is deceptive or misleading regarding the state of the city or they could use hostile-architecture, which simply changes the behavior of homeless people such that they no longer impact the narrative of other residents. In the digital sphere, as noted in the description of "shout-about" campaigns, digital platforms can offer affordances which change the messaging behavior of their users—these changes to messaging behavior change messages, and thus can be used to impact narrative. Creating or adapting templates, filters, and limits for messages, behavior and narrative will be impacted. By creating special filters, limits, and templates for certain kinds of messages, digital platforms can help amplify certain content and deamplify others.

Best Used Where:

- "Playing favorites" with particular points of view or types of information would be seen as reasonable (e.g. "I am safe" templates on social media during an emergency, filters in support of victims of a tragedy).
- Rules based approaches won't necessarily work.
- Current affordances are causing negative behavior.

Beware:

- Sociotechnical systems are complex, every choice made affects behavior in ways you might not expect. While behavior "A" can be changed to behavior "B" with simple

manipulations of affordances in some cases, there is no way to know what other behaviors may be affected.

(2) Logistics Campaigns

Commonly used by: Governments, Public Action Groups, Activist Groups, Academic Organizations, Law Enforcement

Tags: Distributed/Centralized, Anticipatory/Reactive, Indirect, Interactive, Affordances-Based

Summary and Considerations: Logistics campaigns focus on the “how” of messaging and deployment of equipment and materials, rather than the “why” of messaging. Sensemaking is done as a response to uncertainty about risk, reward, implications, and meaning of taking some action as much as it is a response to uncertainty about how to go about taking that action. In the field of user experience design (UX), there is an important maxim: “users should fall into success”, which is to say that users should have to exercise as little thought as possible in understanding how to use some affordance. Good UX is meant to make navigation toward desired outcomes effortless for users.

They can be used as stand-alone initiatives or as an important augment to existing campaigns that address the why. Logistics campaigns can be either grassroots, hyper-local and ground up, broad and top-down, or some hybrid, based on the situation. While many logistics campaigns are not directly connected to specific narrative campaign objectives, all have the potential to impact narratives.

Some Interesting Examples:

- Condom Availability Programs (CAP) in school nurses offices, designated classrooms or special vending machines.
- Pharmacy and community based flu vaccines, where flu shots can be given without an appointment, often at very low cost, with big signs at front door.
- Campaigns to dispense free sanitary pads in schools across the globe.
- Community based needle exchange programs (NEPs) to combat HIV, Hepatitis and other diseases.
- Mosquito net campaigns to prevent malaria infections.
- Disaster relief efforts to bring clean water, medicine, ice and food into disaster zones.
- Barbershop blood pressure monitoring programs.

Best Used Where:

- Problem is well understood by the target population, but performing the desired behavior or action is hampered by access and affordances.

- The barriers to the target audience moving toward the desired behavior or conclusion are practical, such as cost, knowledge of how to take an action, convenience, or practical psychological factors such as confidentiality concerns.
- There is both a well-defined and well-scoped target population accompanied by a clear understanding of logistical impediments and impact of potential deployments.

Beware:

- Eye-Candy: developing a campaign that on its surface looks good, but indicates a poor understanding of implications of deployment. For example:
 - Donations of clothing after hurricanes make people feel good about helping, but bog down actual relief workers who need to now manage a logistics stream that is not needed.
 - Placing condoms dispensers in public places where the students who need it will be too embarrassed to use them effectively.
- Putting the cart before the horse: in some cases, the target population needs to be well aware of the problem and the benefits of the solution before deploying logistics campaigns.
- Culture-clashes: Targeted populations should be served by people that look, think and act like them; white barbershops offering blood pressure monitoring aren't going to easily serve at-risk Black populations.
- Trojan horses: Logistics campaigns can be co-opted by outside actors who use the opportunity to establish a foothold in a given community. For long term success, there should be transparency, trust, and authenticity throughout.

6.2.7. Mixed Category

(1) Honeypotting and Watering Holes

Commonly used by: Governments, Activist Groups, Cybersecurity Firms, Law Enforcement

Tags: Centralized, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory, Direct/Indirect, Affordances-Based

Summary and Considerations: Honeypotting, traditionally, has been a very morally dubious practice. Originally the term referred to creating opportunities for sexual-blackmail in the domain of espionage and intelligence tradecraft. A honeypot might be an individual trained to seduce a target or a brothel used or exploited to create opportunities for blackmail. While coercive recruitment became less used over time, the notion of creating “watering holes” or “honeypots”, hubs which attract the attention of a target group in order to observe their behavior, was an effective strategy in a number of domains. Hackers use watering hole driven strategies to place exploits, and penetration testers use honeypots to attract hackers. These honeypots in penetration testing not only serve as a mechanism to trap hackers, but may also represent entire mock systems wherein they can observe their behavioral patterns and better construct a threat profile. These tactics can also be used in narrative campaigns. Communications hubs can be created that attract the attention of the sections of the target audience, once inside, communications and patterns of behavior can be highly observable, and engagements can be tailored to better understand impacts of messaging on the larger target audience. Further, in the case that the target audience may potentially be considering coordination of dangerous or undesired behavior, these hubs could then be easily disrupted during key points of coordination.

Best Used Where:

- The target audience’s communications and content distribution are difficult to observe.
- The target audience’s needs and interests are well enough understood to enable the generation of a viable hub.

Beware:

- This practice, even when used for noble intent, could easily be seen as nefarious or morally questionable—discovery then would greatly impact the success of future messaging and will pressure the target audience to become skittish.

(2) Shout-About Campaigns

Commonly used by: Digital Platforms, Governments, Advertisers, Companies

Tags: Distributed, Aggressive/Defensive, Anticipatory/Reactive, Direct/Indirect, Interactive, Affordances-Based

Summary and Considerations: The creation of a scripted expression or format for expressions for individuals to repeat and share to indicate that they are for or against something or performing some action. They are sometimes affordances-based campaigns, as is the case with Social Media filters which codify a format for the user, while others may simply rely on messaging alone to reinforce format, such is the case with individuals taking selfies with their vaccine card. It is very important to consider the nature of your target audience, if they do not value civic engagement or see the group of individuals most likely to “shout-about” their engagement with the campaign as a hostile out-group, a shout-about campaign will be counterproductive. The provision of affordances and targeting of messaging can be direct or indirect, for example, in the U.K., some campaigns have focused on providing affordances to “shout-about” engagements to public health experts and civil servants rather than politicians, because target audiences may have lower levels of trust in politicians—thus, targeting the provision of affordances to a group outside the target audience which the target audience did not have hostility toward was impactful whereas simply providing the affordances to everyone or to the target audience would have been less effective or counterproductive.

Best Used Where:

- There is a strong need or desire to make the campaign’s impacts observable through computational techniques.
- There is a desire for easy on-ramps for civic engagement.
- Groups that are likely to engage and participate aren’t considered to be hostile out-groups by the target audience.

Beware:

- Can help catalyze or crystallize tribalism by making clear identifications of in- and out-groups.
- Individuals participating in a coordinated campaign may simply become an accelerant for individuals who believe that the out-group participating in it are “sheep” and may entrench further in response.
- Could prompt an adversarial campaign which either copies tactics or parodies methods.

7. Case Studies

Here, a diverse set of case studies which are relevant to the planning and implementation of narrative campaigns is provided. While some case studies focus specifically on successes, failures, and examples of implementations of actual narrative campaigns, events unattached to narrative campaigns have also been included.

(1) Go Viral and Bad News

Practices used: Gamification/Serious Games, Training and Education Initiatives, Coordinated Cross-Promotion, Prebunking

The University of Cambridge developed a tool with collaboration between the Social Decision-Making Lab at the University of Cambridge, GUSMANSON Design, DROG media agency, and the UK Cabinet Office called “Go Viral”. The game educates the public at large about the dangers of vaccine disinformation and misinformation, which is an immersive experience that shows how it can be verified and dispelled.

The game’s design was based on “Bad News”, which takes players through multiple choice options, with a barometer, relating to how ‘trusted’ a source that person becomes along with how many followers they accrue. “Research has shown that Bad News significantly improves players’ ability to resist misinformation techniques after gameplay, and increase players’ confidence in spotting misleading information”, increasing ability by up to 21%.ⁱ Moreover, this effect itself can last for monthsⁱⁱ with regular “top-ups” or “booster shots” following gameplay.ⁱⁱⁱ

Where “Bad News” was more general, Go Viral was focused on COVID-19—“Players are tasked with inventing and spreading a fake conspiracy theory about COVID-19, and learn about the negative consequences of their actions in the form of replies by social media users in their network, thus exposing how misinformation is created, spread and shared.”

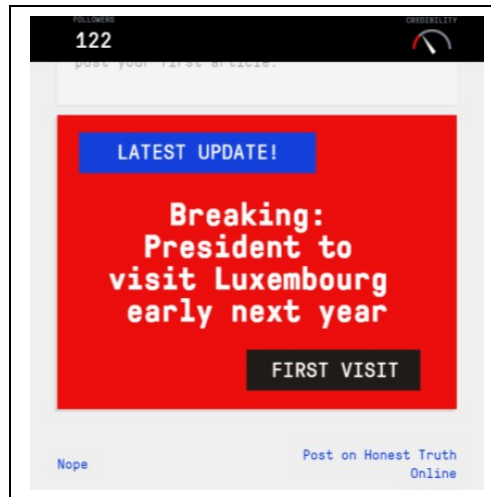


Figure 8. “Bad News” Social Media Simulation.

The game was disseminated through cross-promotion by the BBC, Public Health England, WHO, and the UN. Its link to Bad News allowed it to tap a large international audience to both play and disseminate the game. While the game's impact on individuals which were already affected by propaganda or misinformation was likely minimal, it is a case where audiences that were not yet affected were armed with an inhibitor against future adversarial campaigns. In this sense the game acts as a sort of vaccine against misinformation about actual vaccines, by exposing players to techniques and methods used by bad-faith actors on social media.

(2) MenAfriVac Rollout: A Successful Vaccine Rollout

Practices used: Coordinated Cross-Promotion, Logistics Campaign, Civic Framing, Conversation Initiatives, Really Big Show Scheduling

In 1996 through 1997, the largest meningitis epidemic in African history swept across sub-Saharan Africa, numbering 250,000 new cases, taking 25,000 lives, and leaving another 50,000 with disabilities and a new title for this area of the world: “The Meningitis Belt”. The path to a vaccine would be slow but steady—enabled by a long-term global collaboration between governments, companies, and nonprofits alike. This collaboration began with the World Health Organization (WHO) holding a summit in Cairo, Egypt in 2000, with African ministers of health and global health leaders to discuss meningitis and development of a new vaccine. By 2001, the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation provided a ten-year, 70-million-dollar grant to establish the Meningitis Vaccine Project, a partnership between PATH (a Seattle-based public health NGO) and World Health Organization (WHO) and global collaboration was achieved to establish meningitis surveillance activities in 12 countries. By 2010, a MenAfriVac vaccine was approved and introduced at the cost of \$0.40 per dose, and was created specifically with an African rollout in mind—allowing it to go up to 4 days without refrigeration.

Sub-Saharan Africa is a place renowned for its population’s fear of Western medicine—having been an initial vector of attack for Russian disinformation rumors about U.S. involvement in the creation of HIV/AIDs, among other reasons. The level of distrust in Western medicine may have been as bad or worse than the current status of certain demographics within the United States in reference to COVID-19 interventions. However, by prioritizing actual access to the vaccine, performing highly coordinated cross-promotion of the vaccine en masse by trusted local messengers, and the using of Human Terrain Specialists, the campaign managed to vaccinate over 315 million people across 23 countries over the course of 8 years. This number over this timespan may be misleading however—by December 2011, over 55 million people had received a vaccination in the first 6 countries to perform a roll out and the rollout in Nigeria vaccinated over 15 million people in just 10 days (93% of their target). Each country had a national planning committee which had a chair responsible for all aspects of the roll out, and Nigeria’s was planned for 8 months in advance of its 10-day roll out. It is extremely important to note, that these rollout campaigns never made any notable attempt to counter-message, they focused instead on making access simple and coordinating cross-promotion and incentives for involvement.

In addition, by responding rapidly to potential accelerants for vaccine hesitance or objection, with non-judgmental validation and serious concern, such as the deployment of independent experts after a mass vaccination event in Chad left 36 children with unusual symptoms, potential negative impacts to follow-up events were avoided.

(3) Unexpected Consequences and Misreading of Data Extractions of COVID-19 Rollout

Practices used: Private Law and Terms of Use, Logistics Campaign

Numerous national news stories and editorials were written in early February 2021 highlighting how early vaccination data showed a woeful underrepresentation of racial and ethnic minorities in the vaccination pool. Without exception, the stories and experts would point to “hesitancy” and lack of trust in the vaccine by BIPOC and a vaccine registration system that was biased against these same communities as the primary reasons that BIPOC were not showing up. Federal officials acknowledged that trust was a problem and promised to do more to improve outreach and lower barriers to sign up.

Ironically, in an effort to highlight and combat bias, the media and public health officials were both falling prey to and contributing to a harmful (if well-intentioned) misinformed narrative around vaccine uptake. Because early vaccination rates for BIPOC were 20-30% below expected rates when compared to overall population, these numbers conformed with what experts expected based on well-documented mistrust going back to the infamous Tuskegee experiment and more recent polling from during the Trump Administration that indicated higher “vaccine hesitancy” in BIPOC. Thus, a common and remarkably unanimous narrative began to develop in the media—reinforced by local and national public health experts and political leaders—that BIPOC were not getting vaccinated because they still did not trust the COVID vaccine and because the system was making it much harder for them to get it. But that is not what the data being cited actually showed. Quite to the contrary, when vaccination rates were compared to eligible populations, BIPOC were being vaccinated near to or generally above their share of the population in all reporting states.

The problem was that the age-based criteria for inclusion in earlier vaccine eligibility cohorts skewed dramatically White. Only 60% of the US Population is White/non-Hispanic, but 76% of those eligible for the first 100MM doses under CDC’s age-based guidance are White.

Although there are unquestionably systemic barriers that made it easier for higher income, White Americans with better access to technology and flexibility in schedules to schedule vaccines, early data indicated that BIPOC were largely managing to overcome those barriers. And as polling from February began to be published, it became clear that BIPOC’s attitudes around vaccine trust had dramatically shifted from the fall of 2020 to align with white attitudes and exceed Republican voter trust.

Yet those communities were repeatedly told that others like them did not trust the vaccines and that the system was failing them by preventing people like them from being able to get the vaccine. It is noteworthy, that this is precisely the narrative that was being pushed by foreign and domestic actors in disinformation spaces targeting these same communities. Even though the motivations of public health and advocacy

groups were the opposite, the narrative they created was exactly what a suppression campaign would look like.

(4) Americans Follow the Flag, Not the Man

Practices used: Adjacent Messaging, Threshold and Moments Targeting, Civic Framing

During the 2020 Georgia Senate run-off, over 2 million Georgia voters were identified as actively consuming propaganda content about election fraud and QAnon conspiracies. PublicDemocracy.io, a public benefit corporation which uses advertising data to manage civic, service, political, advocacy, and community building initiatives generated a very effective digital nudge campaign to counter this misinformation that targeted “Stop the Steal” stories and QAnon keywords and video content. Two of their video-content ads performed especially well. The best performing banner ad showed an image of an American soldier saluting the flag with the simple text: “Americans Follow the Flag, Not the Man.” A perfect example of adjacent messaging—there was no call to action on the ad, just an image and some text, and yet it had a click through rate of over 1% (10x what would be considered a “successful” click rate on most digital campaigns engaging affinity or top customer audiences) during its first week of exposures with tens of thousands of Georgia voters leaving election fraud and conspiracy content to explore this alternative message.

The follow-on video ad used scenes of sports teams coming together to pray and shake hands after a game. The ad concluded with “Americans know how to come together after a hard-fought contest. That’s what we do and what makes us special”. This video ad, which ran largely in pre-roll before Stop the Steal and conspiracy video content, performed even better with millions of views and a remarkable 70% completion rate (5-15% completion rates on video are considered successful).

Competitor analyses of these ads showed that the only other ads being targeted directly to these audiences were from sources seeking to stoke or profit from these conspiracies in traditional digital marketing. It was also noteworthy that general audience affinity analysis of those who viewed the ads indicated that they were 48x more likely than the average news reader to consume Russian news content.

(5) WHO Caused Destabilization of Institutional Trust

Practices used: Deceptive Messaging, Propaganda, Adjacent Messaging, Coordinated Cross-Promotion

Over the course of the COVID-19 pandemic, the World Health Organization (WHO) made a series of potentially good-faith decisions that caused very serious blowback and a general destabilization in institutional trust, each of which should be considered in order to better evaluate choices in methodology. The three cases offered below were the most notable.

First, was a decision to give lofty, and public praise of China's Government for their "immediate" release of coronavirus information, the comprehensiveness and rapid delivery of this material was deemed "very impressive, and beyond words." However, it was later leaked that not only was the material released not comprehensive, but that it was likely purposefully limited and delayed in its delivery. WHO officials were reported by the Associated Press as saying that they were working on very minimal, purposefully delayed information and that WHO staff were very frustrated with China's behavior. The disparity between the information and public statements led many Americans to believe that WHO was compromised by the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). This view was echoed by then US President Donald Trump and thus amplified to the entire Western world. The organization which is usually tasked with declaring pandemics and health alerts lost credibility at the same moment that that credibility was essential to global stability. In addition, because of the subject of the deceptive messaging, the CCP's withholding of COVID-19 information, the CCP's repeat offenses in this regard have continued to reinforce the memory of the deception. As of February 2021, the CCP continues to withhold information—including the information that WHO claimed they had already provided.

Second, was poor messaging coherence and consistency regarding the wearing of masks. WHO and WHO collaborators deployed and participated in a number of messages and interviews during the period between January and April 2020 which included comments regarding masks being ineffective and unimpactful on reducing spread of COVID-19. While many of these messages and interviews included some reference to reducing mask use in order to prevent unnecessary strain on access to personal protective equipment (PPE) by health care workers or, in some cases, more direct references to the necessary nuance to understand that the claims regarding mask-effectiveness were being made relative to the risk of front-line healthcare workers not having access—the soundbites echoed by media made it fairly clear to the average listener that masks were simply ineffective. When WHO, WHO collaborators, and adjacent agencies walked back this claim of masks being ineffective and argued that they were now necessary, the response which referenced the previously poorly connected reasoning of relative-impact regarding the need for PPE for healthcare workers caused many to believe that WHO had simply lied about efficacy of masks. Once the view that WHO lied had crystalized, now new interpretations began to emerge

—including more “noble” interpretations, such as the notion that they had lied to prevent shortages as well as more nefarious interpretations linked to previous concerns. In many cases, this claim was not unreasonable, given that many statements made before and after the walk-back were clearly paradoxical if interpreted without full messages or context and would require careful reading to clarify or interpret as consistent.

Finally, WHO, between June and December 2020, either by accident or as part of a narrative campaign, changed the definition of Herd Immunity. In 2020, WHO’s definition of Herd Immunity, offered on their site, read:

Herd immunity is the indirect protection from an infectious disease that happens when a population is immune either through vaccination or immunity developed through previous infection. This means that even people who haven’t been infected, or in whom an infection hasn’t triggered an immune response, they are protected because people around them who are immune can act as buffers between them and an infected person. The threshold for establishing herd immunity for COVID-19 is not yet clear.

This definition was consistent with all common scientific definitions of the term. However, in November, the definition was changed to:

‘Herd immunity’, also known as ‘population immunity’, is a concept used for vaccination, in which a population can be protected from a certain virus if a threshold of vaccination is reached.

This change not only provided validation for the perception that WHO was a politically-driven organization rather than a scientifically driven one to groups that were already hostile to WHO, but also provided an onramp to these views in areas of the scientific community—which saw this redefinition as intellectually irresponsible. Discussion on Twitter about this change created a surface of agreement between scientists and conspiracy theorists. WHO eventually walked back this definition in December, adding necessary nuance:

‘Herd immunity’, also known as ‘population immunity’, is the indirect protection from an infectious disease that happens when a population is immune either through vaccination or immunity developed through previous infection. WHO supports achieving ‘herd immunity’ through vaccination, not by allowing a disease to spread through any segment of the population, as this would result in unnecessary cases and deaths.

Herd immunity against COVID-19 should be achieved by protecting people through vaccination, not by exposing them to the pathogen that

causes the disease. Read the Director-General's 12 October media briefing speech for more detail.

The decisions made by WHO caused damages to institutional trust that will be very difficult to remedy. Further, all adjacent agencies and news organizations involved in cross promotion have also seen impacts to public trust in their brands and messaging.

(6) Water Fluoridation

Practices used: Canceling, Coordinated Cross-Promotion, Shill and Establishing Guilt by Association, Propaganda, Amplification, Deceptive Suppression, and Deceptive Messaging

In the 1940s and 1950s, there were a number of organizations highly incentivized to fluoridate water. The Military had recently seen the impact of poor dental health on military readiness—almost 10% of recruits in 1941 were rejected on this basis alone. The U.S. Public Health Service was seeing a growing problem in dental issues and a shortage of dentists, the professional organizations associated with dentistry were looking for opportunities to increase their prestige, and some might say the American aluminum industry had incentives as well.^{iv} The perceived merits of fluoridation and the potential for perverse incentives present in the 1950s will not be discussed at length here, as the debate and available research at the time warrants its own study. What is relevant to this document is the handling of the debate at the time by the groups mentioned above and modern critiques and the perceptions of some developments in terms of research on fluoride since that time.

The debate at the time saw cross-promotion of direct, aggressive messaging that was sometimes emergent and sometimes coordinated by the groups noted above, potentially in good-faith with legitimate interest in improving dental health, and intended to ensure fluoridation of the water. The proponents of fluoridation repeatedly stated that the scientific community was unanimous in its approval of fluoridation, which was patently false and engaged in aggressive counter-messaging against those who had doubts. These strategies created a highly polarized, hostile debate which devolved the quality of discourse and incentivized scientists to remove themselves from it. Many experts who initially had hesitations about the merits of fluoridation exited or refused to be involved in the debate which left it dominated by what could be described as “crusaders”.

While this set of strategies worked in combating initial legal battles and potential public concerns and creating what the Center for Disease Control has called, “one of the 10 great public health achievements of the 20th century”, in the long term it has had some notable negative echoes. Public concern about fluoridation hasn’t gone away, and serves as a common on-ramp to conspiracy theories. This is exacerbated by the fact that many agencies haven’t changed their messaging on fluoride, with one government website (in.gov) actually claiming that there is “no need for any new research”. Their position is that a debate about the merits of fluoridation would be equivalent to a debate about the validity of science. They are effectively undermining any legitimate potential value of studies on the negative impact of fluoride by associating them with those published in pseudoscientific journals. Deceptive and aggressive messaging of this nature, when studies in reputable journals are still considering links between fluoride and ADHD, lower intelligence scores, neurological and skeletal issues, and fertility, hardens anti-fluoride positions and worse—damages institutional trust. It also damages trust in the

academic community, as this kind of messaging uses the reputation of scientists to platform anti-scientific approaches to dismissing concerns.

This impact is exacerbated by the fact that meta-analyses done on the studies on which this kind of certainty is defended, have indicated that some of the evidence in favor of fluoride is offered by studies that were poorly done: they either had sample sizes that were too low, or worse, were biased; most were at a “high risk of bias”. Those few rigorous studies that did show a positive relationship between CWF and teeth health were all done before 1975, and may not be applicable now given the generally improved health of people today, and increased habits such as brushing teeth with fluoridated toothpaste.

Echoes of damages to institutional and academic trust caused by the past handling of concerns regarding water fluoridation can be seen in discussions today about concerns regarding 5G telecommunications technology and COVID-19.

(7) Anti-Smoking Campaigns (US)

Practices used: n/a (This is a broad category of campaigns run over decades, and as such, include too many practices to be worth listing)

In the 1940s and 50s, nearly half of Americans were considered smokers, despite the presence of multiple studies linking the habit to lung cancer. In 1961, Presidents of the American Cancer Society and National Tuberculosis Association (later the American Lung Association) and others, issued a letter urging President Kennedy to create a commission that would investigate the health hazards of smoking—a collaboration which would lead to the emergence of a semi-coordinated, intergenerational anti-smoking narrative campaign which would include everything from legal and commercial compulsions and enforcements to the development of community-action groups and a myriad of cross-promoted messaging campaigns.

In 1964, we see a direct, centralized counter-message from the Surgeon General, stating the definitive link between smoking and chronic and terminal illness. After this, in 1965, the strategy shifted to managing an adversarial campaign against the Tobacco Industry's own narrative campaign (mass, coordinated advertising) instead of focusing on messaging. First, a series of enforcements are issued by congress, requiring the Tobacco Industry to provide health warnings on its products and to limit its advertising. This was largely ineffective in reducing the smoking rate however, and in 1968, the focus is returned to counter-messaging, but does so in a distributed fashion by using the "Fairness Doctrine", originally created to require companies holding broadcast licenses to cover controversial issues fairly, as a basis to allow the FCC to require broadcast companies to offset the impacts of Tobacco advertising by offering free-time to anti-smoking messaging. This was fought in the U.S. Court of Appeals, but the requirement was deemed to be in good standing. This use of the Fairness Doctrine created many millions of dollars worth of free counter-messaging opportunities for anti-smoking campaigns, and while this is often lauded as a great success, the impact on smoking rates nationally were small relative to what would be necessary to impact a habit so deeply ingrained in American culture and was no larger than the impact of the first raising of cancer concerns in the 1950s which was followed by a rebound and an increase in smokers per capita. After the impact of the Fairness Doctrine-enabled counter-messaging campaigns, there was a similar rebound. The response to this rebound was an outright ban on cigarette advertisements for stations broadcasting on FCC-regulated airwaves in 1971.

What happened next was likely emergent, only being embraced by the semi-coordinated coalition of organizations noted earlier after notable success and impact: the birth of the Nonsmokers' Rights Movement. Instead of counter-messaging about the impact of smoking on the health of the smoker, the Nonsmokers Rights movement focused on messaging about the impact of smoking on the health of nonsmokers, those who are affected by second-hand smoke. After 4 years of stagnancy in smokers per capita, the Maryland Group Against Smokers' Pollution (GASP) was formed in 1975. Over the

course of the next 10 years, dozens of small chapters and other, similar grassroots organizations emerge across the United States demanding local, state, and federal ordinances and laws for the regulation of smoking in order to protect non-smokers. The impacts of this movement resulted in numerous new, and now more justifiable enforcements on smoking, emergent cross-promotion of anti-smoking messages, and the creation of numerous taxes and legal compulsions to disincentivize smoking in addition to age requirements on purchases to prevent the start of the habit in formative years. Given their distributed nature, a variety of approaches were taken, such as targeting children and parents with anti-smoking messages as well as making deceptive, misleading, or emotional claims and making non-health claims intended to stigmatize the habit such as those related to odor and addictive tendencies.

In addition to the continuing of all of these strategies noted above, logistics and affordances campaigns became commonplace—with the offering of over-the-counter nicotine medications and distribution of brochures and literature which focus on how to quit rather than on why to quit.

According to statistics currently offered by the CDC, the combination of these strategies brought the initial, post-World War II, rate of smoking in the United States from 45% down to 14% in 2019 though estimates vary. The inclusion of severe countermeasures that had been taken post-2008 in order to further reduce this rate may have caused difficulty in assessing the number of smokers given that insurance companies, under the Affordable Care Act, had been allowed to charge tobacco-users up to 50% more for health insurance than non-tobacco users and because lying about tobacco use to your insurance provider (which would be uncovered by reporting tobacco use) can be considered insurance fraud—there are very serious ramifications for honesty about smoking.



Further Reading and Source Material

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Contact and Collaborate

The development of theory and research regarding the deployment of Narrative Campaigns sits at the intersection of many fields and existing methodologies. It is our hope that the second edition of this work will include many more submissions and revisions of the tools, frameworks, and practices from a larger set of contributors with more global representation and different levels of involvement.

If there is any interest in contacting the team:

- to provide comment and feedback
- to alert us to errors
- to ask questions or request information
- or to get involved with the work:
 - of contributing to a second edition
 - of translating the first edition

please use the following form: <https://forms.gle/a5ZLc919uDMnmoAy6>

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^{iv} The topic of corporate incentives in water fluoridation is highly contentious.

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